

The Business of the Culture War*

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Abstract

We link the contemporary American “culture war” to the entry of 24-hour cable news networks, which we find emphasize cultural issues more than the broadcast networks preceding them and far more than political candidates. Estimating viewer preferences using household-by-second data, we show cable news faces a tradeoff: cultural content attracts non-news entertainment viewers while economic content attracts viewers of rival news outlets. Broadcast news and politicians similarly trade off the cultural content that appeals to the politically disengaged against the economic content that appeals to the politically engaged, but we show why cable has the strongest incentives to emphasize culture. In turn, constituencies quasi-randomly more exposed to cable news networks assign greater importance to cultural issues, and politicians run more cultural campaigns.

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1 Introduction

A long history of popular commentary argues that news producers' incentive to capture viewers' attention biases their coverage, focusing public attention on the most entertaining or sensational issues rather than the most important (Sinclair, 1919; Postman, 1985). Over the past four decades, competition for attention has intensified. The rise of cable television in the 1980s and 1990s challenged the dominance of the "Big Three" broadcast outlets, dramatically expanding viewer choice and enabling the entry of 24-hour cable news networks (Hamilton, 2004). Whereas the broadcasters aired only 30 minutes of news each night and did so largely to appease the regulators controlling their access to the public airwaves, the success of these 24-hour cable news networks depended on making the news entertaining enough to directly turn a profit, even amid an enormous variety of new entertainment options competing for viewers' attention.¹

These same four decades have also seen a shift in political attention. Cleavages between Republican and Democratic voters on issues such as redistribution, social insurance, and labor have largely been eclipsed by cleavages over racial and gender issues, political correctness, immigration, religion, guns, and crime (Marble, 2024; Gennaioli and Tabellini, 2025). The causes of this "culture war" are the subject of a rich but inconclusive literature, which has often focused on secular economic trends or on changes in parties' platforms or campaign strategies (Enke et al., 2025; Kuziemko et al., 2026; Longuet-Marx, 2026).

We present two novel facts tying the culture war to changes in the market for viewers' attention. First, classifying the content of television news since 1968 and politicians' campaign advertisements since 1960, we show in Figure 1 that cable news, broadcast news, and politicians emphasize very different topics. Since the entry of Fox News and MSNBC in 1996, cable news coverage has focused substantially more on culture-war issues than on economic issues. Politicians' campaign advertising, in contrast, overwhelmingly emphasizes economic issues such as healthcare, taxes, jobs, and social insurance, while the older broadcast outlets also emphasize economic issues more and culture-war topics less than cable. Second, since 1996, the issues disproportionately emphasized in cable news have seen the largest growth in the extent to which they divide Democratic and Republican voters and in the number of people naming them the "most important problem" facing the country, and these issues have also grown to constitute a larger share of politicians' campaign advertising than in any prior year since 1960.

This paper examines why cable news outlets disproportionately emphasize cultural issues, and whether this emphasis can help explain these cultural issues' increased political salience. We trace cable's cultural focus to a distinctive business strategy: cable uses cultural coverage to attract viewers who would not otherwise watch news at all, thereby positioning itself as a closer competitor to entertainment television than to traditional news. We show why the same strategy is structurally disadvantaged for broadcast news, and why the analogous strategy for politicians — centering cultural topics in political campaigns in order to turn out people who would otherwise not vote — is likewise disadvantaged, explaining why the entry of 24-hour cable news networks Fox News and MSNBC generated a sharp increase in the political supply of cultural content. Finally, we show that these networks increased voters' attention to, and politicians' campaign emphasis on, cultural issues.

¹ Because broadcast outlets (unlike cable outlets) use public airwaves, the Federal Communications Commission requires them to "use the broadcast medium to serve the public interest." The threat of regulatory enforcement was an important driver of broadcaster investment in news programming prior to deregulation in the 1980s and 1990s (Napoli, 2001; Lotz, 2014; Brownell, 2023). "The Big Three broadcast television networks — ABC, CBS and NBC — all covered news, but none generally made money doing so. . . They presented news programming for the prestige it would bring to their network, to satisfy the public-service requirements of Congress and the Federal Communications Commission, and more broadly so that they would be seen as good corporate citizens" (Gunther, 1999).

The analysis is built on recordings of nearly all content aired on the six major cable and broadcast news networks since 2015, transcripts and abstracts from these networks since 1968, and videos or storyboards of nearly all campaign television ads aired by congressional and gubernatorial candidates since 2000 (and, for presidential candidates, since 1960). We classify each news segment and each political ad using a common schema of over 200 hierarchical topics. We present results both using high-level “economic,” “cultural,” and “other” aggregates of these topics, as in Figure 1, and at the level of each individual topic.

After establishing that cable news emphasizes cultural issues more than broadcast news and far more than politicians, we next show that cultural content increases cable viewership. The analysis exploits a household-by-second viewership panel sourced from a media analytics company, enabling us to track individual televisions as they switch between channels and to link this behavior to the second-by-second content of these channels. We estimate event studies relating households’ tune-in and tune-out behavior to high-frequency content variation, approximating the experiment of randomly assigning households to different types of content. We find that cultural topics outperform economic topics on cable news: switching from entirely economic to entirely cultural political content increases viewership by 2.8%, approximately one-fifth of the magnitude of the viewership drop caused by commercial advertising.

The key empirical pattern motivating our subsequent analysis is that this cultural viewership premium is the sum of two opposite-signed flows. When cable news outlets air culture rather than economics, they decrease the flow of households switching away to non-news entertainment channels or turning off the television: culture is better than economics for “mobilizing” people who would otherwise disengage from news. Yet airing culture rather than economics also *increases* the flow of households switching to competing news outlets: culture is worse than economics for “poaching” people who are engaged with news and would otherwise choose a rival outlet. Culture therefore increases total viewership because the positive mobilization effect on the viewers who would otherwise choose entertainment outweighs the negative poaching effect on the pool who would otherwise watch competing news outlets.

This heterogeneity motivates a model of the parallel tradeoff facing cable news, broadcast news, and politicians, which we use to analyze why these three agents choose different content. *Poaching* content attracts engaged consumers who would otherwise choose a competitor — a rival news outlet or a rival politician — while *mobilizing* content attracts disengaged consumers who would otherwise choose the outside option of not watching news or not voting. We show why cable has uniquely strong incentives to emphasize mobilizing rather than poaching content, rationalizing its cultural emphasis relative to broadcast news and politicians.

Relative to broadcast news, cable news outlets’ stronger incentives to emphasize culture stem in part from the composition of their potential viewers. Cable airs 24 hours of news a day, while broadcast outlets air national news in a narrow set of timeslots. Cable therefore competes relatively more against entertainment programming for viewers’ attention, giving it stronger incentives to air the cultural content that appeals to viewers who would otherwise watch entertainment. Indeed, both cable’s cultural viewership premium and cable’s greater emphasis on culture are strongest at times in which broadcast news typically does *not* air: that is, the times when cable outlets’ marginal viewers are most likely non-news entertainment viewers rather than viewers of competing news outlets. Further supporting the interpretation that cable news competes more directly with entertainment than traditional broadcast news, we use historical consumer survey data to show that upon their founding, Fox News and MSNBC drew relatively more from the demographic groups that were watching *entertainment* programming than traditional broadcast news.

Relative to politicians, cable news outlets’ stronger incentives to emphasize culture stem in part from their greater relative payoff from each mobilized consumer. To a first approximation, a cable outlet maximizes

its audience *size* and therefore equally values a viewer poached from a competing news channel and a viewer mobilized from entertainment programming. In contrast, a politician maximizes her vote *margin* and therefore values each voter poached from an opponent twice as much as each voter mobilized from not voting, since a poached voter increases her number of voters *and* decreases her opponent's.² If, like on TV, economic content better poaches voters from rival politicians and cultural content better mobilizes nonvoters, this difference in objectives gives politicians stronger incentives to emphasize economics and weaker incentives to emphasize culture, relative to cable news. While our empirical analysis for politicians is much more suggestive, we find that in this domain, too, economics indeed appears better for poaching and culture better for mobilizing. Consistent with the greater value of poaching in politics, we also find that candidates running more cultural campaigns are less likely to win than candidates running more economic campaigns.

Of course, a wide range of other differences between cable and broadcast news, and between cable news and political campaigns, may also drive differences in content choice. To quantify the importance of the “poaching” vs. “mobilization” mechanisms above, we estimate a structural model of household viewing and network content choice, enabling us to simulate how cable content would differ if cable outlets faced the composition of potential viewers watching during broadcast outlets’ evening newscasts or the margin-maximizing objective of politicians. We calculate that differences in potential viewer composition can account for 62 percent of the cable–broadcast difference in content, and differences in size- vs. margin-maximizing objectives can explain 27 percent of the cable–politician difference.

Having shown evidence that cable news’ cultural focus reflects a business strategy focused on mobilization of the politically disengaged, and that the analogous strategy would be disadvantaged for both broadcast outlets and politicians, we examine the *consequences* of cable’s distinct incentives for politics. We identify the effects of cable news following Martin and Yurukoglu (2017), who show that media markets in which a cable news network was quasi-randomly assigned a lower channel number exhibit greater viewership of that network. We find that individuals in constituencies more exposed to cable news are more likely to name a cultural issue and less likely to name an economic issue as the “most important problem facing the country” in long-running Gallup surveys: a one-standard-deviation increase in cable news viewership raises the stated importance of cultural relative to economic issues by 0.059 standard deviations. Politicians in these constituencies also respond: a one-standard-deviation increase in a constituency’s cable news exposure increases the cultural emphasis of political ads by 0.44 standard deviations. While we cannot precisely disentangle the effects of cultural cable news content *per se* from the other mechanisms through which cable might affect political outcomes, we show that the effects do not simply reflect the well-established effects of Fox News and MSNBC on partisanship.

This paper is limited in several respects beyond those highlighted above. Most importantly, the analyses exploit marginal variation around the current political equilibrium, treating viewers’ preferences over news topics and these topics’ effectiveness for mobilization and poaching as given. The topic-level estimates may not extend to other settings or institutional structures, even if the conceptual distinction between the incentives of “margin-maximizing” politicians and “size-maximizing” actors is quite general.

²Outlets may weigh some viewers more than others or maximize subscription revenue in addition to advertising revenue, and politicians may also care about their own or their party’s preferences. The model generalizes to such cases of “impure” margin- or size-maximization, so long as politicians have greater relative incentives to poach than outlets.

A vast literature examines news outlets’ choice of ideological slant and its determinants.³ This paper instead examines how the unique incentives facing cable news shape the *issues* it emphasizes, measuring these incentives directly from high-frequency viewing behavior and following a tradition linking media content choice to the composition of an outlet’s marginal consumers (George and Waldfogel, 2003; Anderson and Coate, 2005; Durante and Knight, 2012). Conceptually, we build most directly on Prior (2007), who links increased viewer choice to a divergence in political participation, and on Angelucci et al. (2024), who show that the entry of television reshaped newspapers’ content and consumers’ news diets. Our key contribution is to link cable news outlets’ distinctive incentives to the “agenda-setting” role of news (McCombs and Shaw, 1972; Iyengar and Kinder, 1987) across the spectrum of political topics, and to trace their downstream effects.⁴

In establishing the parallel poaching vs. mobilization tradeoff facing cable news, broadcast news, and politicians, we tie together the literatures on media positioning and on politician positioning (e.g., Glaeser et al. 2005; Callander and Carbajal 2022; Di Tella et al. 2025), which have largely proceeded independently. The data we compile represent the richest and most long-running account to date of how politicians position themselves on the campaign trail and of what cable and broadcast news outlets cover, enabling us to place these agents in a common content space and analyze differences between them through the lens of their different incentives.⁵

Finally, we relate to a literature on the causes and consequences of the observed political realignment by which voting patterns increasingly reflect cultural rather than economic cleavages (Krasa and Polborn, 2014; Bonomi et al., 2021; Gennaioli and Tabellini, 2025). An open question is whether these changes, and polarization more broadly, are led by politicians or by voters (Danieli et al., 2024; Trebbi, 2025; Longuet-Marx, 2026). Prior politician-side explanations for polarization or political realignment include Democrats’ retreat from economic “predistribution” (Kuziemko et al., 2026), political innovations pairing economically regressive platforms with cultural appeals (Hacker and Pierson, 2020; Buisseret and Van Weelden, 2025), or stronger party discipline (Canen et al., 2026). Prior voter-side explanations include globalization shocks (Ash et al., 2021; Choi et al., 2024), other secular economic trends (Inglehart and Flanagan, 1987; Grossmann and Hopkins, 2024; Enke et al., 2025), or foreign events (Bordalo et al., 2020). We focus instead on the incentives facing a third set of actors, 24-hour cable news, and we explain changes in the demand-side importance of cultural issues and the supply-side response of politicians as a byproduct of the distinctive business strategy

³See reviews in Gentzkow et al. (2015); Puglisi and Snyder Jr (2015), or more recently Prat (2018); Cagé (2020); Boxell and Conway (2022); Djourelouva (2023); Braghieri et al. (2025). A smaller literature examines other structural “biases” in news content: negativity (Sacerdote et al., 2020), sensationalism and “soft news” (Gambaro et al., 2025; Martin et al., 2026), identity framings (Hopkins et al., 2025), entertainment (Baum, 2002; Durante et al., 2019; Kim and Patterson Jr, 2025), and opinionated commentary over factual reporting (Bursztyn et al., 2023).

⁴Our focus on long-run political attention to economic vs. cultural issues complements work examining shorter-run attentional consequences of media (Eisensee and Strömberg, 2007; Durante and Zhuravskaya, 2018; Kaplan et al., 2025), and more generally, an extensive literature on the consequences of media slant and propaganda for voting, partisanship, and other political outcomes (reviewed in Strömberg 2015; Zhuravskaya et al. 2020).

⁵Prior work simultaneously modeling media and politician positioning, though assigning fundamentally different action spaces to the two actors rather than focusing on the difference in their objective functions, includes Strömberg (2004); Chan and Suen (2008); Piolatto and Schuett (2015). Prior work characterizing the content of political advertising, some of which also finds that economic issues comprise the majority of ads, includes Kaplan et al. (2006); Fowler et al. (2021a); Breuer et al. (2025). Gordon and Hartmann (2016); Moshary (2020); Garcia-Jimeno and Yildirim (2025) model competition in, and the market for, political advertising more generally. The poaching vs. mobilization distinction itself corresponds to the familiar distinction between business stealing and market expansion arising in models of differentiated products (e.g., Mankiw and Whinston 1986; Berry and Waldfogel 1999).

cable adopted in response to these incentives.⁶

Section 2 describes the data and the classification of news segments and political ads. Section 3 establishes the motivating cross-sectional and time-series descriptive facts. Section 4 shows that cultural coverage raises cable viewership relative to economic coverage, and traces this return to culture’s greater effectiveness for mobilizing disengaged consumers who would not otherwise watch news. Section 5 presents a conceptual framework contrasting cable, broadcast, and politicians’ incentives to air poaching vs. mobilizing content and uses this framework to structure analyses explaining cable’s uniquely strong incentives to air cultural content. Section 6 shows that exposure to cable news increases the importance of cultural issues in voters’ stated priorities and politicians’ campaign advertisements. Section 7 concludes.

2 Data and Classification

We draw upon seven primary types of data. This section describes the first four: (i) video files, transcripts, and summaries of news segments; (ii) video files and storyboards of political advertisements; (iii) data on household-level and aggregate news viewership; and (iv) data on individuals’ political preferences and media consumption, from a variety of political and consumer surveys. The remaining three types of data are more standard: (v) presidential, gubernatorial, and congressional electoral outcomes, from Dave Leip’s Atlas of U.S. Elections (Leip, 2023) and from the CQ Voting and Elections Collection (CQ Press, 2023); (vi) the channel lineups and ratings of Fox News, MSNBC, and CNN in each market from Nielsen FOCUS (The Nielsen Company, 2021); and (vii) county-level demographics from a variety of official sources.

2.1 Content of news and political ads

Television news The primary data source for television news content is the TV News Archive, a project of the nonprofit Internet Archive (Internet Archive, 2024). The TV News Archive provides video recordings of CNN, MSNBC, Fox News, and the San Francisco local affiliates of ABC, CBS, and NBC starting in 2012, with near-full coverage starting in 2014. We exclude local programming appearing on the broadcast affiliates, limiting the sample to nationally-aired content. Closed-caption transcripts of the audio are available for many episodes; for the remaining episodes, we generate transcripts using speech-to-text software. We extend the content series to the 1990s using the LexisNexis News Transcripts database (LexisNexis, 2024), which has less universal coverage; we further extend the series to 1968 using the Vanderbilt Television News Archive (Vanderbilt University, 2024), collected and processed by Armona et al. (2026), which contains the title and abstract of national segments aired by the three major broadcasters. In total, we classify 7.9 million one-minute windows of cable news and 1.8 million one-minute windows of broadcast news from the TV News Archive, 1.1 million one-minute windows of LexisNexis transcripts, and 590,573 Vanderbilt segment abstracts.

⁶The analysis complements Durante et al. (2019), who find that long-term exposure to Silvio Berlusconi’s entertainment television channel increases voters’ later receptiveness to Berlusconi’s populist rhetoric, and Perego and Yuksel (2022), who show that increased competition leads news outlets to specialize in more divisive issues — a mechanism complementary to, and potentially reinforcing, the poaching vs. mobilization channel we examine. Other work characterizing similar causal chains from media to voters’ beliefs and behaviors to politicians’ responses includes Ferraz and Finan (2008); Snyder and Strömberg (2010); Olken (2011) and, in local television news, Martin and McCrain (2019); Mastroiocco and Ornaghi (2025). Consistent with the distinct incentives facing broadcast and cable news, Campante and Hojman (2013) find that the introduction of broadcast television *reduced* the polarization of legislators representing exposed districts, in contrast to work finding the opposite effect for cable news (Clinton and Enamorado, 2014; Arceneaux et al., 2016).

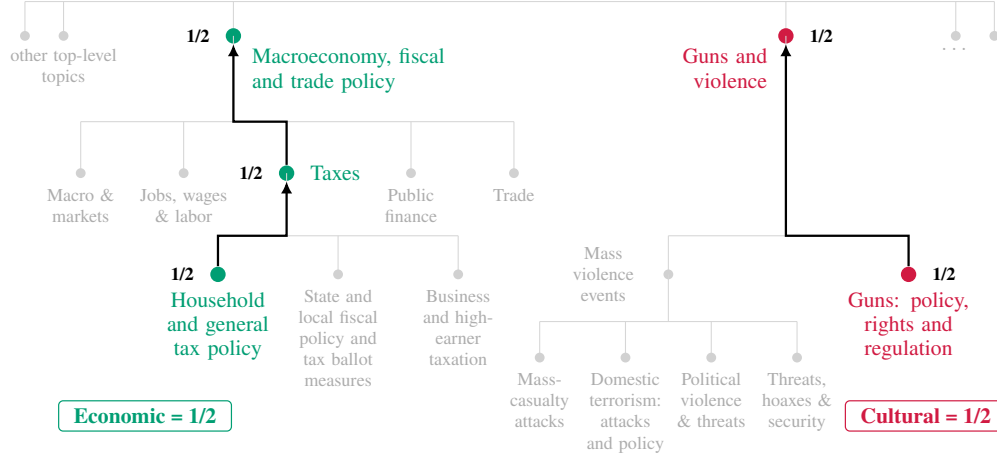
Political ads The primary data sources for political advertisements are the Wesleyan Media Project and its predecessor, the Wisconsin Advertising Project, which track broadcast television advertising by gubernatorial, congressional, and presidential candidates between 2000 and 2022 (Fowler et al., 2021b; Wesleyan Media Project, 2023) and record each ad airing, including both ads sponsored directly by the candidates and those sponsored by outside groups. The dataset covers all 210 media markets (Nielsen Designated Market Areas, or DMAs) for years after 2008, with only the 75–100 largest DMAs covered between 2000 and 2008. Video files are available in most years; otherwise, we use ad “storyboards” containing frames from the ad and a transcript of the accompanying audio. We extract transcripts from video files and storyboards using speech-to-text and optical character recognition software, resulting in 60,816 unique advertisements (204 hours of video). We extend the sample of presidential advertisements back to 1960 using a collection of approximately 9,000 videos collected by the Julian P. Kanter Political Commercial Archive at The University of Oklahoma (University of Oklahoma, 2024) and provided by Breuer et al. (2025).

Classifying topics In cooperation with two former congressional staffers, we develop a unified hierarchical schema to classify each political ad and each 60-second news window, presented in Appendix A. The schema contains 23 high-level branches, such as “macroeconomy, fiscal and trade policy,” “health and medicine,” “immigration,” and “morality, religion, and gender”. Across these branches, the schema contains 259 topics, enabling granular content classification. For instance, a segment or ad about corporate tax rates is coded as “business, corporate and high-earner taxation” and one about immigration raids as “interior enforcement, raids and deportation”. Many segments or ads receive multiple topic classifications.

We then use a large language model to classify the political ads and news segments, validating performance using a set of 1,000 ads hand-labeled by the former congressional staffers and 5,000 60-second news segments hand-labeled by workers with backgrounds in journalism (see Appendix A for further details). The model extracts the lowest-level classifications in the hierarchical schema possible: some news segments or political ads are specific enough that we can assign low-level classifications, but many are vague (e.g., about “the economy”) and thus we can assign only parent-level classifications. As shown in Appendix Table A3, the model generally achieves high fidelity relative to the human coders both for the broad content families and for individual topics.⁷

The resulting classifications are vectors, with each element corresponding to a topic in the schema. To map the raw classification output to the final feature vectors, we begin by assigning a value of $1/N$ to each of the N raw topics identified by the classifier, then sequentially “rolling up” these weights to the parents of these raw topics. For example, a video that discusses both “household and general tax policy” and “guns: policy, rights and regulation” would start with values of $1/2$ for the vector elements corresponding to each; we would then assign $1/2$ to the elements corresponding to the parent of each (“taxes” and “guns and violence”); and the process would continue until we have propagated to all parent categories. This weighting procedure enables us to compare the prevalence of topics at different levels of the hierarchical classification schema.

⁷We report both accuracy and the F1 score, defined as the harmonic mean of precision (the share of texts the classifier assigns to a topic that the human coders also assign to it) and recall (the share of texts the human coders assign to a topic that the classifier also assigns to it). Because many topics are rare, accuracy tends to be extremely high (over 99% for many topics), reflecting “true negative” texts where the topic did not appear and the classifier correctly did not detect it. The F1 score excludes these true negatives and so is not inflated by a topic’s rarity: it is driven only by texts that at least one of the classifier or the coders assigns to the topic, and it falls whenever the classifier either misses texts the coders flagged or flags texts the coders did not.



Classification roll-up procedure

Economic and cultural groupings To facilitate exposition, we assign each topic to exactly one of five families: economic, cultural, political process, mixed, or nonpolitical.⁸ We report every topic and its assigned family in Appendix Table A1. The economic–cultural distinction follows Shafer and Spady (2014): topics concerning “the distribution of material goods” are economic and topics concerning “the reinforcement of behavioral norms” are cultural. “Political process” topics include topics explicitly about government functioning or electoral predictions or results; “mixed” topics include substantive topics such as foreign policy that are not cleanly classified as either economic or cultural; and “nonpolitical” topics include commercial advertising or sports and entertainment content.

The granularity of the topic classification makes family assignment less ambiguous than it would be at the level of broad issues. For instance, we can distinguish the economic topic of immigration’s labor-market consequences from the cultural topic of border security. Nonetheless, the process is inherently subjective. In Section 5.5, we extensively validate the schema and these groupings, including by replicating the main estimates with alternative assignments of topics to families and presenting data-driven exercises blind to our labels or to the schema itself.

2.2 News viewership

We obtain a panel of household-level TV viewing behavior between January 1, 2015 and December 31, 2020 from FourthWall Media (FourthWall Media, 2021), a media analytics company. FourthWall collects high-frequency “viewership events” — changing the channel, or turning on or off the TV — from each household via set-top boxes or smart TVs (Canen and Martin, 2023). We observe every continuous viewership spell lasting five seconds or longer. These data enable us to reconstruct what program each household was watching at each second and, by linking these events with the classified TV News Archive data, what issues were being discussed. The panel includes 15,000 households from 28 Nielsen Designated Market Areas (DMAs).

⁸We compute family shares at the level of the raw classification rather than from the rolled-up vector, so the five family shares are nonnegative and sum to one by construction. The primary relative cultural measures are differences of these family shares with nonpolitical content excluded from the denominator.

2.3 Political and consumer surveys

We use data from a variety of individual-level surveys, the most important of which are the Gallup Poll Social Series (GPSS, Gallup 2021) and the MRI Survey of the American Consumer (GfK MRI, 2020).

The GPSS is a repeated cross-sectional survey of approximately 2,000 Americans per month; we access waves from 2000 through 2022. While many of the questions rotate, the “Most Important Problem” (MIP) question is asked consistently: “What do you think is the most important problem facing the country today?” Respondents answer in open-ended form and Gallup codes each response into one of approximately eighty categories. We match categories to the corresponding topic in the classification schema, reporting this mapping in Appendix A. We also observe each respondent’s demographics, ZIP code, and political affiliation. We extend this series before 2000 using the Most Important Problem Dataset compiled by Yildirim and Williams (2024), which lacks detailed demographics and geographic identifiers.

The MRI Survey of the American Consumer is a long-running repeated cross-sectional consumer survey. We access the television viewership segment of the Media modules for 1992–2020, which include approximately 20,000 consumers in each year and include respondents’ self-reported viewership of dozens or hundreds of different television shows or networks, varying by year.

3 Issue Emphasis of Cable News, Broadcast News, and Political Advertising

This section describes cross-sectional differences in issue coverage between cable news, broadcast news, and political TV advertisements, and time-series changes in the importance of these issues to voters and their prevalence in news and political ads. We establish two broad facts. Cross-sectionally, cable news predominantly emphasizes the non-economic issues often associated with the culture war, political ads predominantly emphasize bread-and-butter economic issues, and broadcast news falls between the two. In the time series, the issues overrepresented in cable news relative to broadcast news are those which have grown in their relative importance in politics since the entry of Fox News and MSNBC in 1996.

3.1 Cross-sectional differences in issue coverage

Figure 2 presents the relative prevalence of schema topics across cable news, broadcast news, and political advertising, limiting for readability to the top 80 topics by summed prevalence across the three sources. Panel A reports cable prevalence relative to broadcast news and Panel B reports cable prevalence relative to political advertising. Topics to the right of the vertical line appear more commonly in cable. We plot economic topics in green, cultural topics in red, and all other topics in gray.

Panel A shows that cable news emphasizes more cultural and less economic content than broadcast news. 72% of all of cable’s economic or cultural coverage is cultural, compared to 50% of broadcast’s. Cable contains roughly 50% more content about immigration and crime, about 30% more coverage of racial and gender issues, and three times more criticism of media. Broadcast contains approximately three times as much coverage of infrastructure and housing and twice as much coverage of health, education, and social welfare.

The pattern is even starker for the cable–politician comparison in Panel B: only 16% of political ads’ economic or cultural content is cultural. Cable airs approximately four times as much crime, policing, and justice content, four times as much anti-media content, and twice as much guns and violence content, whereas ads contain ten times as much macroeconomic content or education and social welfare content as cable news.

Immigration and abortion are important exceptions: driven by recent years, they are more represented in political ads than cable news. While there are some differences in advertising by party (Appendix Figure B1), economic topics comprise the majority of messaging for both parties, and this is true even in 2022, the final and most cultural year in the data.

We use television ads to measure candidate messaging because, throughout the period we study, TV ads dominate campaign advertising expenditures: even in 2024, candidates' total expenditure on TV and radio ads was approximately double their expenditure on digital advertising (Fowler et al., 2025). Nonetheless, Appendix F characterizes the content of candidates' digital advertising and social media activity, and shows that the issue emphasis of candidates' posts on Twitter, their ads on Facebook and Instagram, and their ads on Google and YouTube is broadly similar to that of their television advertising: digital ads closely track television ads, and although candidates' Twitter posts place more weight on cultural issues than their TV ads, economic topics still comprise the majority of their Twitter content.

3.2 Time-series changes in issue emphasis and issue importance

3.2.1 Changes in news content

The cross-sectional differences between cable and broadcast coverage in Figure 2 suggest that the entry of Fox News and MSNBC in 1996 substantially increased the supply of cultural news. As shown in Appendix Figure B2, the three major broadcasters (ABC, CBS, NBC) are virtually indistinguishable both before and immediately after the entry of cable networks, emphasizing economic topics slightly more than cultural topics. While we lack transcript coverage from Fox News and MSNBC until 1998, over a year after they began broadcasting, it is clear that by 2000, they were significantly more cultural than the broadcast news outlets. We also lack CNN content before the 1990s; narrative accounts indicate that CNN's programming in this early period emphasized international reporting and live breaking-news coverage, in line with its founder's own internationalist convictions (Schonfeld, 2001; Napoli, 2020).⁹ CNN converged to Fox News and MSNBC's cultural coverage levels by around 2001. Starting in 2010, the three broadcast channels began decreasing their economic emphasis and increasing their cultural emphasis, partially closing the content gap with cable news.

These facts are consistent with qualitative accounts emphasizing that cable outlets broke with many of the traditional conventions of broadcast news. Motivated largely by the need to produce 24 hours of news content per day, they introduced a variety of programming innovations, incorporating entertainment and tapping into partisan outrage (Berry and Sobieraj, 2013; Hemmer, 2022), and used increasingly sophisticated ratings analytics to inform coverage decisions (Smith, 2019; Confessore, 2022; Hayes, 2025). The later increase in cultural content among broadcasters coincides with increasing financial pressures in the wake of the Great Financial Crisis, which pushed the networks to run their news divisions as profit centers (Koppel, 2010) and led to substantial newsroom cuts (Pew Research Center, 2010, 2011; Waldman, 2011).

Since our analysis focuses on the entry of Fox News and MSNBC in 1996, an important question is why CNN — also a 24-hour cable news outlet — did not emphasize cultural messaging upon its founding. One potential explanation is that when CNN's format was set in 1980, there was no evidence that culture-war programming could sustain a news outlet (Schonfeld, 2001; Napoli, 2020). The demand for cultural news content was demonstrated only over the following fifteen years, perhaps most importantly by the explosive

⁹Prominent exceptions were *Crossfire*, which featured aggressive partisan debates about economic, cultural, and foreign-affairs topics, and the soft-news talk show *Larry King Live* (Schonfeld, 2001).

popularity of (heavily cultural) conservative talk radio, which itself was made possible by the 1987 repeal of the Fairness Doctrine.¹⁰ By this time, CNN had already invested in a globally-focused hard-news franchise, with 21 international bureaus, distribution in over 200 countries, and a reputation for factual and investigative reporting.¹¹

3.2.2 Changes in issue importance

We now turn to suggestive evidence that cable’s entry, paired with its emphasis on cultural topics, increased the political importance of cultural issues. We examine the topic-by-topic relationship between the cable–broadcast coverage ratios plotted in Panel A of Figure 2 and changes in three measures of each topic’s importance in politics since the entry of Fox News and MSNBC: each topic’s perceived importance to voters, its predictiveness for voting behavior, and the share of political advertising it comprises. We define these measures as follows:

1. **Perceived importance:** Many of the topics in the schema can be linked to answer choices in Gallup’s “Most Important Problem Facing the Country” question (Appendix Table A2). We calculate the survey-weighted share m_{xt}^{imp} of mapped response mass assigned to topic x in each year t .
2. **Predictiveness for voting:** The American National Election Studies, a long-running political survey, has consistently asked several questions eliciting respondents’ positions on different political issues, which we link to the corresponding topics in the schema (Appendix Table A2). For each issue measure elicited in both the first and last wave (1996 and 2020), we estimate the following regression for each issue x in each year t :

$$V_{it} = \alpha_{xt} + \beta_{xt} p_{ixt} + \epsilon_{ixt},$$

where p_{ixt} is respondent i ’s position on issue x in year t , scaled to $[-1, 1]$, and V_{it} is the respondent’s reported presidential vote, coded -1 for a Democratic vote, 1 for a Republican vote, and 0 for another candidate or not voting. We define m_{xt}^{pred} as the R^2 from this bivariate regression, which captures the extent to which vote outcomes are differentiated along issue x .

3. **Representation in political ads:** We calculate the airings-weighted share m_{xt}^{ads} of issue x within political ads in year t .

To estimate changes over time, we estimate, separately for each measure, the regression $\log m_{xt} = \alpha_x + \delta_x t + \epsilon_{xt}$, where the log transform enables us to interpret δ_x as an average percent increase or decrease per year.

Figure 3 plots the estimated δ_x coefficients, capturing trends in importance, against the corresponding log cable–broadcast content ratios. We also report these estimates, and variations of the specification, in Appendix Table D1. This evidence is naturally suggestive, particularly given the limited number of topics

¹⁰Fox News was a direct descendant of the most popular such show, *The Rush Limbaugh Show*, which at its peak drew roughly 20 million listeners a week: Roger Ailes produced Rush Limbaugh’s television program before building the talk channel America’s Talking and then Fox News (Sherman, 2014).

¹¹Indeed, even as its wall-to-wall coverage of the O.J. Simpson trial in 1995 raised ratings by half, CNN’s management was conflicted about airing such sensationalist cultural content. CNN president Tom Johnson recalled that “I would try to cut away from O.J. Simpson,” but the viewership penalty of doing so was too large (Levin, 2024). CNN’s gradual shift toward cultural programming accelerated after founder Ted Turner lost operational authority over the network in 2001, the same year Fox News first surpassed CNN in primetime ratings.

that can be linked, but the estimates suggest that the (predominantly cultural) topics emphasized relatively more by cable news grow more important to survey respondents, more predictive of voting behavior, and more prevalent in candidate advertising. These patterns motivate our examination both of why cable disproportionately emphasizes these topics and whether cable is responsible for these changes in issue importance.

4 Viewership Returns to Culture on Cable News

This section turns from documenting cable’s emphasis on cultural issues to estimating the effect of covering cultural issues on cable viewership.

4.1 Empirical strategy

Our approach is to relate contemporaneous viewership of news segments to these segments’ content. Several threats to identification may confound a cross-sectional regression of viewership on content, arising from unobserved factors which simultaneously influence both the content networks air and the audience size they attract. For example, networks may strategically choose to air cultural topics that they expect will perform well during periods that would have experienced high viewership regardless, or hosts who draw large audiences for reasons unrelated to their choice of content may have a preference for discussing cultural topics.

We address these threats by exploiting the high-frequency nature of our data, which enables us to include rich sets of controls isolating idiosyncratic variation in the timing of when topics are discussed. We also estimate specifications that control for arbitrary shocks to viewers’ propensity to tune in at a particular time, simulating an experiment of randomly assigning different content types to viewers when they turn on the channel. The identifying assumption is that residual variation in content stems from idiosyncratic variation in network decisions or the stock of available news events, unrelated to potential viewership outcomes. We produce “event study” plots showing the effects of leads and lags of content, enabling visual inspection of potential pretrends to gauge the plausibility of this identifying assumption.

In the baseline specification, the panel unit is a network n by fifteen-minute timeslot s (e.g., Fox News at 8:00–8:15pm) and the running variable t is the calendar-date (e.g., Thursday, June 7, 2018). Following Freyaldenhoven et al. (2026), we write the model as:

$$V_{n,s,t} = \sum_{m=-P}^P \beta_m x_{n,s,t-m} + \eta_t + g'_{n,s,t} \phi + \varepsilon_{n,s,t}, \quad (1)$$

where η_t are calendar date fixed effects, $x_{n,s,t}$ is a scalar measure of content, $P = 7$ is the number of pre- and post-periods we include, and g' is a vector of controls: at baseline, we include show-by-timeslot-by-month and show-by-timeslot-by-day-of-week fixed effects. The dependent variable in the baseline specification is the logged total number of seconds viewed across all households in the panel. We cluster standard errors at the panel unit (network-by-timeslot) and time (date) levels.

The model exploits both variation within panel units across successive days (e.g., Fox News at 8:00–8:15pm on June 7 compared to June 8) and variation across panel units within calendar days (e.g., differences in content on June 7 between 8:00–8:15 on Fox News, 7:00–7:15 on Fox News, and 8:00–8:15 on MSNBC). Interpreting β_0 as the causal effect of content at time t on viewership at time t requires the assumption that

$\mathbb{E}[\varepsilon_{n,s,t} \mid x_{n,s,t-P}, \dots, x_{n,s,t+P}, \eta_t, g_{n,s,t}] = 0$: conditional on the controls, the content a network airs must be unrelated to the slot’s potential viewership $V_{n,s,t}(x^\circ)$ for a fixed reference mix x° .

Threats to identification Shocks to viewership operate through two distinct channels. The first is content-independent: shocks to households’ propensity to watch irrespective of what airs in the slot, such as a holiday that keeps viewers home or a strong lead-in audience. The identifying assumption fails if residual movements in content are correlated with timeslot-specific viewership shocks — for example, if a producer times economic coverage to moments they expect to underperform for unrelated reasons. By exploiting progressively more fine-grained variation, the specifications below restrict the level at which such a confound would have to operate, and we also gauge the plausibility of the identifying assumptions by examining whether network-by-timeslots that change their content emphasis at $t = 0$ are on different viewership trends on preceding days compared to network-by-timeslots that do not.¹²

The second channel through which viewership shocks operate is content-dependent: the arrival of a newsworthy event raises the appeal of coverage specifically of that topic. If such shocks move viewership *only* through shifting the content networks choose to air, they do not violate the identifying assumption and, indeed, generate useful identifying variation. However, if viewers tune in after a newsworthy event because they *expect* to find coverage of the newsworthy event but end up watching even if the network is discussing another topic — and the fixed effects fail to partial out this variation — the identifying assumption would fail. We estimate a second specification directly addressing this concern by conditioning on viewers tuning in to a segment and examining how long they watch.

Given the fixed effects, the residual variation in content that identifies the viewership returns to content reflects both idiosyncratic editorial and host decisions of where to place a segment in a given month, week, or episode and variation in the flow of real-world stories (e.g., Hamilton 2004; Hayes 2025).

4.2 Results

For ease of exposition, we first present results with a single measure of relative cultural content: the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by the sum of the segment’s cultural, economic, process, and mixed shares. The denominator excludes nonpolitical topics, mostly entertainment or commercial advertising. Positive coefficients indicate a viewership premium for cultural relative to economic content.

Panel A of Figure 4 plots the resulting coefficients $\{\beta_m\}_{m=-6}^7$ in black, with associated 95% confidence intervals and with the $m = -7$ coefficient normalized to 0. The contemporaneous coefficient is 0.0138 (s.e. 0.0025), indicating that switching from entirely economic political content ($x_{n,s,t} = -1$) to entirely cultural political content ($x_{n,s,t} = 1$) increases contemporaneous viewership by approximately 2.8%. Equivalently, a one-standard-deviation increase in relative cultural content increases contemporaneous viewership by approximately 0.5%. Reassuringly, the pre-period coefficients are tightly identified near zero and show no evidence of differential pretrends. The binned scatterplot of this relationship (Appendix Figure B6) confirms the relationship between residualized relative cultural content and viewership is approximately linear.

¹²The timing of production also limits the scope for such fine-grained strategic network behavior. The primary high-frequency mechanism by which networks adjust content in response to viewership operates at the *daily* level (for example, Fox News senior vice president John Moody’s infamous daily memos). Producers, and sometimes hosts, review the previous day’s ratings in morning meetings (Hayes, 2025) and often use this information to inform their coverage. The $m < 0$ pre-trend coefficients test for precisely these dynamics.

A useful benchmark is the comparable effect of switching from a segment with no commercial advertising to a segment exclusively devoted to commercial advertising (Wilbur, 2008). We re-estimate Equation 1, defining the treatment instead as the share of commercial advertising, in Appendix Figure B3. The contemporaneous coefficient is -0.1439 (s.e. 0.0065), roughly five times the magnitude of the decline caused by a switch from cultural to economic political coverage.

Additional show-level controls Panel A of Figure 4 presents additional specifications to rule out potential threats to identification. We include a specification with show-by-day-of-week-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects, which exploit only variation in content between, for example, the 8:15pm–8:30pm timeslot across the four Tuesday episodes of *Tucker Carlson Tonight* in March 2018. We include a second specification that adds network-by-date fixed effects, ruling out shocks that might lead a particular network to both experience lower viewership on a given day and, separately, broadcast more economic content relative to cultural content. Finally, we include a specification that adds an *episode*-level fixed effect, comparing viewership during a more economic fifteen-minute timeslot within a given 60-minute episode to viewership during a more cultural fifteen-minute timeslot in that same episode.

The estimated viewership premium of cultural relative to economic content remains strong and statistically significant across all three alternative specifications. Relative to the baseline specification, show-by-day-of-week-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects and network-by-date fixed effects have little effect on the coefficient estimate. Episode fixed effects significantly attenuate the estimate; they also do so in the commercial advertising specification (Appendix Figure B3), suggesting that viewers are generally less sensitive to within-episode variation than across-episode variation — a pattern which would emerge if, for example, viewers are willing to watch some content they disprefer in expectation that the episode will later revert to its typical mix. Remaining confounds must operate at a level more granular than an episode: for example, a show’s producer would need to anticipate an unusually large viewership decline during a particular part of their show on a particular day and strategically time their economic content for that moment.

Disaggregating effects In Panel B of Figure 4, we examine the effects of each content family and higher-level topic on viewership. Directly replicating the specification of Panel A, replacing the treatment with each share, would prevent us from comparing coefficient estimates: each coefficient would measure the effect of substituting the topic for whatever mix of other content the topic displaces. Instead, we estimate two joint static specifications, one for content families and one for higher-level topics. The specification follows Equation 1, but sets $P = 0$ and jointly includes all shares, with nonpolitical content as the omitted group. The estimates capture the effect of substituting the given family for nonpolitical content, holding the other shares fixed. At both the family level and the higher-level topic level, we find that cultural content outperforms economic content, with mixed and process content falling between the two. Similar patterns emerge at the level of individual topics (Appendix Figure B4).

Conditioning on tuning in We next estimate a specification that controls for arbitrarily granular shocks to viewers’ propensities to tune in to a segment, ruling out the concern that some news stories may shift viewers’ *overall* propensity to watch TV — if, for instance, they expect networks to cover certain stories and thus tune in even if the network does not actually do so. We condition on the event that a household tunes into a channel at all and watches at least five seconds, the minimum viewership duration represented in the data, and we examine whether households watch a larger proportion of the remaining segment when cultural

content is being aired than when economic content is being aired. Under the assumption that conditional on the rich fixed effects, viewers cannot anticipate the content being aired at exactly the time they tune in, this specification approximates the experiment of randomly assigning households cultural or economic content.¹³

As shown in Panel A of Appendix Figure B5, households tune out of a network significantly more quickly when it is airing economic, rather than cultural, content: A one-unit increase in relative cultural content raises the share of the remaining segment watched by 0.53 percentage points (s.e. 0.074), relative to a mean of 52.5%. The estimate is stable across the specifications shown in Figure 4. That the coefficient remains significant under episode fixed effects is particularly reassuring, since the identifying assumption in this specification remains valid even if the viewer can anticipate the exact mix of an episode, as long as they cannot anticipate when particular segments will air beyond the typical airing patterns within the show.

Further robustness Appendix B.1 presents a series of exercises further probing the robustness of these results. Estimates replicate when we examine viewers displaced from their previous channel by a commercial advertising break, whose timing generates a source of exogenous variation in when viewers tune in (Panel A of Appendix Table B1). They also replicate using alternative segment lengths and panel setups and using hour-level audience estimates from Nielsen’s nationally representative panel (Panels B–D of Appendix Figure B5). Finally, static panel regressions that impose no event-window requirement closely track the event-study estimates (Panels A–B of Appendix Table B2).

4.3 Interpretation

The design exploits idiosyncratic variation in which of a network’s *already-selected* stories viewers encounter, rather than variation in the selection of stories themselves. The estimates therefore measure the average difference in audience appeal between cultural and economic stories, conditional on networks choosing to air these stories. Because this parameter is different from the effect of replacing the marginal economic story with the marginal cultural story, the results do not indicate that networks are failing to equate marginal viewership returns with marginal costs, even if the marginal costs of producing economic and cultural coverage are equal.

An important limitation of this design is that the estimates are short-run. While the cultural premium shows no sign of reversal within the estimation window, the marginal variation we exploit cannot capture slower-moving costs or benefits, such as effects on a network’s reputation or the formation of viewing habits. This limitation raises the concern that some stories, such as a jobs report or a Federal Reserve decision, are aired precisely due to these long-term reputational considerations or due to journalistic obligation, even if they depress short-run viewership. To the extent that a greater share of these “must-run” stories are economic than cultural, this could lead us to estimate an economic-family penalty on average even if viewers have no intrinsic preference for cultural content. The fact that we estimate a viewership penalty for every high-level economic topic, including those for which “must-run” stories are rare, suggests this concern is unlikely to be driving the effects. The granular topic-level estimates in Appendix Figure B4 similarly address the related concern that the estimates capture only a “breaking news” effect rather than a generalized preference for cultural content: economic topics generally underperform even those cultural topics for which breaking news stories are rare. We return to the question of how the “bundled treatment” of cultural content differs from that of economic content (e.g. in emotionality, sensationalism, or simplicity) in Section 5.5.

¹³In the structural exercise detailed in Appendix H.1, we structurally estimate the extent to which these fixed effects absorb households’ information about content and show that this assumption is justified.

A common narrative is that networks air cultural content primarily because it is cheaper to produce than original economic reporting (Hamilton, 2004; Koppel, 2010). Under the assumption that networks air stories when their expected viewership returns justify their cost, our estimates suggest that networks’ cultural emphasis is likely not driven by cost differences: cheaper cultural production would imply a lower quality threshold for cultural stories and thus a cultural viewership *penalty*. We estimate a cultural *premium* even though cable already emphasizes culture far more than economics (Section 3), suggesting it is reaching correspondingly deeper into the pool of candidate cultural stories, depressing the relative appeal of the aired cultural set.

4.4 Poaching and mobilization flows

The data enable us to estimate not only whether viewers tune out in response to economic rather than cultural content, but also which alternative they select after tuning out. We distinguish two alternatives: competing news networks (the “poaching” margin) vs. non-news/entertainment networks and turning off the TV (the “mobilization” margin). Panel A of Figure 5 replicates our standard event-study specification (Equation 1), but separately plots flows to competing news networks, along the poaching margin, and flows to entertainment or turning off the TV, along the mobilization margin.¹⁴

Results The average positive effect of culture on cable viewership masks two opposite-signed flows: cultural content decreases the rate at which viewers switch to entertainment or turn off the TV by 0.59 percentage points (s.e. 0.076), but *increases* the rate at which they switch to competing channels by 0.29 percentage points (s.e. 0.053). That is, cultural content is more effective at mobilization than economic content, but less effective at poaching than economic content. As it is for viewership, the relationship between residualized relative cultural content and diversion is linear (Appendix Figure B9).

We collapse these results to a single dependent variable, “diversion,” defined as the share of households switching to competing news channels minus the share switching to an entertainment channel or turning off the TV. A positive diversion estimate therefore reflects that a topic is relatively more effective for mobilizing than for poaching. Estimating diversion for each of the top-level topics in Panel B of Figure 5, and for every topic in Appendix Figure B7, we find that the pattern holds more generally: cultural topics are relatively more effective for mobilization and economic topics relatively more effective for poaching.

Robustness As an alternative approach that does not condition on viewers having tuned into the focal segment, we replace the dependent variable with total seconds chosen by *all* households in our panel during the timeslot, separately estimating the effect of content on network j on total seconds spent watching network j , total seconds spent watching rival news networks $k \neq j$, and total seconds spent watching entertainment or with the TV off. Appendix Figure B10 reports the outcomes in both logs and levels. In both cases, cultural relative to economic content increases viewing of the focal network, and it reduces entertainment and television-off time (increasing mobilization) while increasing viewing of rival news networks (decreasing poaching). We also replicate the battery of robustness checks implemented for the aggregate viewership

¹⁴We classify a household as having switched from channel A to channel B if (1) the household has no other viewing intervals of more than five seconds between when they stop watching A and start watching B , and (2) the start time of viewing B is less than two minutes after the end time of viewing A . This definition ensures that if a viewer manually switches from channel A to channel B by way of the intermediate channels, we still capture this as an A - B switch. We study outflows, rather than also including households who flow *in* to the segment, because — as underlies our identification strategy — only households tuned into a channel know what content is being broadcast on the channel and can plausibly respond to it.

results in Appendix Figure B8, confirming that the magnitude of the contemporaneous coefficient remains stable and statistically significant, and that no specification surfaces concerning pretrends.

Following the robustness check of Section 4.2 presented in Panel A of Appendix Table B1, Panels B and C implement specifications examining the extent to which culture, relative to economics, attracts viewers displaced by a commercial advertising break from entertainment programming (Panel B) or from broadcast news (Panel C). More culture relative to economics attracts viewers displaced from entertainment, whereas more economics relative to culture attracts viewers displaced from broadcast news. These results on *inflows* thus exactly parallel the primary findings on *outflows* presented in Figure 5.

5 Returns to Culture for Broadcast News and for Politicians

We now turn to the question of why cable news is unique in its strong cultural emphasis. The heterogeneous flows documented in Section 4.4 motivate a framework structuring the parallel tradeoff facing cable, broadcast, and politicians between “mobilizing” disengaged consumers and “poaching” engaged consumers from rivals. We use this framework to guide our comparison of the incentives facing cable news with those facing broadcast news and politicians. We show that cable has stronger incentives than broadcast and politicians to engage in mobilization — which, since cultural content is relatively more effective for mobilization, may help rationalize its cultural focus. The framework intentionally abstracts from the many other differences between these three sets of agents that might also lead to content differences; Section 5.4 estimates a richer model, which we use to assess the quantitative importance of the mechanisms we examine here.

5.1 Conceptual framework

Cable news, broadcast news, and politicians face a similar problem: each competes to attract consumers, and each can attract consumers on either the poaching margin (consumers who would otherwise choose a competing news outlet or opposing candidate) or the mobilization margin (consumers who would otherwise choose the outside option of entertainment/turning off the TV, or abstain/vote third party). A supplier i faces a mass $\mathcal{P}$ of *poachable* consumers, who are marginal between i and one or more competitors $-i$, and a mass $\mathcal{M}$ of *mobilizable* consumers, who are marginal between i and the outside option. A supplier chooses the cultural share of its content, $x \in [0, 1]$, with the remaining $1 - x$ economic, and wins a fraction $p(x)$ of the poachable and $m(x)$ of the mobilizable, so its audience is $V_i(x) = \mathcal{M}m(x) + \mathcal{P}p(x)$.¹⁵ Following Figure 5, cultural emphasis mobilizes and economic emphasis poaches: $m'(x) > 0 > p'(x)$.

The supplier maximizes

$$\Pi(x) = V_i(x) - \omega V_{-i}(x) - c(x), \quad (2)$$

where $\omega \in [0, 1]$ is the weight placed on the number of consumers choosing competitors: a mobilized consumer raises Π by 1, while a poached consumer raises it by $1 + \omega$. $c(\cdot)$ is a cost capturing editorial, reputational, or production considerations.

¹⁵This simplified model restricts attention to two content types and interior solutions, and rules out “countermobilization,” by which i ’s content causes the *competitor’s* latent supporters — consumers who would otherwise choose the outside option, and who are not part of i ’s own mobilizable mass $\mathcal{M}$ — to choose the competitor. Appendix G generalizes the results to J topics and corner solutions, and accounts for such countermobilization flows. We note that countermobilization is implausible in the television domain and remains contested in the political domain (Hall and Thompson, 2025).

An interior optimum balances the two margins against cost:

$$\underbrace{\mathcal{M} m'(x^*)}_{\text{mobilization gain}} + \underbrace{(1 + \omega) \mathcal{P} p'(x^*)}_{\text{poaching loss}} = c'(x^*). \quad (3)$$

Different suppliers may differ in their optimal topic emphasis because they face a different *number* of mobilizable vs. poachable consumers ($\mathcal{M}$ and $\mathcal{P}$ differ), or because they place a greater *value* on each poached vs. mobilized consumer (ω differs).¹⁶

5.2 Returns to culture for broadcast news

We now apply this framework to the comparison between cable and broadcast news, where the first-order difference is the timing of programming. In contrast to 24-hour cable news, broadcast national news occupies a thin and tightly clustered schedule: most programming on broadcast affiliates is devoted to local news, sports, or scripted and reality entertainment, and the networks air their national newscasts at specific times of day, and at the same times as one another. Cable and broadcast news thus face very different marginal consumers. The typical viewer of broadcast national news, watching during the few times of day when broadcast national news is available and when the news-seeking audience is concentrated and every network is competing for it, is relatively more likely to be on the *poaching* margin of choosing between competing newscasts. The typical viewer of cable news watches at hours during which they have fewer news alternatives, and is thus relatively more likely to be on the *mobilization* margin of otherwise watching entertainment or turning off the television. Given that cultural content is better for mobilization and economic content better for poaching, this difference in marginal consumers may help explain why broadcast chooses a lower cultural share than cable.

Heterogeneity by broadcast availability If cultural content on cable news is a strategy to mobilize viewers who would otherwise watch entertainment, then the returns to this strategy should be higher when more potential cable news viewers are watching entertainment and lower when more potential cable news viewers are watching rival news outlets. We therefore examine whether cable’s viewership premium, and its greater cultural emphasis, are driven by timeslots when broadcast news does not air. We measure broadcast availability at the year-by-day-of-week-by-half-hour level as the share of DMA-dates in which at least one of ABC, CBS, or NBC airs national news in that slot. Across these recurring cells, mean availability is 22% and median availability is 7%: in the typical slot, broadcast national news is unavailable in most media markets on most dates.

We estimate an interacted version of Equation 1, allowing the full dynamic relationship between content and viewership to vary with broadcast availability:

$$V_{n,s,t} = \sum_{m=-P}^P [\beta_m x_{n,s,t-m} + \gamma_m (x_{n,s,t-m} \times A_{s,t-m})] + \delta A_{s,t} + \eta_t + g'_{n,s,t} \phi + \varepsilon_{n,s,t}. \quad (4)$$

¹⁶The flow estimates of Section 4.4 identify the *total* responses $\mathcal{M}m'$ and $\mathcal{P}p'$, not their components: a supplier’s content could move total mobilization more either because more of its potential audience is mobilizable (larger $\mathcal{M}$) or because each mobilizable consumer responds more strongly (larger m'), and likewise for poaching. We maintain the normalization that the per-consumer response functions $m(\cdot)$ and $p(\cdot)$ are common across suppliers, attributing differences in total responses, given measured composition, to differences in $\mathcal{M}$ and $\mathcal{P}$.

Here, $A_{s,t} \in [0, 1]$ is the broadcast availability of the recurring year-by-day-of-week-by-half-hour cell containing timeslot s on date t , and all other terms are as in Equation 1. Importantly, the fixed effects of Equation 1 already absorb cross-timeslot level differences in viewership and content. The contemporaneous cultural premium in a slot with availability A is $\beta_0 + \gamma_0 A$.

Panel A of Figure 6 shows that cable’s cultural premium declines strongly with broadcast availability. The contemporaneous event-study interaction estimate is $\hat{\gamma}_0 = -0.0190$ (s.e. 0.0062), such that the implied premium falls from 0.0209 at the 10th percentile of availability to 0.0058 at the 90th percentile. Panel B shows a parallel decline in cable’s cultural content share. The linear slope of relative cultural content on broadcast availability is -0.1019 (s.e. 0.0210), implying an 8.0 percentage-point decline between the 10th and 90th percentiles of availability.¹⁷

These results suggest that the differences between cable and broadcast news are concentrated in the times in which broadcast news is unavailable; and thus, that the distinctive incentives generated by the 24-hour news model can explain cable’s stronger incentives to air the cultural content best for mobilizing viewers who would otherwise watch entertainment or not watch TV.

Historical evidence from consumer survey data The rich television viewership module included in the MRI Survey of the American Consumer enables a broader test of whether Fox News and MSNBC attracted their early audience by poaching viewers from other news programs or mobilizing viewers who were previously watching entertainment. This exercise complements our prior viewership analyses in two ways. First, whereas the household-by-second viewership data begin in 2015, the MRI data enable us to speak to viewer behavior before and immediately after the launch of Fox News and MSNBC in 1996. Second, whereas the event studies recover the preferences of marginal viewers around marginal shifts in content, leaving longer-term reputation and beliefs unchanged, this exercise captures networks’ overall strategy, characterizing whom each network attracted rather than estimating viewers’ responses to content.

We classify every show or network included in the viewership survey as either “news” or “entertainment” programming, then compute, for each survey respondent, the number of news and entertainment programs they report watching in the past week (Appendix Table B4). MRI is a cross-section, so we cannot observe individual-level switching behavior from broadcast news or entertainment to cable news; we instead compute this behavior at the level of demographic groups. Using data from 1992–1995, the period before the entry of Fox News and MSNBC, we train a LASSO model to predict (within-wave z -scored) news and entertainment viewership based on the demographic variables available in MRI.¹⁸ We use this model to generate predicted news and entertainment viewership for respondents in 1998 and 1999, the first survey waves for which we have viewership data for Fox and MSNBC. In this post-entry sample, we then regress (within-wave z -scored)

¹⁷Appendix Table B3 shows that the estimate is robust to other constructions of broadcast availability, including measuring *contemporaneous* (same-slot) broadcast availability rather than the average broadcast availability of the slot and measuring availability as the average *fraction* of ABC, CBS, or NBC news availability rather than as the average of an indicator for whether any of these three networks are available. Given that broadcast news occupies a thinner and less continuous schedule, we are underpowered to investigate the analogous effects of cultural content on viewership for *broadcast* news. This is particularly true using our preferred event-study approach, which drops over two-thirds of observations because most observations do not fall in a continuously observed 14-day window ($t-7, \dots, t+6$). Following the static specification robustness check employed in Section B.1, which closely replicated the primary event-study coefficient, we estimate a static version of Equation 1 setting $P = 0$. Panel C of Appendix Table B2 presents results; the confidence intervals are too wide to reject coefficient equality.

¹⁸The variables are age, education, income, household composition, race, gender, marital status, presence of children, Hispanic ethnicity, employment status, satellite access, county size, and Census region. We also use ZIP codes to merge in and include as predictors the DMA-level demographic and socioeconomic characteristics we use as market-level controls throughout the paper: racial and age shares, log population, the unemployment rate, labor-force participation, and log income per capita.

indicators for respondents' self-reported viewership of each product jointly on predicted entertainment viewership and predicted news viewership, with survey-wave fixed effects. For a given product, these two coefficients capture the extent to which its early viewers comprised the demographic groups previously watching news and those previously watching entertainment.

Figure 7 plots each product's pair of coefficients, with confidence intervals accounting for the generated regressors by bootstrapping both stages. The flagship evening newscasts of ABC, CBS, and NBC cluster tightly: their viewership loads strongly on predicted news viewership and negatively on predicted entertainment viewership. A useful comparison is news-format radio, which likewise loads on predicted news but not predicted entertainment viewership. Entertainment networks such as ESPN and HBO, in contrast, load positively on predicted entertainment viewership and negatively on predicted news viewership. The two cable entrants sit around halfway between entertainment and broadcast news: viewership of Fox News is essentially unrelated to predicted news viewership, and Fox News loads on predicted entertainment viewership as strongly as the entertainment networks, while MSNBC is essentially unrelated to both. In line with its lack of cultural emphasis during this period (Section 3.2.1), CNN behaves like a broadcast news division, loading strongly on predicted news viewership and negatively on predicted entertainment viewership. Appendix Figure B11b extends the exercise to all networks in the MRI viewership module and shows similar patterns.

Together, the contemporaneous household-by-second results and the historical consumer survey results suggest that cable news outlets have pursued a long-running strategy of mobilizing consumers who would otherwise watch entertainment, and that this strategy is driven by the distinctive incentives generated by cable's 24-hour news model.

5.3 Returns to culture for politicians

We next turn toward the comparison between cable news outlets and politicians. In addition to potential differences in the number of mobilizable vs. poachable consumers these two agents face, there is also an important difference in objectives. A political candidate maximizes her vote *margin* ($\omega \approx 1$) and so values poached voters twice as much as mobilized voters. An outlet approximately maximizes its number of viewers ($\omega \approx 0$) and so is roughly indifferent between a poached vs. a mobilized viewer.¹⁹

If in politics — as in cable news — economic appeals are relatively more effective for poaching and cultural appeals relatively more effective for mobilizing, then economics should be relatively more effective and culture relatively less effective in politics, and this difference in objectives could help explain why politicians choose a greater share of economic content and a lower share of cultural content in their campaign advertising.

This section examines whether, indeed, economics is more effective for poaching but less effective for mobilization in political campaigns, as it is on cable news; and whether, given politicians' differing objective functions, economics is relatively better for winning elections. Since we lack a credible source of exogenous variation in campaign emphasis, we view both analyses as suggestive.

¹⁹As shown in Appendix G, the comparative statics do not require that the candidate's ω is exactly 1 or that the outlet's ω is exactly 0. Candidates may value poaching less than twice as much as mobilizing if, for example, mobilized voters are more likely to donate or volunteer. Outlets may value poached viewers more than mobilized viewers if, for example, ad revenue is determined in part by their viewership share of news in addition to their total viewership. We require only that candidates value poached consumers, relative to mobilized consumers, more than outlets do.

Empirical approach The sample includes Democratic and Republican general-election nominees in contested races in which the top two candidates each air at least one campaign ad after the primary. We estimate various specifications of:

$$V_{ist} = \beta x_{ist} + g'_{ist} \phi + \varepsilon_{ist}, \quad (5)$$

where i is a unique candidate, s a seat, t an election year, and V_{ist} is the outcome of interest: either an indicator for whether the candidate won their race, or a measure of the campaign’s effectiveness for poaching or mobilization. The explanatory variable of interest is x_{ist} , relative cultural advertising, defined analogously to the relative cultural emphasis of news: the cultural share minus the economic share of the campaign’s advertising, divided by the sum of its cultural, economic, process, and mixed advertising and standardized within office. The controls g include party-by-seat fixed effects (e.g., Democratic House candidates in Louisiana’s 4th), party-by-office-by-year fixed effects (e.g., Democratic House candidates in 2006), incumbency-by-office controls, time-varying constituency demographic and economic controls interacted with party, economic controls interacted with an incumbency indicator, and party interactions with three outcomes from the same seat’s previous election: the party’s two-party vote share, the share of the eligible population voting for the highest-vote opponent, and the share of the eligible population either abstaining or voting for another candidate. Candidates are weighted by constituency population.²⁰ The specification therefore examines whether candidates who run more culturally focused campaigns perform better or worse, compared to (1) other campaigns for the same seat by the same party in other years, and to (2) other campaigns for different seats by the same party in the same year.

The identifying variation in content may reflect misoptimization, idiosyncratic campaign decisions, or politicians’ personal preferences.²¹ The variation may also include potential confounders, despite the rich controls: for example, candidates who are less skilled campaigners may both perform worse in elections and tend to air more cultural ads; or candidates who expect to lose may turn to culture as a higher-variance strategy.

Results Table 1 presents our preferred specification. Column 1 shows that — unlike the cultural viewership *premium* estimated for cable news — we estimate, if anything, a cultural campaign *penalty*: a one-standard-deviation increase in relative cultural content is associated with an approximately 5.0 percentage-point lower probability of winning (s.e. 1.9). Although we cannot observe individual-level switching behavior as we can in the viewership data, we construct politician-side analogs of poaching and mobilization by separately analyzing the association between campaign content and the negative of the highest-vote other candidate’s votes per eligible voter (“poaching”) and the negative of the abstention and third-party share (“mobilization”). As in Section 4.4, we also construct a scalar “diversion” statistic, mobilization minus poaching, so that (as on cable) higher values indicate content relatively more effective for mobilizing than for poaching. Columns 2–4 report results. A one-standard-deviation increase in relative cultural content

²⁰The demographic controls are log population, log population density, and the population shares without a high school degree, with a bachelor’s degree, with a postgraduate degree, ages 18–34, 35–54, 55–64, and 65 and older, Black, male, rural, Evangelical, and Hispanic. The economic controls are labor-force participation, the unemployment rate, and log per-capita income.

²¹A body of research documents that political campaign strategists are no better at predicting which messages will be effective than laypeople (Broockman et al., 2024), that politicians hold systematic misperceptions about voters (Furnas and LaPira, 2024; Lucas et al., 2025), and that campaigns and advertising intermediaries are dominated by unrepresentative groups of highly active and vocal constituents, volunteers, and staffers (Martin and Peskowitz, 2018; Ward, 2021; Laurison, 2022) who may hold different preferences from everyday citizens.

is associated with 0.59 percentage points less poaching (s.e. 0.16), and a 0.41 percentage-point increase in mobilization (s.e. 0.20), with their difference a positive 1.0 percentage-point diversion estimate (s.e. 0.32).²²

Appendix C presents a number of additional specifications and robustness checks. Across specifications and subsamples, we find no consistent evidence that cultural campaigns are more electorally successful; in fact, we estimate a cultural campaign *penalty* in most, but not all, specifications. We also find that culture is robustly associated with greater mobilization and lower poaching relative to economics, though the effects are driven by statewide rather than House races. Cultural messaging is not simply a proxy for ideological extremity: while cultural messaging is weakly correlated with ideological extremity, more extreme candidates are *more* likely to win primaries but less likely to win the general election, whereas more cultural candidates are less successful in both stages (Appendix Table C3). Examining heterogeneity over time (Appendix Table C2), we find that these estimated *marginal* effects are stable even as the *level* of cultural messaging increases substantially.

These results must be interpreted with caution given the nature of the underlying variation, but we conclude that there is no evidence for a cultural premium in politics of the kind we estimate for cable news. The patterns are consistent with culture in politics being more effective for mobilization and economics more effective for poaching — as in cable news — but poaching being a relatively more important determinant of electoral victory than of cable viewership, as the basic difference between audience *size* and vote *margin* maximization suggests.

5.4 Quantitative decomposition

The comparisons above explain content differences between cable news and broadcast news through differences in the *composition* of their potential viewers — the relative numbers of mobilizable and poachable viewers each faces — and the differences between cable news and politicians through differences in their *objectives* — the relative value each places on a poached vs. a mobilized consumer. Naturally, cable, broadcast, and politicians differ along many other dimensions which could plausibly explain differences in content. To assess whether the two mechanisms we emphasize are quantitatively meaningful, we estimate a structural model of household viewing and network content choice, and we use the model to simulate two counterfactuals: how cable’s content would differ if it faced the same potential viewers as broadcast news outlets’ evening newscasts, and how it would differ if it faced politicians’ objective function.

The reduced-form evidence is already suggestive. On the cable–broadcast comparison, Figure 6 shows that cable’s relative cultural content falls from 0.22 at the 10th percentile of broadcast news availability to 0.14 at the 90th percentile of broadcast news availability, closing the entire cable–broadcast content gap. On the cable–politician comparison, Appendix Figure B10 shows that although airing cultural content increases own viewership, it increases viewership of competitors by almost as much: if cable maximized its viewership *margin* over its competitors rather than its total viewership, it would find cultural content significantly less appealing.

Our approach is to specify the simplest possible model that allows us to capture the nontrivial substitution patterns required to generate differential poaching vs. mobilization responses to cultural content, and to identify this model using the reduced-form moments already presented. We describe the model briefly here,

²²The results are consistent either with economic content being more effective than culture at poaching opponents’ voters or with economic content being less prone to “countermobilize” people who would otherwise abstain into voting for the candidate’s opponent. As shown in Appendix G, however, both outcomes enter the politician’s objective with additional weight ω , so the prediction that margin-maximizing politicians have lower payoffs from culture is unchanged.

relegating details to Appendix H.

Household demand Every minute, households choose among eight mutually exclusive options: television off, non-news entertainment, each of the three cable news networks (CNN, Fox News, MSNBC), and, in timeslots when they air, the national newscasts of the three broadcast networks (ABC, CBS, NBC). Households choose the option maximizing:

$$u_{idm|o} = a_{imod} + \beta_i r_{dm|o} + \varepsilon_{idm|o}. \quad (6)$$

Here, a_{imod} absorbs all non-content determinants of household i 's likelihood of choosing option d in each minute of fifteen-minute timeslot m , given their viewing state o at the start of the minute; and β_i reflects household i 's preference for relative cultural content. Households do not perfectly observe a network's realized relative cultural content, $r_{dm} \in [-1, 1]$, unless they are already tuned in; if they are not tuned in, they instead form an expectation over the realized content given their information set $\mathcal{I}_{dm}$. Households therefore react to *perceived* relative cultural content, given the household's current state o :

$$r_{dm|o} = \begin{cases} r_{dm}, & d = o, \\ q_{dm} \equiv \mathbb{E}[r_{dm} | \mathcal{I}_{dm}], & d \neq o. \end{cases} \quad (7)$$

We can place the expectation operator inside the expression for utility since utility is linear in content. We assume prospective viewers hold rational expectations conditional on their information. The identifying assumption is the same as in the reduced-form analyses of Section 4: that the controls absorb predictable variation in content and viewing demand, so that residual content innovations reflect unpredictable idiosyncratic shocks. This assumption is largely testable by examining the extent to which more cultural content, conditional on the controls, predicts *inflows* into a network rather than simply persistence conditional on tuning in: if so, households have information about network content not absorbed by the controls. Appendix H estimates a richer model that allows households that are not watching a network to receive a signal about the network's realized content, ranging from perfectly uninformative to perfectly informative, and shows that the estimated precision of the signal is close to zero in all years, justifying the identifying assumption.

We parametrize $\varepsilon_{idm|o}$ as an i.i.d. type-I extreme value shock, so that choice probabilities take the standard logit form:

$$P_{imod} = \frac{\exp(a_{imod} + \beta_i r_{dm|o})}{\sum_j \exp(a_{imoj} + \beta_i r_{jm|o})}. \quad (8)$$

Each household's cultural taste β_i is fixed, regardless of its current viewing choice. Nevertheless, aggregate poaching and mobilization will respond differently to network d 's content if households on the "poaching" margin between d and a competing news network — meaning they have high probabilities of watching each — have different cultural tastes β_i than households on the "mobilization" margin between network d and the outside option of not watching news. The primary objective of our demand estimation exercise is therefore to estimate the joint distribution of cultural tastes and households' positions on these two margins.

We parametrize $\beta_i = z_i' \theta$, where z_i is a vector of summary statistics capturing household i 's viewing behavior (Appendix Table H2). We then estimate θ by minimum distance, choosing coefficients so that the model reproduces the key reduced-form moments documented in Sections 4 and 5.2 (Appendix Table H3): the effect of relative cultural content on viewership (Figure 4), switching to competing news networks and to

the outside option (Figure 5), the effect on total seconds watched of competing news networks and the outside option (Appendix Figure B10), the interactions of these returns with broadcast availability (Figure 6), and, separately for each network, the effect of its content on the viewership of competing news networks and of the outside option.

Network supply Each network k chooses how its political airtime is allocated between economic content, cultural content, and mixed/process (“other”) content: shares $p_k = (p_{kE}, p_{kC}, p_{kO})$ summing to one, so that network k ’s relative cultural content is $r_k = p_{kC} - p_{kE}$. We take the observed amount of political time as given rather than modeling the allocation of time between political and nonpolitical content. As in Equation 2, network k ’s payoff is given by:

$$\Pi_k := V_k - \omega \sum_{j \in N, j \neq k} V_j - C_k(p_k), \quad (9)$$

where V_j is alternative j ’s expected audience under the estimated household demand model, given the networks’ content, C_k is the cost of producing content p_k , and ω encodes the network’s objective: $\omega = 0$ is audience maximization, under which the network equally values a viewer poached from a competing news outlet and one mobilized from not watching news, and $\omega = 1$ values each poached viewer twice as much as each mobilized one.

We recover marginal costs at observed choices using the network’s first-order condition, requiring the observed mix p_k^0 to be optimal given observed audience returns and the airtime constraint: $\frac{\partial}{\partial p_{kE}} \Pi_k = \frac{\partial}{\partial p_{kC}} \Pi_k = \frac{\partial}{\partial p_{kO}} \Pi_k$. At the observed mix, differences in marginal costs exactly offset the audience value of moving a unit of airtime between two formats.

The supply-side parameter determining the size of the content response in the counterfactual exercises is the convexity of costs C_k . If marginal costs are close to constant as the network repositions further away from the observed mix, then small changes in the payoffs to mobilizing vs. poaching content will have large effects on content; if marginal costs quickly increase, then changes in content will be smaller. To estimate cost convexity, we assume that costs can be written as the sum of a network-specific component that is linear in the mix and a common convex component:

$$C_k(p_k) = \sum_a c_{ka} p_{ka} + \tau \sum_a p_{ka} \ln p_{ka}, \quad (10)$$

where the c_{ka} are persistent network–format cost levels (e.g. the talent, production, and scheduling commitments underlying each format) and the parameter $\tau > 0$ governs convexity: format a ’s marginal cost, $c_{ka} + \tau(1 + \ln p_{ka})$, rises in the share already allocated to it, so the first stories moved between formats are those at the margin and further repositioning grows increasingly costly. Appendix H.2 microfound this functional form in a model where networks select from a pool of potential stories, each with an idiosyncratic quality shock.

When a counterfactual changes the marginal audience value of relative cultural content, $\partial(V_k - \omega \sum_{j \neq k} V_j) / \partial r_k$, by an amount Δ_k , subtracting the observed first-order condition from its counterfactual counterpart yields the new mix directly from the observed one,

$$p_{kC} \propto p_{kC}^0 e^{\Delta_k / \tau}, \quad p_{kE} \propto p_{kE}^0 e^{-\Delta_k / \tau}, \quad p_{kO} \propto p_{kO}^0, \quad (11)$$

with the shares renormalized to sum to one. Near the observed mix, a change Δ_k moves relative cultural content by $(p_{kE}^0 + p_{kC}^0 - (r_k^0)^2) \Delta_k / \tau$.

We estimate curvature τ using the observed variation across timeslots in Panels A and B of Figure 6. In particular, τ is identified by equating the ratio of the two gradients — how much scheduled content falls with availability, relative to how much the return falls — to the model’s local response. The identifying assumption is therefore a supply-side exclusion restriction: conditional on the determinants of audience demand captured in the model, broadcast-news availability shifts cable’s incentives to air cultural rather than economic content but does not itself shift the relative marginal cost of supplying those types of content. One way to interpret the assumption is that programming can be reallocated across times of day without a systematic change in its relative production cost — for example, Fox News could, if it chose, move *Tucker Carlson Tonight* from the evening to the morning without changing its relative cost of producing cultural vs. economic content. Under this exclusion restriction, the observed scheduling response to broadcast availability identifies the curvature governing how content responds to changes in audience incentives. This assumption is clearly false in the short-run, given show-specific investments in hosts, production teams, and other input factors; it is more plausible in the long-run, such that networks can reallocate these input factors across timeslots.

Counterfactual 1: cable facing the flagship newscast’s potential viewers Our first counterfactual asks how cable’s content would change if it faced the same composition of potential viewers as do broadcast outlets’ evening network newscasts. We use the demand model to calculate how each cable network’s audience return to cultural content changes when, in all of their slots, we replace the population of households with their TVs on with the population with TVs on at 6:30pm, when broadcasters’ evening newscasts air. We otherwise hold household tastes, cable’s audience-size objective, and costs fixed and recompute cable networks’ optimal content choice. As shown in the first row of Table 2, cable’s relative cultural content falls from 0.199 to 0.145, closing 62 percent of the cable–broadcast gap.

Counterfactual 2: cable with a politician’s objective Our second counterfactual instead raises ω (outlets’ weight on viewers of competing news outlets) from zero to one, so that each cable network values a viewer poached from rival news twice as much as one mobilized from entertainment or from television off. As shown in the second row of Table 2, cable’s relative cultural content falls from 0.199 to 0.042, closing 27 percent of the cable–politician gap.

Appendix Figure H1 reports how both magnitudes vary with the cost curvature τ .

5.5 Decomposing economics vs. culture

Validating the economic vs. cultural distinction As assigning each topic to an “economic” or “cultural” group is inherently subjective, Appendix E presents four exercises examining the robustness of the findings to alternative choices. First, we form a matrix of our topic-level empirical results in which each row is a topic and the six columns are the cable–broadcast and cable–politician differences in that topic’s estimated emphasis, performance, and diversion. We plot the topics’ loadings on the first two principal components of this matrix to show that topics we label economic separate clearly from those we label cultural. Second, we show the estimates remain robust under a variety of reasonable alternative family codings, including more restrictive definitions of the cultural and economic families focused on narrowly policy-focused topics. The third and fourth exercises discard the schema, reestimating every topic-level regression instead using features discovered from raw text via an open-weights sparse autoencoder, a model that embeds inputs using a feature

space corresponding to human-interpretable concepts (McDougall et al., 2025). The third exercise uses a large language model to label each of these features’ topic families, contrasting features labeled as economic with those labeled as cultural; the fourth exercise dispenses with family assignments altogether and relates features’ estimated diversion to their emphasis and performance. Both exercises indicate that the empirical findings are not driven by the idiosyncratic construction of our schema.

Unbundling mechanisms Cultural and economic topics may differ in many ways, among them simplicity (Acemoglu et al., 2026) and emotionality (Gennaro and Ash, 2022; Cruz et al., 2026). Disentangling why cultural content is more effective for mobilization and economic content for poaching is beyond the scope of this paper. Nonetheless, in Appendix E.5 we measure the emotional arousal, emotional valence, and linguistic complexity of each news segment and each ad using off-the-shelf approaches (Mohammad, 2025; Graeber et al., 2024), and we compare these dimensions between economic and cultural topics. In cable news, broadcast news, and political advertising alike, cultural content is more emotionally arousing, more negatively valenced, and linguistically simpler. However, adding all these measures and their interactions with content to our baseline specifications only very slightly attenuates the estimates. We view further decomposition of the bundles constituting cultural and economic messaging as an avenue for future work.

6 Changes in Issue Importance

In this section, we turn from the determinants of cable news’ greater emphasis on cultural content to the effects of cable news on the importance of cultural issues in politics. In particular, we show that people in geographies exogenously more exposed to cable news report placing greater importance on cultural issues and lower importance on economic issues, and we show that political candidates supply more cultural and less economic rhetoric.

As described in Section 2.3, we construct the measure of voter priorities from responses to Gallup’s Most Important Problem question. This measure of voter priorities is correlated with political rhetoric, as shown in Appendix Figure D1: markets whose residents report greater relative cultural concerns also receive more culturally focused candidate advertising, a relationship that survives with unit and time fixed effects.

6.1 Empirical approach

To isolate exogenous variation in cable news viewership, we use the instrumental variables approach pioneered by Martin and Yurukoglu (2017). The logic of the instrument is as follows. The 210 Nielsen Designated Market Areas in the United States vary in their assignment of different networks to different channel numbers. The process by which MSNBC and Fox News were assigned channels was, conditional on a basic set of controls, random: Martin and Yurukoglu (2017), and follow-up work (Simonov et al., 2022; Ash et al., 2024), show that channel numbers are orthogonal to a wide range of demographic characteristics. Fox News and MSNBC receive higher viewership in areas in which they are assigned a lower channel number: since other popular networks tend to have low channel numbers, viewers who “channel-surf” are more likely to watch more Fox News or MSNBC when these networks are placed near the popular networks. We match respondents with Nielsen data on the channel numbers and the average viewership of Fox News and MSNBC in their DMA. The endogenous variable of interest is the sum of the networks’ viewership, which

we instrument with the sum of their channel numbers.²³

The individual-level Most Important Problem estimates use various specifications of:

$$y_{imt} = \beta \widehat{R}_{mt} + C_i \eta + Z_{mt} \sigma + \varepsilon_{imt}, \quad (12)$$

where y_{imt} is the individual's stated importance of cultural issues relative to economic issues, $\widehat{R}_{mt}$ is the fitted value of the networks' combined rating in media market m in year t , C_i is a vector of individual-level controls, and Z_{mt} is a vector of media-market-by-year-level controls. We map the respondent's first reported answer to our schema (see Appendix Table A2), assigning a value of 1 to cultural topics, -1 to economic topics, and 0 to process and mixed responses. We cluster standard errors by DMA.

Since campaign advertising is at the district level for House candidates, and at the state level for gubernatorial and Senate candidates, we average cable news viewership and channel numbers over counties to form constituency-level measures. We then estimate various specifications of:

$$x_{ist} = \beta \widehat{R}_{st} + C_{it} \eta + Z_{st} \sigma + \varepsilon_{ist}, \quad (13)$$

where x_{ist} is the average content of politician i 's advertisements in election year t , $\widehat{R}_{st}$ is the fitted average combined rating of the two networks across all counties that comprise i 's constituency, s , instrumented by the average channel numbers across all markets in $s(i)$ and standardized, C_{it} is a vector of politician-by-year-level controls, and Z_{st} is a vector of constituency-by-year-level controls. Because constituencies often span multiple DMAs, we conservatively cluster standard errors at the state level.

For both measures, we report Anderson–Rubin p -values, 95% credible intervals calculated via a Bayesian bootstrap clustered at the same level as the analytic standard errors (media market for Most Important Problem, state for advertising) (Rubin, 1981; Andrews and Shapiro, 2026), and randomization-inference (RI) p -values obtained by permuting the Fox News and MSNBC channel positions jointly across markets and summing them within each draw.

6.2 Results

Voter priorities We present estimates on voter priorities in Table 3. Column 1 controls for year fixed effects, individual-level demographic controls, and the demographic controls listed in Section 5.3, measured for the respondent's county. Column 2 adds the economic controls listed in Section 5.3. Column 3, our preferred specification, replaces the year fixed effects with year-by-state fixed effects. Column 4 additionally controls for partisanship, adding the county's lagged Republican presidential vote share, indicators for each respondent's choice on a five-point party alignment scale, and year-by-respondent-party fixed effects. County and respondent-level partisanship is a “bad control” in the sense that increases in a county's or voter's relative weight on culture are likely to affect their voting behavior; we nevertheless find it valuable to assess whether the results are distinct from the well-established effect of cable viewership on voting (Della Vigna and Kaplan, 2007; Martin and Yurukoglu, 2017).

The estimated effects are positive throughout. In our preferred specification in Column 3, a one-standard-deviation increase in viewership raises the stated importance of cultural issues relative to economic issues by 0.059 standard deviations (s.e. 0.027, RI $p = 0.018$). Conditioning on partisanship in Column 4 slightly attenuates the coefficient, but it remains marginally significant (RI $p = 0.084$). Equivalently, increasing

²³Appendix Table D2 shows that entering the two channel positions separately yields similar estimates.

ratings by 10% of the mean has an effect of 0.016 standard deviations.²⁴ The results are robust to alternative constructions of the voter priorities measure (Appendix Table D3) and are not driven by any one state (Appendix Figure D2).

Political ads We next present estimates on political appeals in Table 4. Column 1 includes office-by-year fixed effects, an incumbency indicator with office-specific slopes, and the demographic controls listed in Section 5.3. Column 2 replaces the office-by-year fixed effects with party-by-office-by-year fixed effects. Column 3 adds the economic controls listed in Section 5.3, and Column 4 adds lagged constituency voting. As in Table 1, Column 5 restricts to races in which both the candidate and the candidate’s strongest opponent aired advertising; and Column 6 adds both candidates’ ideological extremity and campaign advertising volume.

Across specifications, a one-standard-deviation increase in cable viewership increases politicians’ relative cultural emphasis by 0.43 to 0.48 within-office standard deviations (s.e. 0.14 to 0.21). These estimates are stable across specifications and remain significant when we control for candidates’ ideological extremity or lagged constituency voting. In our preferred specification of Column 3, the estimate is 0.44 (s.e. 0.15; RI $p = 0.010$): increasing ratings by 10% of the mean raises candidates’ relative cultural advertising by 0.14 within-office standard deviations. The order-of-magnitude difference relative to the effects on Most Important Problems is in part driven by the different units of aggregation (individual-level MIPs vs. constituency-level advertising). Re-estimating the effects on Most Important Problems at the level of a DMA, discarding individual-level variation and thus rescaling by the smaller cross-DMA standard deviation, results in a coefficient estimate of 0.08 standard deviations. As with MIPs, Appendix Figure D2 shows that the effects are not driven by any one state.

6.3 Interpretation

Limitations An important limitation of these analyses is that they identify the aggregate effect of exposure to cable news on Most Important Problems and candidate advertising, not the direct effect of cultural coverage on cable news. Other distinctive features of Fox and MSNBC’s programming, such as their partisan slant or use of outrage, narrative, or opinion, may also be important. However, the fact that controlling for voting does not eliminate estimated effects, and that the estimated viewership effects of cultural content only slightly attenuate when controlling for emotional register or lexical simplicity (Appendix E.5), is suggestive of a direct effect. A second limitation is that we cannot disentangle the extent to which the changes in politicians’ campaign advertising are a reaction to their constituents’ changing preferences vs. a direct result of the politician’s own viewership of cable, among other explanations.

Heterogeneity and disaggregation Exploring dynamics in Appendix Figure D3 by plotting binned scatterplots (Cattaneo et al., 2024) of the reduced-form relationship between channel numbers and both outcomes, we find that cross-sectional differences emerge as early as 2000–2007, but the variation decreases over time. This decreased cross-sectional variation is consistent with a combination of increasing cable ratings and diminishing marginal effects, though it may also reflect a number of other factors, including increasing nationalization of politics (e.g. Angelucci et al. 2023).

²⁴We use ratings averaged over all hours of day, which are therefore much lower than the standard reported primetime ratings.

Appendix Tables D4 and D5 estimate the effects of Fox News and MSNBC separately. The effects of Fox News are of a similar magnitude to the pooled estimates for both outcomes. For voter priorities, the MSNBC estimates are much less precise and are not statistically significant in our preferred specification; for candidate advertising, the MSNBC estimates are larger than the Fox estimates and remain significant.

We present estimates for all topics in Appendix Figure D4. These effects must be interpreted with caution given the wide confidence intervals and, given that the Most Important Problem captures the respondent's single most salient concern, nontrivial substitution patterns between topics. The estimates generally suggest decreased economic and increased cultural concerns and political advertising, though the patterns are less consistent than the topic-level results of Section 4.

Magnitudes We conduct a back-of-the-envelope exercise using the cross-sectional variation exploited in the preceding IV tables to illustrate the magnitude of the estimates relative to observed levels. To conduct this exercise, we convert the estimated effects of viewership of Fox News, MSNBC, or both together on voters' Most Important Problem (Appendix Table D4) or on politicians' campaign ads (Appendix Table D5) into unstandardized effects per rating point, and multiply these by each network's mean viewership in 2020. We then subtract this value from the observed endpoint, reporting the resulting levels in Appendix Table D6. Removing both networks shifts the relative cultural MIP measure from 0.06 to -0.06 , equal to 38% of the observed change since the pre-Fox 1996 baseline of -0.27 . This change also shifts the relative cultural advertising measure from -0.18 to -0.72 , accounting for slightly *more* than the observed change since the normalized 2000 baseline of -0.65 .

We view this calculation as suggestive given the strong assumptions it requires: in particular, we are unable to account for time-series changes in the parties' positions, election outcomes, and the many other national shocks affecting voter priorities and political advertising.

7 Discussion

This paper links recent growth in political conflict on cultural issues — the “culture war” — to changes in the landscape of entertainment and news media competition in the 1980s and 1990s. We use high-frequency television viewership data matched with news content to estimate audience preferences over different news topics, enabling us to characterize the distinctive incentives facing 24-hour cable news outlets and the culture-war-centered business strategy they employed to respond to these incentives. We show why the analogous business strategy is structurally disadvantaged for the older broadcast outlets and for politicians, helping explain the rise in the importance of cultural issues since the entry of Fox News and MSNBC in 1996.

International perspective Most Western liberal democracies have experienced political realignment patterns that appear to reflect growth in the salience of cultural issues (Gethin et al., 2022; Danieli et al., 2024; Gennaro et al., 2024). Two natural explanations for recent international political trends are social media (e.g. Guriev et al. 2021; Campante et al. 2018; Zhuravskaya et al. 2020) and globalization and economic displacement (Norris and Inglehart, 2019; Ash et al., 2021; Gennaioli and Tabellini, 2025). While both factors may plausibly have contributed to cultural trends in American politics, there are two reasons to doubt they account for the full story. First, the US — in which 24-hour TV news plays a disproportionately large role — experienced an earlier, sharper, and broader rise in cultural political divisions than other countries. The US is an outlier in terms of affective and partisan polarization (Boxell et al., 2024; Desmet et al.,

2025), populist cultural values (Iversen and Soskice, 2020), urban–rural voting divides (Taylor et al., 2024), trust in the news media and the partisan gap in trust (Newman et al., 2021; Burn-Murdoch, 2024), and the percentage of respondents reporting that the country is in a “culture war” (Duffy et al., 2021), and the less frequent disputes that emerge in other countries over guns, abortion, policing, religion, and gay rights often appear directly exported from the US (The Economist, 2021).²⁵ Second, in Appendix I, we examine the effects of Twitter (following the strategy of Müller and Schwarz 2023; Fujiwara et al. 2024) and the effects of the “China shock” (following Autor et al. 2013, 2020) on cultural Most Important Problems and cultural campaign advertising, and we find no consistent evidence of increases in cultural importance across specifications and outcomes.

Domestic perspective We conclude with a more speculative application of the “poaching” vs. “mobilization” framework beyond cable news, broadcast news, and politicians. The incentives of many other political actors are, as for cable news, better characterized by *size*- rather than *margin*-maximization. Membership- or contribution-based interest groups, organizers of protests and social movements, and social media personalities are all likely to favor mobilizing strategies that diverge from politicians’ poaching-focused messaging, and in some instances may actively undermine it (Hacker and Pierson, 2020; Wasow, 2020). Holding the relative costs of mobilization and poaching fixed across domains, these size-maximizing actors may be more likely to lead issue realignment and polarization, with politicians adhering to the median of status-quo political cleavages until voter preferences change enough to warrant a pivot in campaign strategy.²⁶

This perspective sheds light on several episodes of cultural polarization in American politics since World War II. In the 1960s, activist groups raised the salience of polarizing social issues such as civil rights, feminism, and the Vietnam War. Fault lines over these issues initially cross-cut partisan divisions among both legislators and citizens (Mason, 2018): for example, the Democratic Party contained a segregationist wing and the Republican Party a racially liberal wing. The Democratic Party’s decision to incorporate the socially progressive movements of this era and the Republican Party’s pivot toward embracing anti-counterculture backlash, law and order, and Southern racial grievances aligned these cultural divisions with partisan ones (Carmines and Stimson, 1989; Kuziemko and Washington, 2018); but the initial salience of the divisions was driven by size-maximizing actors, not politicians (Wang, 2021; Noel, 2014).

The same is true of the cultural polarization of the 1980s and 1990s, which originated largely with televangelists and Religious Right movement leaders who were eventually incorporated into the Republican Party and with the partisan talk radio shows unleashed by the 1987 abolition of the Fairness Doctrine (Schlozman, 2015; Pienkny, 2025). Indeed, narrative accounts suggest that hosts such as Rush Limbaugh emphasized cultural grievances precisely to attract listeners dissatisfied with existing news options (Sherman, 2014; Hemmer, 2022), with quasi-experimental evidence showing that these shows affected listeners’ political attitudes and behavior (Amarasinghe and Raschky, 2022; Pienkny, 2025). Most emblematic of the mechanism highlighted in this paper is Pat Buchanan, a popular television commentator and unsuccessful presidential candidate who popularized the term “culture war” in his 1992 speech at the Republican National Convention

²⁵On the polarizing effects of social media, or the lack thereof, see, e.g., Levy (2021); Allcott et al. (2020); Nyhan et al. (2023), and the survey in Aridor et al. (2024). On the political effects of economic displacement, see, e.g., Fetzer (2019); Colantone and Stanig (2018); Dippel et al. (2022), and the survey in Guriev and Papaioannou (2022). Boxell et al. (2024) find that trends in affective polarization are positively correlated with growth in the number of private 24-hour news channels in the country, whereas they are negatively correlated with growth in inequality or the share of the population accessing news online.

²⁶The aggregate electoral effects are likely to depend on which party is trusted more on (or “owns”) the issues which grow in salience (Therriault, 2015). In the United States, the Republican Party holds an advantage on many cultural issues and the Democratic Party on many economic issues (Egan, 2013).

(Buchanan, 1992). Through the lens of this paper, Buchanan's emphasis on cultural issues likely contributed both to his media success and to his electoral defeat. Despite the failure of Buchanan's presidential campaigns, historical accounts (e.g., Hemmer 2022; Ganz 2024) trace many of the key planks of Trumpism to Buchanan and other "size-maximizing" media figures who raised the salience of cultural issues decades before parties began centering them more explicitly in their campaigns.

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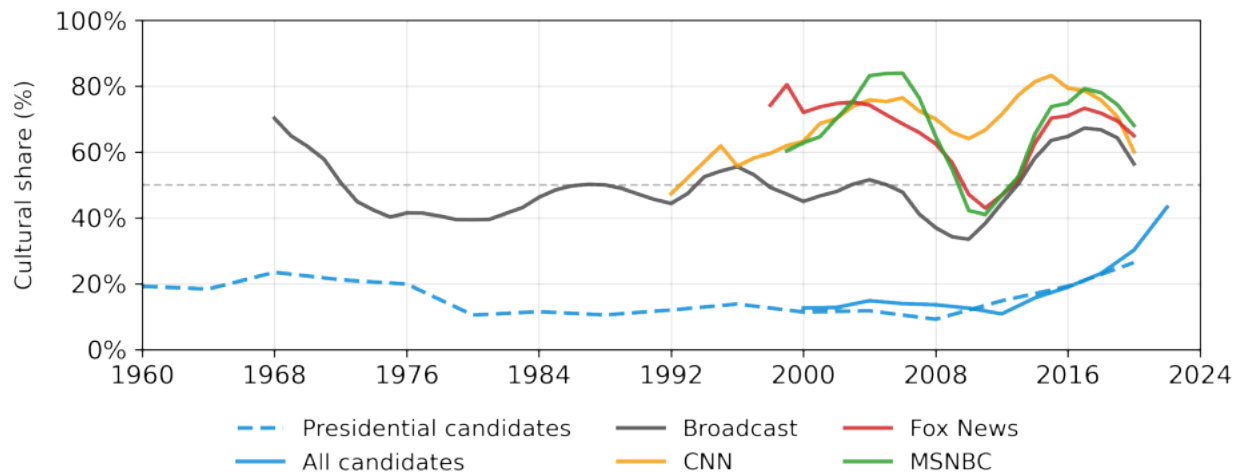
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Figure 1: Cultural share of cultural and economic content in television news and campaign ads



Notes: In each year, Figure 1 plots cultural content as a share of all content classified as either cultural or economic. As described in Section 2, the broadcast series uses segment abstracts from the Vanderbilt Television News Archive until 2014 and TVArchive recordings thereafter. The cable series uses Vanderbilt segment abstracts and LexisNexis transcripts until 2014 and TVArchive recordings thereafter. The political candidate series uses the Kanter Political Commercial Archive, which includes only presidential ads, until 1999, and the Wisconsin and Wesleyan Media Projects, which add gubernatorial and congressional ads, thereafter. Topic assignments are described in Appendix A. Cable and broadcast series are smoothed with four-year rolling means.

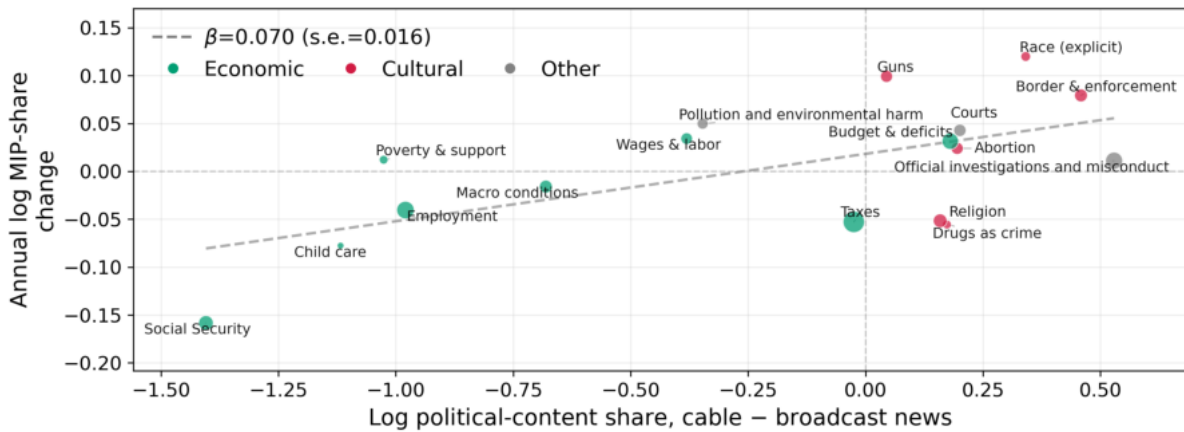
Figure 2: Topic prevalence in cable news relative to political ads and broadcast news



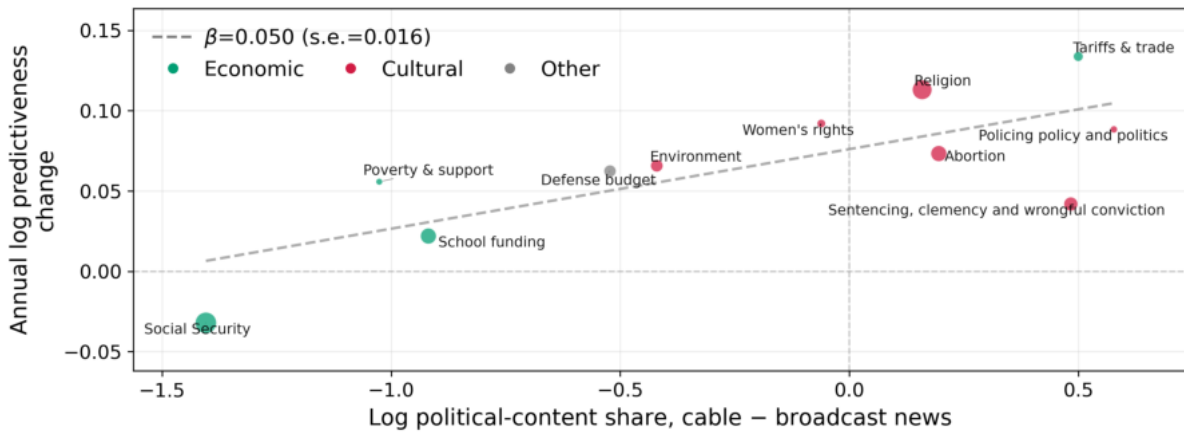
Notes: Each point is a topic's cable prevalence divided by its prevalence in broadcast news (Panel A) or political ads (Panel B). The figure plots only the 80 most prevalent topics across all three domains (out of 259 topics total), restricting to topics appearing in more than 0.05% of all three domains. Green, red, and gray denote economic, cultural, and "other" topics, respectively. We plot 95% confidence intervals. Shares exclude nonpolitical codes and special, empty, or missing content.

Figure 3: Cable–broadcast coverage gaps and change in different measures of issue importance

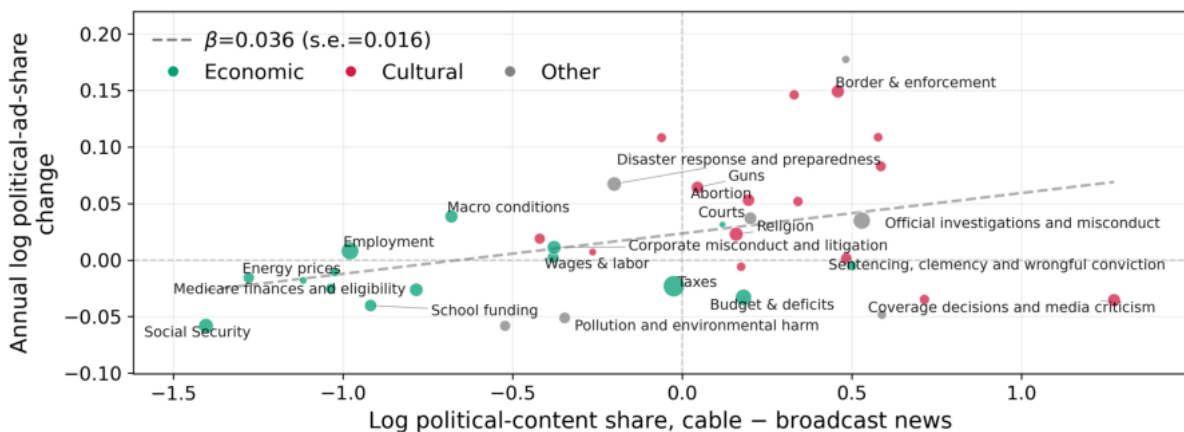
(a) Growth in perceived importance (Gallup “Most Important Problem”)



(b) Growth in predictiveness for voting



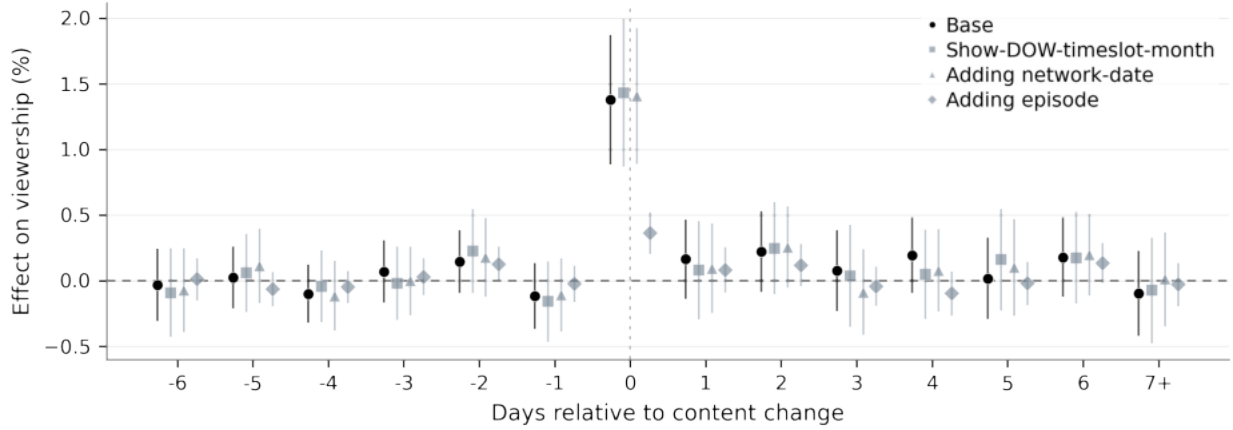
(c) Growth in political advertising



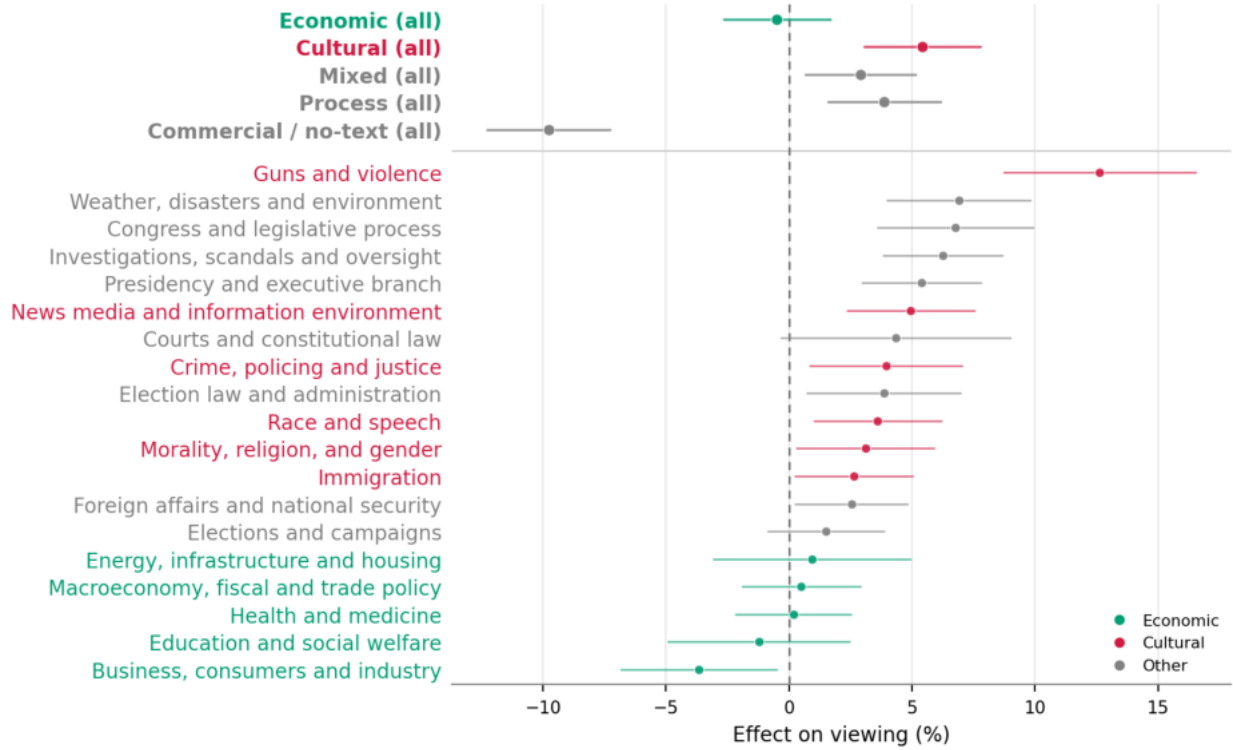
Notes: The x -axis is the difference between the log cable and log broadcast political-content shares for a topic. The y -axis is the topic-specific annual linear trend in the log Gallup Most Important Problem share (Panel A), log ANES vote-choice predictiveness (Panel B), or log airings-weighted political-ad share (Panel C). As in Figure 2, we do not plot topics appearing in fewer than 0.05% of broadcast, cable, and political ads. We cluster standard errors by top-level topic and plot the linear fit. Point size is proportional to summed prevalence across the three domains.

Figure 4: Effect of segment content on segment viewership

(a) Effects of cultural relative to economic content



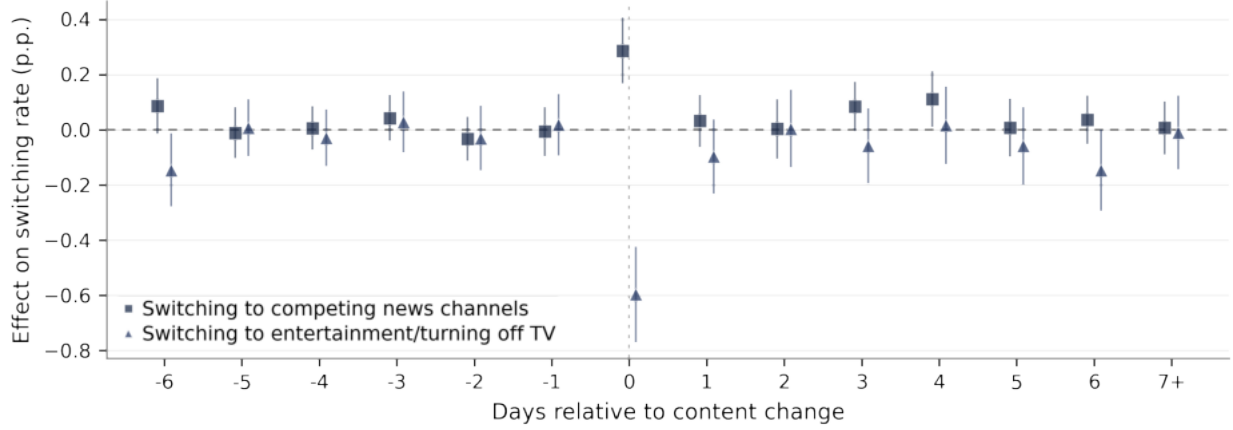
(b) Effects of high-level topics



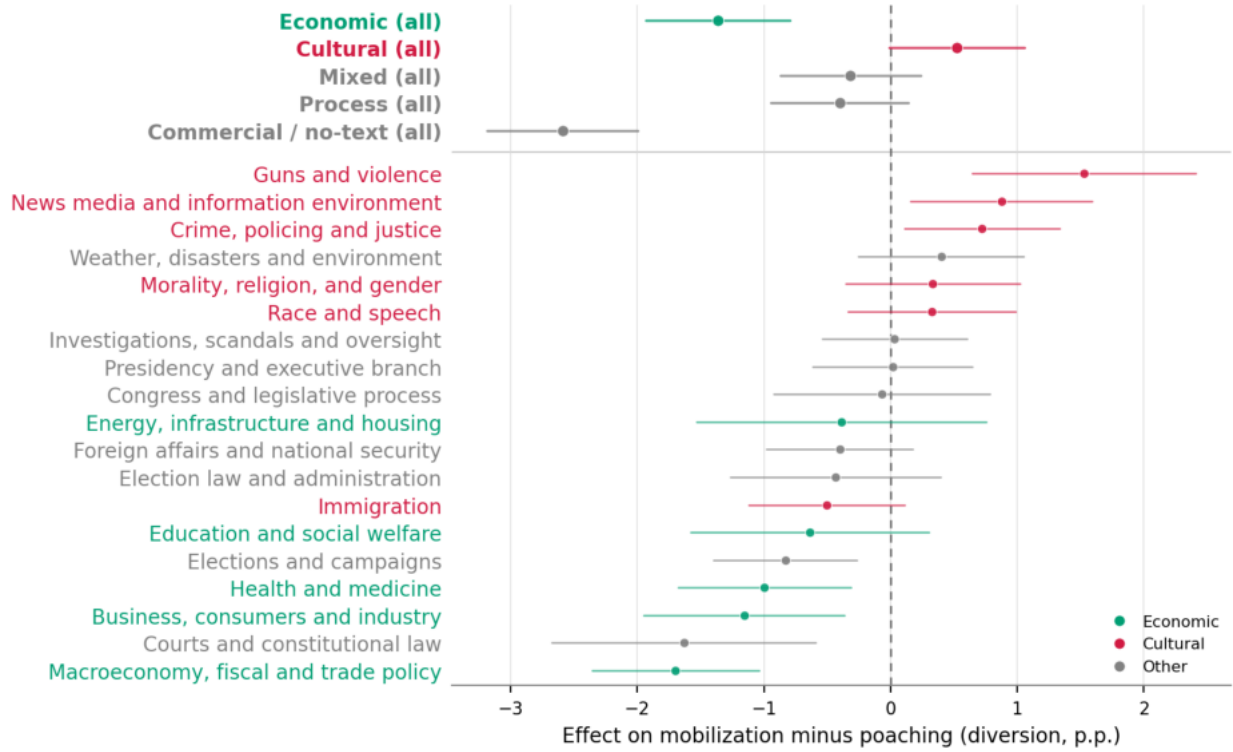
Notes: Panel A plots estimates of $\{\beta_m\}_{m=-6}^7$ from various specifications of Equation 1, with β_{-7} normalized to 0. The dependent variable in the top panel is logged total seconds viewed of the fifteen-minute segment, computed from FourthWall data; the explanatory variable of interest is relative cultural content, defined as the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content, ranging from -1 to 1. The base specification controls for calendar date fixed effects, show-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects, and show-by-timeslot-by-day-of-week fixed effects; additional specifications fully control for show-by-day-of-week-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects, add network-by-date fixed effects, and add fixed effects for the particular 60-minute episode. Panel B instead reports coefficients from two cross-sectional specifications of Equation 1, setting $P = 0$ and where we jointly include all content families (top) or all high-level topics (bottom). In both, the excluded category is nonpolitical topics; each coefficient therefore compares the indicated content with nonpolitical content, holding other included shares fixed. Standard errors are two-way clustered by network-timeslot and calendar date, and we display 95% confidence intervals.

Figure 5: Effect of segment content on switching behavior away from segment

(a) Effect of cultural relative to economic content

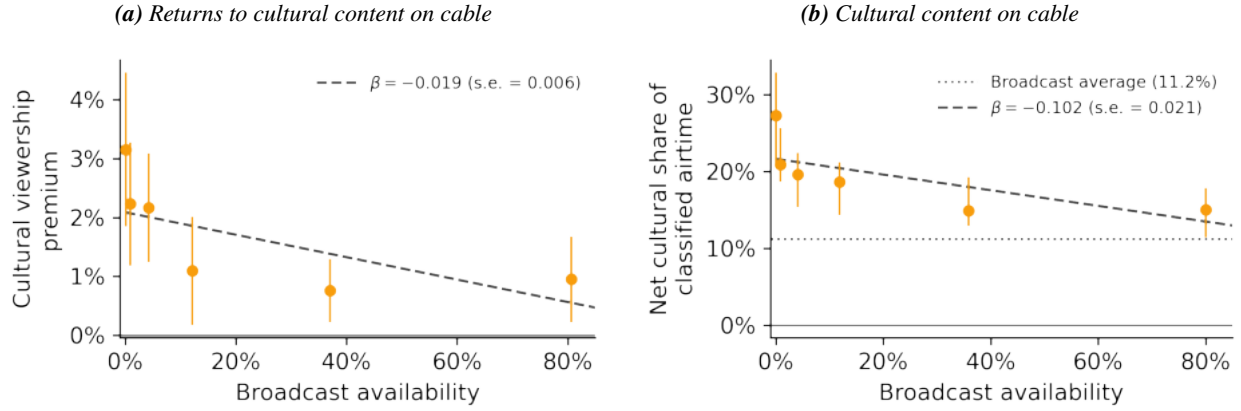


(b) Effect of high-level topics



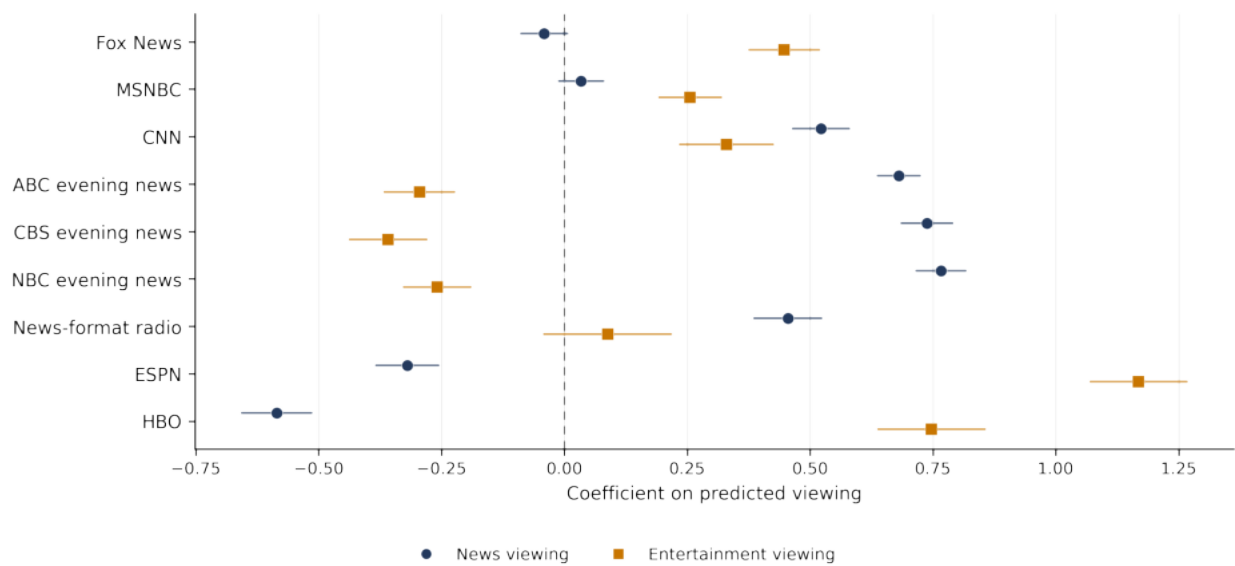
Notes: Panel A plots estimates of $\{\beta_m\}_{m=-6}^7$ from two specifications of Equation 1: one in which the dependent variable is the share of households switching to a competing news channel and one in which the dependent variable is the share of households switching off the news (i.e. either switching to a non-news channel or turning off the TV). The explanatory variable of interest is relative cultural content, defined as the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content, ranging from -1 to 1. Panel B instead reports coefficients from two cross-sectional specifications of Equation 1, setting $P = 0$ and where we jointly include all content families (top) or all high-level topics (bottom). In both, the dependent variable is the difference in the switching rate to competing news channels relative to the switching rate to the outside option. The excluded category is nonpolitical topics; each coefficient therefore compares the indicated content with nonpolitical content, holding other included shares fixed. Standard errors are two-way clustered by network-timeslot and calendar date, and we display 95% confidence intervals.

Figure 6: Returns to cultural content and content choice by broadcast news availability



Notes: Panel A plots estimates of the cable cultural viewership premium, β_0 , from split-sample specifications of Equation 1, using six equal-sized (quantile-spaced) broadcast-availability bins. Panel B plots the cultural content of cable using the same bins; the dotted horizontal line shows the pooled 2015–2019 relative cultural content of broadcast national news. Broadcast availability is defined as the TV-household-weighted share of dates in which at least one of ABC, CBS, or NBC carries national-network news in a given year $\times$ day of week $\times$ half-hour cell. In both panels, relative cultural content is defined as the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content. Standard errors are two-way clustered by network-timeslot and calendar date, and we display 95% confidence intervals.

Figure 7: Predictiveness of demographic groups' prior news and entertainment consumption for viewership of each product



Notes: Each row reports the two coefficients from a regression of a (within-wave z -scored) indicator for whether the respondent reported watching the product in the past seven days jointly on the respondent's predicted news viewership and predicted entertainment viewership, with survey-wave fixed effects. The sample comprises respondents in the 1998 and 1999 survey waves. Predictions come from LASSO models trained on the 1992–1995 waves to predict the (within-wave z -scored) number of news programs and entertainment programs each respondent watches, using as covariates the demographic variables available in MRI (age, education, income, household composition, race, gender, marital status, presence of children, Hispanic ethnicity, employment status, satellite access, county size, and Census region) and the nine demographic and socioeconomic characteristics of the respondent's media market that we use as market-level controls throughout the paper. We plot 95% confidence intervals from a joint bootstrap of both stages. Broadcast evening news rows are the flagship evening newscasts on ABC, CBS, and NBC. News-format radio indicates listening to all-news or news/talk format radio stations.

Table 1: Political advertising content and electoral performance

	Won election (1)	Poaching (2)	Mobilization (3)	Diversion (4)
Relative cultural emphasis	-5.04*** (1.87)	-0.59*** (0.16)	0.41** (0.20)	1.00*** (0.32)
Dependent-variable mean	49.7	-24.0	-52.2	-28.2
Observations	1,263	1,263	1,263	1,263

Notes: The unit of observation is a candidate-year. The sample comprises major-party House, Senate, and gubernatorial general-election candidates from 2000–2022 in contested races in which the top two candidates both aired at least one campaign advertisement after the primary. Relative cultural emphasis is the cultural share minus the economic share of the candidate’s advertising, divided by the sum of the cultural, economic, process, and mixed content shares and standardized within office. In Column 1, the dependent variable is an indicator for whether the candidate wins. In Column 2, the dependent variable, “poaching,” is the negative of the highest-vote opponent’s share of the eligible population. In Column 3, the dependent variable, “mobilization,” is the negative of the outside-option share, where the outside option combines abstention and votes for all remaining candidates. In Column 4, the dependent variable, “diversion,” is mobilization minus poaching. Coefficients, standard errors, and dependent-variable means are multiplied by 100 and expressed in percentage points. Every column includes incumbency-by-office controls, demographic and economic controls interacted with party, economic controls interacted with incumbency, party-by-office-by-year and party-by-constituency-by-office fixed effects, and party interactions with lagged candidate two-party vote, prior poaching, and prior mobilization. The demographic controls are log population, log population density, and the population shares without a high school degree, with a bachelor’s degree, with a postgraduate degree, ages 18–34, 35–54, 55–64, and 65 and older, Black, male, rural, Evangelical, and Hispanic. The economic controls are labor-force participation, the unemployment rate, and log per-capita income. All columns weight candidates by the population of their constituency. We cluster standard errors at the race level. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

Table 2: Structural counterfactuals

	Observed target	Counterfactual cable	Share of gap closed
Broadcast’s audience composition	0.112	0.145	62.2%
Politicians’ objective	-0.373	0.042	27.4%

Cable’s observed relative cultural content is 0.199. Relative cultural content is the cultural share less the economic share of political content, so a decline is movement toward economics.

Table 3: Cable-news exposure and relative cultural MIP

	<i>Dependent variable: Relative cultural MIP</i>			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Fox + MSNBC viewership	0.054*** (0.0229)	0.049*** (0.0209)	0.059*** (0.0274)	0.041** (0.0247)
95% Bayes bootstrap credible interval	[0.019, 0.131]	[0.017, 0.120]	[0.009, 0.141]	[-0.014, 0.104]
Randomization-inference <i>p</i> -value	0.002	0.012	0.018	0.084
Economic controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year $\times$ state FE	No	No	Yes	Yes
Voting controls	No	No	No	Yes
Year $\times$ respondent-party FE	No	No	No	Yes
Mean dependent variable	-0.391	-0.391	-0.391	-0.391
First-stage <i>F</i> -statistic	10.76	12.30	15.94	14.87
Anderson–Rubin <i>p</i> -value	0.000	0.001	0.004	0.041
Observations	176,236	176,227	176,227	175,943

Notes: The unit of observation is a Gallup respondent. The sample comprises respondents from 2000–2022. The dependent variable codes the respondent’s first reported most important problem as one for cultural, minus one for economic, and zero otherwise, divided by its unweighted standard deviation within each column’s estimation sample. The primary explanatory variable is the standardized sum of Fox News and MSNBC viewership, instrumented with the sum of the networks’ channel positions. Columns 1 and 2 include year fixed effects. Every column includes respondent age, race, education, and sex; and the county’s demographic controls: fixed-1996 log population, log population density, and age-65-plus share, and contemporaneous log population, log population density, and the population shares without a high school degree, with a bachelor’s degree, with a postgraduate degree, ages 18–34, 35–54, 55–64, and 65 and older, Black, male, rural, Evangelical, and Hispanic. Column 2 adds the economic controls: fixed-1996 log per-capita income, labor-force participation, the unemployment rate, and log per-capita income. Column 3 replaces the year fixed effects with year-by-state fixed effects. Column 4 adds controls for lagged county Republican presidential vote and respondent party identification and ideology, together with year-by-respondent-party fixed effects. Bracketed intervals are equal-tailed 95 percent credible intervals from 500 Bayesian-bootstrap draws clustered at the same level as the standard errors. Randomization-inference *p*-values permute the paired channel positions across DMAs, sum them within each draw, and recompute the Anderson–Rubin statistic over 500 draws. We weight by Gallup’s provided survey weights and cluster standard errors at the DMA level. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively, and are based on the Anderson–Rubin statistic.

Table 4: *Cable-news exposure and candidate advertising content*

	<i>Dependent variable: Relative cultural ad content</i>					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Fox + MSNBC viewership	0.431*** (0.1442)	0.434*** (0.1453)	0.440*** (0.1544)	0.467*** (0.1582)	0.450*** (0.1990)	0.483*** (0.2102)
95% Bayes bootstrap credible interval	[0.211, 1.116]	[0.193, 1.009]	[0.224, 1.281]	[0.241, 1.172]	[0.107, 1.404]	[0.186, 1.364]
Randomization-inference p -value	0.024	0.018	0.010	0.004	0.088	0.078
Party $\times$ office $\times$ year FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Economic controls	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Voting controls	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Paired-advertiser sample	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Campaign controls	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Mean dependent variable	0.121	0.121	0.121	0.121	0.101	0.101
First-stage F -statistic	10.21	10.19	8.74	8.53	8.09	8.48
Anderson–Rubin p -value	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.009	0.007
Observations	2,956	2,956	2,956	2,940	1,606	1,606

Notes: The unit of observation is a candidate-year. The sample comprises major-party House, Senate, and gubernatorial general-election candidates from 2000–2022. The dependent variable is the candidate’s relative cultural advertising: the cultural share minus the economic share of the candidate’s advertising, divided by the sum of the cultural, economic, process, and mixed content shares and standardized within office. The primary explanatory variable is the standardized sum of Fox News and MSNBC viewership, instrumented with the sum of the networks’ channel positions. Every column includes incumbency-by-office fixed effects and the constituency’s demographic controls, interacted with party: fixed-1996 log population, log population density, and age-65-plus share, and contemporaneous log population, log population density, and the population shares without a high school degree, with a bachelor’s degree, with a postgraduate degree, ages 18–34, 35–54, 55–64, and 65 and older, Black, male, rural, Evangelical, and Hispanic. Column 1 includes office-by-year fixed effects. Column 2 replaces them with party-by-office-by-year fixed effects. Column 3 adds the economic controls interacted with party and with incumbency: fixed-1996 log per-capita income, labor-force participation, the unemployment rate, and log per-capita income. Column 4 adds the interaction of party with lagged Democratic two-party candidate-election vote. Column 5 restricts the sample to candidates whose highest-vote opponent also aired classified TV advertising in our sample. Column 6 further controls for the candidate’s and opponent’s standardized extremity (the absolute value of the static DIME CFscore) and own and opponent log ad airings. Bracketed intervals are equal-tailed 95 percent credible intervals from 500 Bayesian-bootstrap draws clustered at the same level as the standard errors. Randomization-inference p -values permute the paired channel positions across DMAs, sum them within each draw, and recompute the Anderson–Rubin statistic over 500 draws. We weight by constituency population and cluster standard errors at the state level. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively, and are based on the Anderson–Rubin statistic.

Online Appendix

“The Business of the Culture War”

Shakked Noy and Aakaash Rao

A Classification Schema

This appendix describes the classification schema. Sections A.1–A.2 present the schema and the linkages we construct to the Gallup Most Important Problem responses and the American National Election Studies questions. Section A.3 describes the classifier and provides details on classifier performance. Appendix E presents analyses validating the economic vs. cultural distinction that organizes the paper’s results.

A.1 Schema

Appendix Table A1 presents all 259 topics in the schema, their unique family, and their prevalence in political advertising, broadcast news, and cable news.

Appendix Table A1: Classification schema and cross-medium prevalence

Topic	Ads	Broadcast	Cable	Family
1 Elections and campaigns	—	7.17	11.59	Process
1.0 General / residual	—	0.13	0.09	Process
1.1 Republican presidential nomination contest	—	0.49	0.76	Process
1.2 Democratic presidential nomination contest	—	0.55	0.96	Process
1.3 Horse race: polling, forecasting and campaign strategy	—	1.84	3.24	Process
1.4 Candidates as subjects: biography, record, conduct and disclosure	—	1.13	2.01	Process
1.5 Parties, factions and coalitions	—	0.44	1.11	Process
1.6 Campaign events: rallies, debates and conventions	—	0.93	1.15	Process
1.7 Congressional, state and local contests	—	0.55	0.85	Process
1.8 Election outcomes, mechanics and minor candidacies	—	0.34	0.46	Process
1.9 Endorsements, surrogates and outside advocacy	—	0.51	0.64	Process
1.10 Campaign money	—	0.26	0.33	Process
2 Election law and administration	0.63	0.83	1.07	Process
2.0 General / residual	0.01	0.00	0.00	Process
2.1 Election administration, access and integrity	0.28	0.59	0.58	Process
2.2 Foreign interference in elections	0.00	0.17	0.37	Process
2.3 Campaign finance law and regulation	0.34	0.07	0.12	Process
3 Presidency and executive branch	2.03	3.45	4.14	Process
3.0 General / residual	0.00	0.01	0.02	Process
3.1 Agenda and unilateral action	0.22	1.05	1.30	Process
3.2 Personnel	0.05	0.78	0.96	Process

Continued on next page

Topic	Ads	Broadcast	Cable	Family
3.3 Presidential conduct and person	0.27	1.16	1.38	Process
3.4 Official finances, holdings and ethics	1.30	0.12	0.18	Process
3.5 Agencies and the administrative state	0.19	0.33	0.29	Process
4 Congress and legislative process	0.58	0.78	1.21	Process
4.0 General / residual	0.29	0.29	0.34	Process
4.1 Congressional procedure and leadership	0.12	0.19	0.36	Process
4.2 Shutdowns, appropriations and funding standoffs	0.17	0.30	0.51	Process
5 Investigations, scandals and oversight	2.52	2.69	4.71	Process
5.0 General / residual	0.02	0.02	0.03	Process
5.1 Investigation, prosecution and misconduct of officials	2.33	1.66	2.81	Process
5.2 Congressional oversight and impeachment	0.16	0.83	1.47	Process
5.3 Conduct of investigators and integrity institutions	0.02	0.17	0.40	Process
6 Courts and constitutional law	0.33	0.93	1.14	Process
6.0 General / residual	0.10	0.02	0.06	Process
6.1 Judicial nominations, vacancies and confirmation fights	0.20	0.32	0.38	Process
6.2 Courts, judges and constitutional litigation	0.04	0.59	0.70	Process
7 News media and information environment	0.73	1.11	2.92	Cultural
7.0 General / residual	0.00	0.01	0.02	Cultural
7.1 Politicians versus the press	0.03	0.10	0.28	Cultural
7.2 Coverage decisions, media criticism and the information environment	0.70	0.40	1.43	Cultural
7.3 News organisations, journalists and press access	0.01	0.61	1.19	Process
8 Macroeconomy, fiscal and trade policy	34.54	4.65	3.35	Economic
8.0 General / residual	0.14	0.02	0.02	Economic
8.1 Macroeconomy and markets	2.69	1.82	1.08	Economic
8.1.0 General / residual	0.01	0.01	0.00	Economic
8.1.1 Financial markets and stock indices	0.11	0.79	0.44	Economic
8.1.2 Macroeconomic conditions, monetary policy and outlook	1.29	0.94	0.48	Economic
8.1.3 Economic policy programmes and agendas	1.29	0.08	0.16	Economic
8.2 Jobs, wages and labour	9.50	1.28	0.60	Economic
8.2.0 General / residual	1.27	0.04	0.03	Economic
8.2.1 Labour-market conditions: hiring, layoffs, unemployment	6.33	0.76	0.29	Economic
8.2.2 Wages, pay and collective bargaining	1.49	0.31	0.21	Economic
8.2.3 Workplace rules, mandated benefits and labour enforcement	0.42	0.17	0.07	Economic
8.3 Taxes	13.61	0.66	0.65	Economic
8.3.0 General / residual	0.06	0.02	0.01	Economic
8.3.1 Household and general tax policy	7.34	0.40	0.43	Economic
8.3.2 State and local fiscal policy and tax ballot measures	2.55	0.12	0.06	Economic
8.3.3 Business, corporate and high-earner taxation	3.65	0.12	0.15	Economic
8.4 Public finance	6.28	0.61	0.74	Economic
8.4.0 General / residual	0.61	0.02	0.01	Economic

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Topic	Ads	Broadcast	Cable	Family
8.4.1 Federal budget, deficits and debt	5.01	0.37	0.45	Economic
8.4.2 Fiscal stimulus and pandemic economic relief	0.65	0.22	0.28	Economic
8.5 Trade	2.32	0.25	0.28	Economic
8.5.0 General / residual	0.00	0.01	0.01	Economic
8.5.1 Tariffs, trade conflicts and agreements	0.83	0.14	0.23	Economic
8.5.2 Industrial policy, supply chains and economic competition	1.49	0.11	0.04	Economic
9 Business, consumers and industry	4.56	5.94	2.75	Economic
9.0 General / residual	0.11	0.04	0.03	Economic
9.1 Corporate news	1.85	2.73	1.25	Economic
9.1.0 General / residual	0.00	0.01	0.00	Economic
9.1.1 Company performance, ownership and operations	0.29	1.86	0.88	Economic
9.1.2 Business distress: bankruptcy, closures and industry downturn	0.51	0.60	0.16	Economic
9.1.3 Bailouts, subsidies and industry relief	1.05	0.26	0.20	Economic
9.2 Corporate accountability	2.02	1.55	1.04	Economic
9.2.0 General / residual	0.05	0.00	0.00	Economic
9.2.1 Corporate misconduct, liability and litigation	1.25	1.22	0.84	Economic
9.2.2 Antitrust and business regulation	0.72	0.32	0.20	Economic
9.3 Consumers	0.50	1.24	0.23	Economic
9.3.0 General / residual	0.01	0.18	0.02	Economic
9.3.1 Consumer prices and household costs	0.47	0.38	0.05	Economic
9.3.2 Product recalls, defects and food safety	0.02	0.68	0.16	Economic
9.4 Technology sector: companies, platforms and data practices	0.08	0.38	0.20	Economic
10 Energy, infrastructure and housing	3.99	4.37	1.60	Economic
10.0 General / residual	0.03	0.02	0.01	Economic
10.1 Energy and resources	2.60	1.30	0.48	Economic
10.1.0 General / residual	0.08	0.03	0.02	Economic
10.1.1 Energy prices	0.74	0.69	0.19	Economic
10.1.2 Energy industry economics and workforce	1.19	0.25	0.15	Economic
10.1.3 Energy infrastructure and pipeline projects	0.25	0.06	0.04	Economic
10.1.4 Agriculture and fisheries	0.34	0.27	0.07	Economic
10.2 Utilities: service, safety and accountability	0.17	0.30	0.15	Economic
10.3 Transportation and infrastructure	0.64	2.15	0.74	Economic
10.4 Housing, land use and development	0.56	0.61	0.22	Economic
11 Health and medicine	17.79	10.63	6.22	Economic
11.0 General / residual	0.08	0.30	0.14	Economic
11.1 Health care system	16.09	1.74	1.41	Economic
11.1.0 General / residual	1.67	0.14	0.09	Economic
11.1.1 Health law repeal, replacement and legal challenges	2.00	0.40	0.64	Economic
11.1.2 Coverage programmes, eligibility and enrollment	2.34	0.22	0.18	Economic
11.1.3 Drug prices, shortages and access	2.69	0.24	0.08	Economic

Continued on next page

Topic	Ads	Broadcast	Cable	Family
11.1.4 Veterans' health care and benefits	1.13	0.12	0.10	Economic
11.1.5 Medicare finances, benefits and eligibility	2.85	0.12	0.06	Economic
11.1.6 Hospitals, clinics and the health workforce	0.75	0.33	0.20	Economic
11.1.7 Insurance practices, billing and patient protections	2.66	0.18	0.06	Economic
11.2 Medicine and research	0.61	4.89	2.11	Economic
11.3 Public health	0.71	3.42	2.29	Mixed
11.3.0 General / residual	0.00	0.01	0.01	Mixed
11.3.1 Vaccination and immunisation policy	0.02	0.12	0.06	Mixed
11.3.2 Infectious disease and outbreaks	0.55	2.37	1.68	Mixed
11.3.3 Tobacco, diet and health behaviour	0.04	0.49	0.14	Mixed
11.3.4 Health mandates, restrictions and public-health authority	0.10	0.44	0.40	Mixed
11.4 Drugs, addiction and the opioid epidemic	0.29	0.28	0.26	Mixed
12 Education and social welfare	12.76	2.27	1.30	Economic
12.0 General / residual	0.63	0.04	0.02	Economic
12.1 Schools	5.63	0.77	0.52	Economic
12.1.0 General / residual	0.68	0.13	0.07	Economic
12.1.1 School funding, budgets and teacher pay	2.11	0.09	0.04	Economic
12.1.2 School operations, rules and discipline	0.64	0.34	0.31	Mixed
12.1.3 School quality, standards and achievement	2.04	0.17	0.07	Economic
12.1.4 School choice, charters and vouchers	0.17	0.04	0.04	Economic
12.2 Higher education	1.31	0.33	0.12	Economic
12.2.0 General / residual	0.14	0.07	0.02	Economic
12.2.1 College costs, student debt and financial burden	1.17	0.14	0.05	Economic
12.2.2 Campus life and academic practice	0.00	0.12	0.05	Mixed
12.3 Curriculum, campus speech and ideological disputes	0.15	0.08	0.12	Cultural
12.4 Social welfare	4.32	0.52	0.16	Economic
12.4.0 General / residual	0.06	0.00	0.00	Economic
12.4.1 Poverty, income support and food assistance	0.53	0.30	0.11	Economic
12.4.2 Social Security, pensions and retirement security	3.73	0.22	0.05	Economic
12.5 Homelessness, encampments and homeless services	0.03	0.14	0.06	Economic
12.6 Child care and early education	0.50	0.04	0.01	Economic
12.7 Disability, foster care and child welfare	0.18	0.35	0.28	Economic
13 Immigration	2.70	1.17	1.71	Cultural
13.0 General / residual	0.10	0.05	0.09	Cultural
13.1 Border and enforcement	1.54	0.46	0.73	Cultural
13.1.0 General / residual	0.04	0.01	0.01	Cultural
13.1.1 Border security	0.96	0.18	0.35	Cultural
13.1.2 Border operations, personnel and arrivals	0.08	0.11	0.11	Cultural
13.1.3 Interior enforcement, raids and deportation	0.47	0.16	0.25	Cultural
13.2 Detention, due process and refugee admission	0.07	0.33	0.44	Cultural
13.3 Status and admissions	0.72	0.27	0.38	Cultural
13.3.0 General / residual	0.01	0.00	0.01	Cultural
13.3.1 Legal immigration, citizenship and Dreamers	0.68	0.22	0.31	Cultural

Continued on next page

Topic	Ads	Broadcast	Cable	Family
13.3.2 Entry bans, travel restrictions and litigation	0.02	0.05	0.06	Cultural
13.4 Immigration and the economy	0.27	0.06	0.07	Economic
14 Crime, policing and justice	3.11	9.02	13.40	Cultural
14.0 General / residual	0.11	0.06	0.09	Cultural
14.1 Crime incidents	0.84	5.16	7.06	Cultural
14.1.0 General / residual	0.03	0.22	0.29	Cultural
14.1.1 Homicide, shootings and suspicious deaths	0.13	1.61	2.86	Cultural
14.1.2 Property crime, assault and vandalism	0.05	0.69	0.65	Cultural
14.1.3 Missing persons, abductions and manhunts	0.07	0.94	1.72	Cultural
14.1.4 Vehicle crime, police pursuits and dangerous driving	0.04	0.25	0.20	Cultural
14.1.5 Fraud, scams and cybercrime	0.25	1.04	0.58	Cultural
14.1.6 Domestic, sexual and family violence	0.26	0.42	0.76	Cultural
14.2 Courts and corrections	1.16	2.44	4.74	Cultural
14.2.0 General / residual	0.00	0.00	0.00	Cultural
14.2.1 Criminal trials, verdicts, prisons and custody	0.20	2.10	4.19	Cultural
14.2.2 Criminal-justice policy, sentencing, clemency, wrongful conviction	0.95	0.33	0.54	Cultural
14.3 Policing	0.78	1.03	1.12	Cultural
14.3.0 General / residual	0.00	0.00	0.00	Cultural
14.3.1 Police conduct: use of force, misconduct and accountability	0.02	0.65	0.70	Cultural
14.3.2 Police officers and departments	0.15	0.24	0.19	Cultural
14.3.3 Policing policy and politics	0.61	0.13	0.24	Cultural
14.4 Drugs as crime	0.22	0.34	0.40	Cultural
14.4.0 General / residual	0.02	0.01	0.03	Cultural
14.4.1 Drug trafficking, cartels and enforcement	0.16	0.24	0.26	Cultural
14.4.2 Drug policy and cannabis legalization	0.04	0.08	0.11	Cultural
15A Guns and violence	1.74	4.08	4.06	Cultural
15.0 General / residual	0.00	0.00	0.00	Cultural
15.1 Mass violence events	0.41	3.62	3.59	Cultural
15.1.0 General / residual	0.00	0.00	0.00	Cultural
15.1.1 Mass shootings and other mass-casualty attacks	0.04	1.52	1.65	Cultural
15.1.2 Terrorism in the United States: attacks, investigations and policy	0.34	1.53	1.52	Cultural
15.1.3 Political violence, extremist plots and threats to officials	0.03	0.09	0.11	Cultural
15.1.4 Threats, hoaxes and security precautions	0.01	0.48	0.31	Cultural
15.2 Guns: policy, rights and regulation	1.32	0.45	0.47	Cultural
15B Race and speech	0.75	3.64	4.79	Cultural
15.3 Race	0.48	1.54	2.59	Cultural
15.3.0 General / residual	0.01	0.01	0.02	Cultural
15.3.1 Racial and ethnic rhetoric and conduct by public figures	0.18	0.46	1.23	Cultural

Continued on next page

Topic	Ads	Broadcast	Cable	Family
15.3.2 Hate crimes, racist attacks and organised extremism	0.03	0.25	0.28	Cultural
15.3.3 Profiling, discrimination and affirmative action	0.13	0.29	0.34	Cultural
15.3.4 Monuments, renaming and contested memory	0.03	0.07	0.07	Cultural
15.3.5 Race as an explicit public subject	0.11	0.46	0.65	Cultural
15.8 Protest and speech	0.26	1.26	1.57	Cultural
15.8.0 General / residual	0.00	0.00	0.00	Cultural
15.8.1 Protest, unrest and public political expression	0.12	1.18	1.33	Cultural
15.8.2 Free speech and offensive expression	0.14	0.09	0.24	Cultural
15.9 Commemoration and historical memory	0.00	0.84	0.63	Mixed
15C Morality, religion, and gender	3.84	3.22	4.03	Cultural
15.4 Gender and sexual misconduct	0.93	1.26	1.50	Cultural
15.4.0 General / residual	0.00	0.01	0.01	Cultural
15.4.1 Sexual misconduct allegations against public figures	0.19	0.81	1.13	Cultural
15.4.2 Women's rights and gender in public life	0.40	0.35	0.33	Cultural
15.4.3 Pay equity and workforce participation	0.34	0.09	0.03	Economic
15.5 Abortion	1.75	0.22	0.27	Cultural
15.5.0 General / residual	0.02	0.01	0.01	Cultural
15.5.1 Abortion law and rights	1.37	0.18	0.23	Cultural
15.5.2 Abortion providers and funding	0.37	0.04	0.03	Cultural
15.6 LGBTQ rights and gender identity	0.21	0.38	0.77	Cultural
15.6.0 General / residual	0.00	0.00	0.01	Cultural
15.6.1 LGBTQ rights, recognition and religious objection	0.20	0.34	0.70	Cultural
15.6.2 Transgender issues	0.02	0.03	0.06	Cultural
15.7 Religion	0.78	1.18	1.38	Cultural
15.7.0 General / residual	0.00	0.00	0.01	Cultural
15.7.1 Religion in politics and religious liberty	0.77	0.22	0.42	Cultural
15.7.2 Religious institutions, leaders and believers	0.00	0.95	0.96	Cultural
15.10 Gambling, alcohol, tobacco and vice regulation	0.17	0.18	0.11	Cultural
16 Foreign affairs and national security	4.80	19.90	20.99	Mixed
16.0 General / residual	0.24	0.06	0.06	Mixed
16.1 Diplomacy and foreign relations	0.81	4.04	5.16	Mixed
16.1.0 General / residual	0.00	0.04	0.11	Mixed
16.1.1 US–Russia relations	0.05	0.35	0.46	Mixed
16.1.2 US–China relations	0.09	0.21	0.35	Mixed
16.1.3 US–Iran relations	0.16	0.62	0.73	Mixed
16.1.4 US–North Korea relations	0.01	0.58	0.70	Mixed
16.1.5 US–Israel relations	0.02	0.22	0.29	Mixed
16.1.6 Bilateral and allied relations, and presidential foreign travel	0.19	1.79	2.10	Mixed
16.1.7 US foreign policy doctrine, standing and instruments	0.29	0.23	0.42	Mixed
16.2 War and armed conflict	1.61	7.64	8.32	Mixed

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Topic	Ads	Broadcast	Cable	Family
16.2.0 General / residual	0.29	1.37	1.54	Mixed
16.2.1 Counter-insurgency and named ground campaigns abroad	1.30	4.37	3.93	Mixed
16.2.2 Syrian civil war	0.00	0.54	0.77	Mixed
16.2.3 Russia–Ukraine conflict	0.00	0.13	0.19	Mixed
16.2.4 Israeli–Palestinian conflict	0.01	1.22	1.90	Mixed
16.3 Terrorism abroad	0.22	2.31	2.35	Cultural
16.3.0 General / residual	0.12	0.10	0.09	Cultural
16.3.1 Terrorist attacks abroad	0.03	1.45	1.33	Cultural
16.3.2 ISIS and al Qaeda as organizations	0.07	0.76	0.93	Cultural
16.4 US military as an institution	1.55	2.56	1.36	Mixed
16.4.0 General / residual	0.12	0.08	0.08	Mixed
16.4.1 Defense budget, readiness and programmes	0.97	0.34	0.20	Mixed
16.4.2 Deployments, posture and personnel incidents	0.06	0.95	0.61	Mixed
16.4.3 Military service, families and commemoration	0.40	1.18	0.46	Mixed
16.5 Intelligence, espionage and surveillance authorities	0.35	0.85	0.92	Mixed
16.6 The world beyond US policy	0.00	2.44	2.81	Mixed
16.6.0 General / residual	0.00	0.01	0.01	Mixed
16.6.1 Politics, unrest and crises abroad	0.00	2.43	2.80	Mixed
16.6.2 World news miscellany	—	—	—	Nonpolitical
17 Weather, disasters and environment	2.58	14.15	9.02	Mixed
17.0 General / residual	0.00	0.00	0.00	Mixed
17.1 Weather and natural disasters	0.31	8.40	4.92	Mixed
17.1.0 General / residual	0.00	0.01	0.00	Mixed
17.1.1 Severe weather, wildfire and natural disaster events	0.07	6.52	3.38	Mixed
17.1.2 Disaster response, aid and preparedness	0.25	1.87	1.53	Mixed
17.2 Climate and environment	2.24	1.85	0.97	Mixed
17.2.0 General / residual	0.12	0.05	0.02	Mixed
17.2.1 Climate science, impacts and attribution	0.05	0.32	0.09	Cultural
17.2.2 Climate and environmental policy and regulation	1.05	0.31	0.20	Cultural
17.2.3 Pollution and environmental contamination	0.57	0.70	0.50	Mixed
17.2.4 Water, habitat and conservation	0.46	0.47	0.15	Mixed
17.3 Wildlife, pets and animals	—	—	—	Nonpolitical
17.4 Accidents and manmade disasters	0.03	3.90	3.13	Mixed
18 Science and space	—	—	—	Nonpolitical
19 Sports	—	—	—	Nonpolitical
20 Entertainment, celebrity and the arts	—	—	—	Nonpolitical
21 Human interest and daily life	—	—	—	Nonpolitical

Notes: The table presents all 259 issue topics in the schema. Shares are percentages of total political content; nonpolitical content and commercial advertising are excluded from the denominator. Dashes mark topics that are not relevant for a particular domain and are thus omitted.

A.2 ANES and MIP linkages

We present the mapping between MIP responses and ANES questions and the schema below. ANES question numbers refer to question numbers in the ANES Time Series Cumulative Data File.²⁷

Appendix Table A2: Schema categories linked to MIP responses and ANES questions

Category	MIP responses	ANES questions
1 Elections and campaigns	Government-President Clinton-Congress-Politicians, Government-President-Congress- Politicians, Presidential choices/election year, Unifying the Country	–
2.1 Election administration, access and integrity	Election/Election Reform	–
5.1 Investigation, prosecution and misconduct of officials	Abuse of power, Dishonesty/Lack of Integrity, Poor leadership/corrupt	–
6 Courts and constitutional law	Judicial System/Courts/Laws	–
7.2 Coverage decisions, media criticism and the information environment	The media	–
8 Macroeconomy, fiscal and trade policy	Other Economic	–
8.1 Macroeconomy and markets	–	free_market (VCF9132)
8.1.2 Macroeconomic conditions, monetary policy and outlook	Cost of Living-Inflation, Economy (General), Lack of money, Recession	–
8.2 Jobs, wages and labour	–	jobs_index (VCF0809, VCF0210)
8.2.1 Labour-market conditions: hiring, layoffs, unemployment	Unemployment-Jobs	–
8.2.2 Wages, pay and collective bargaining	Wage Issues	–
8.3 Taxes	Taxes	–
8.4 Public finance	–	public_finance_index_reclass_v1 (VCF0606, VCF0839)
8.4.1 Federal budget, deficits and debt	Federal Budge Deficit-Debt [sic], Federal Budget Deficit-Debt	–

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²⁷See <https://electionstudies.org/data-center/anes-time-series-cumulative-data-file/>.

Category	MIP responses	ANES questions
8.5 Trade	Foreign Trade-Trade Deficit	–
8.5.1 Tariffs, trade conflicts and agreements	–	trade (VCF9231)
9.2.1 Corporate misconduct, liability and litigation	Corporate Corruption	–
10.1 Energy and resources	Energy crisis, Lack of energy Sources	–
10.1.1 Energy prices	Fuel/Oil Prices	–
11 Health and medicine	Cancer/Diseases	–
11.1 Health care system	Costs associated with health insurance, Costs associated with health insurance [sic], Health Care-Hospitals	health_insurance (VCF0806)
11.1.5 Medicare finances, benefits and eligibility	Medicare Increases-Senior Citizen Insurance	–
11.3.2 Infectious disease and outbreaks	AIDS	–
12 Education and social welfare	Access to Education, Education	–
12.1.1 School funding, budgets and teacher pay	–	education_spending (VCF0890)
12.2.1 College costs, student debt and financial burden	–	fin_aid_college_spending (VCF0891)
12.4 Social welfare	Care for the Elderly, Welfare	–
12.4.1 Poverty, income support and food assistance	Gap Between the Rich and Poor, Poverty-Hunger-Homelessness	poverty_reclass_v1 (VCF0886, VCF0894, VCF0220, VCF0223)
12.4.2 Social Security, pensions and retirement security	Social Security Issues	social_security (VCF9049)
12.6 Child care and early education	Childrens Needs	childcare_spending (VCF0887)
13 Immigration	–	therm_immigrants (VCF0233)
13.1 Border and enforcement	Immigration-Illegal Aliens	–
13.3 Status and admissions	–	decrease_immigration (VCF0879a)
13.3.1 Legal immigration, citizenship and Dreamers	Licenses for the Undocumented	–
13.4 Immigration and the economy	–	immigration_steals_jobs (VCF9223)
14.1 Crime incidents	Crime-Violence	–

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Category	MIP responses	ANES questions
14.1.6 Domestic, sexual and family violence	Child Abuse	–
14.2.2 Criminal-justice policy, sentencing, clemency, wrongful conviction	–	death_penalty (VCF9237)
14.3.1 Police conduct: use of force, misconduct and accountability	Police brutality	–
14.3.2 Police officers and departments	–	therm_police (VCF0214)
14.3.3 Policing policy and politics	–	crime_spending (VCF0888)
14.4 Drugs as crime	Drugs	–
15.1.1 Mass shootings and other mass-casualty attacks	School Shootings	–
15.1.2 Terrorism in the United States: attacks, investigations and policy	Terrorism	–
15.2 Guns: policy, rights and regulation	Gun Control-Gun Laws Too Strong, Gun Laws too Weak-Availability of Guns, Gun control/Guns	guns (VCF9238)
15.3 Race	–	race_index (VCF0830, VCF0867a, VCF0206, VCF0216, VCF0215, VCF9050, VCF9037)
15.3.5 Race as an explicit public subject	Race Relations	–
15.4.2 Women's rights and gender in public life	–	women_index (VCF0253, VCF0834)
15.5 Abortion	Abortion Issues	abortion_index (VCF0838, VCF0230)
15.6 LGBTQ rights and gender identity	–	gay_index (VCF0232, VCF0876a, VCF0878)

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Category	MIP responses	ANES questions
15.6.1 LGBTQ rights, recognition and religious objection	Gay marriage/Homosexual rights	–
15.7 Religion	Breakdown of the Family, Ethical-Moral-Religious Decline, Way children are raised	religion_index (VCF0850, VCF0853, VCF0234, VCF9043+VCF9051, VCF9003)
16 Foreign affairs and national security	International Problems-Foreign Affairs, Lack of a Military/Defense, National Security	–
16.1.1 US–Russia relations	Situation with Russia	–
16.1.2 US–China relations	Situation with China	–
16.1.4 US–North Korea relations	Situation with Korea	–
16.1.7 US foreign policy doctrine, standing and instruments	Foreign Aid-Focus Overseas	foreign_aid_spending (VCF0892)
16.2 War and armed conflict	Fear of War, Kosovo-Serbia-Yugoslavia-Milosevic, War Between Middle East Nations	–
16.2.1 Counter-insurgency and named ground campaigns abroad	Iraq, Iraq-Saddam Hussein, Situation in Afghanistan, War-Conflict in the Middle East	–
16.2.2 Syrian civil war	Syria	–
16.4.1 Defense budget, readiness and programmes	–	defense (VCF0843)
17.1.2 Disaster response, aid and preparedness	Natural disaster response, Natural disaster response’ [<i>sic</i>]	–
17.2 Climate and environment	Overpopulation	–
17.2.2 Climate and environmental policy and regulation	–	enviro_reg (VCF0842)
17.2.3 Pollution and environmental contamination	Environment-Pollution	–
17.4 Accidents and manmade disasters	Space Shuttle Disaster	–
18 Science and space	Advancement of computers/technology	–

Notes: Only schema topics with at least one direct reviewed Gallup or ANES linkage are shown. Gallup entries are literal coded responses; ANES entries report the analysis variable followed by its cumulative-file question identifiers. Survey measures are not assigned to descendants that they do not directly identify.

Appendix Figure A1: Screenshots of classification applications

(a) News classifier

(b) Ads classifier

A.3 Classification details and validation

We use OpenAI’s GPT-5.6 Luna to classify news segments and political advertisements. To validate this classification, we hired human coders from the platform Upwork. We hired five coders to generate the news validation set, each of whom had experience with journalism or in politics, or had degrees in journalism or political science. We hired two coders to generate the ads validation set, both of whom were former staffers to members of Congress, and we also classified all ads in the validation set ourselves.

Each coder independently classified news segments or ads according to the schema in Appendix Table A1. Given the length and complexity of the schema, we developed desktop applications to facilitate classification (Appendix Figure A1). In both domains, we assigned a given category to a segment or ad if and only if a majority of coders (including ourselves, for ads) assigned that category.

Appendix Table A3 presents results from the validation set, comparing the model’s classifications to the

hand-coded labels. Panel A reports the four content families obtained by rolling up the classifications (per the procedure described in Section 2.1); Panel B reports each top-level topic of the schema, and, beneath it, all of the topics below it scored jointly. We report the accuracy and the F1 score (the harmonic mean of precision and recall) of the classifier relative to the hand-coded labels. Classification quality is generally high.

Appendix Table A3: Classifier validation against hand-coded labels

		Accuracy			F1		
	Topics	Broadcast	Cable	Political ads	Broadcast	Cable	Political ads
Panel A. Content families							
Economics	83	0.942	0.951	0.943	0.763	0.754	0.958
Culture	82	0.942	0.924	0.948	0.866	0.872	0.890
Process	38	0.958	0.911	0.934	0.850	0.894	0.607
Mixed	47	0.949	0.944	0.949	0.825	0.835	0.820
Panel B. Top-level topics, each above its own subtopics							
1 Elections and campaigns		0.978	0.949	—	0.821	0.858	—
its subtopics	11	0.994	0.982	—	0.678	0.679	—
2 Election law and administration		0.993	0.982	0.996	0.679	0.732	0.867
its subtopics	4	0.998	0.995	0.999	0.710	0.712	0.867
3 Presidency and executive branch		0.975	0.944	0.967	0.705	0.741	0.400
its subtopics	6	0.994	0.986	0.994	0.640	0.654	0.393
4 Congress and legislative process		0.997	0.987	0.987	0.800	0.724	0.381
its subtopics	3	0.998	0.995	0.994	0.682	0.706	0.190
5 Investigations, scandals and oversight		0.986	0.969	0.975	0.823	0.887	0.590
its subtopics	4	0.995	0.982	0.993	0.771	0.783	0.557
6 Courts and constitutional law		0.997	0.987	0.996	0.774	0.673	0.714
its subtopics	3	0.999	0.995	0.999	0.774	0.627	0.714
7 News media and information environment		0.989	0.969	0.990	0.526	0.664	0.375
its subtopics	4	0.997	0.989	0.997	0.508	0.576	0.375
8 Macroeconomy, fiscal and trade policy		0.990	0.979	0.938	0.731	0.778	0.932
its subtopics	24	0.999	0.997	0.979	0.696	0.713	0.817
9 Business, consumers and industry		0.973	0.985	0.942	0.689	0.537	0.574
its subtopics	15	0.996	0.997	0.990	0.616	0.438	0.512
10 Energy, infrastructure and housing		0.986	0.991	0.974	0.707	0.566	0.869
its subtopics	10	0.999	0.999	0.994	0.726	0.639	0.835
11 Health and medicine		0.979	0.987	0.973	0.821	0.837	0.950
its subtopics	18	0.998	0.999	0.992	0.766	0.841	0.880
12 Education and social welfare		0.990	0.995	0.967	0.667	0.606	0.908
its subtopics	19	0.999	0.999	0.993	0.623	0.585	0.837
13 Immigration		0.994	0.985	0.992	0.835	0.834	0.927
its subtopics	12	0.998	0.996	0.997	0.716	0.740	0.877
14 Crime, policing and justice		0.966	0.977	0.979	0.836	0.850	0.821
its subtopics	22	0.994	0.996	0.997	0.741	0.745	0.724
15A Guns and violence		0.990	0.990	0.989	0.809	0.877	0.845
its subtopics	8	0.997	0.997	0.998	0.799	0.833	0.800

Continued on next page

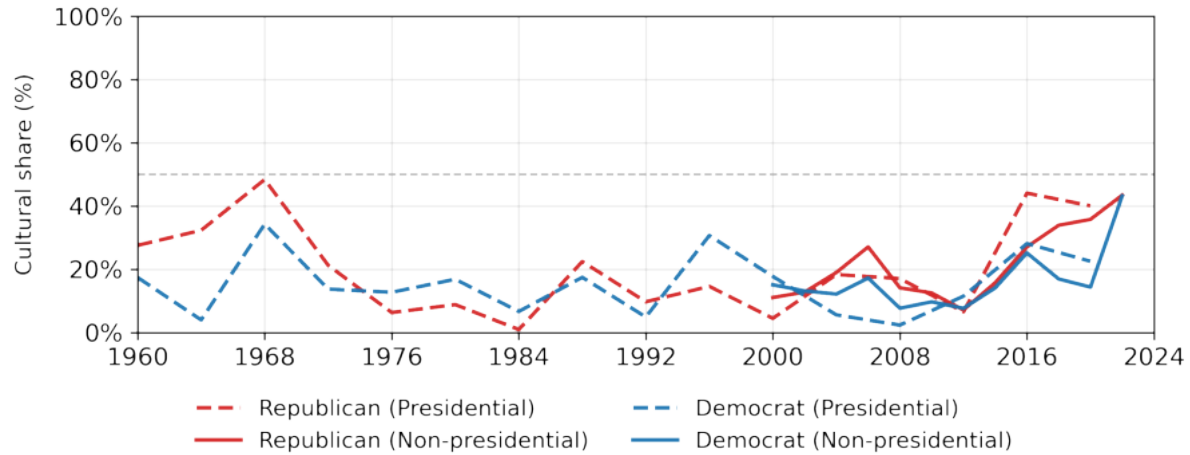
	Topics	Accuracy			F1		
		Broadcast	Cable	Political ads	Broadcast	Cable	Political ads
15B Race and speech		0.981	0.966	0.987	0.751	0.716	0.519
<i>its subtopics</i>	<i>12</i>	<i>0.996</i>	<i>0.993</i>	<i>0.998</i>	<i>0.696</i>	<i>0.689</i>	<i>0.500</i>
15C Morality, religion, and gender		0.983	0.976	0.980	0.739	0.779	0.892
<i>its subtopics</i>	<i>18</i>	<i>0.998</i>	<i>0.997</i>	<i>0.997</i>	<i>0.718</i>	<i>0.759</i>	<i>0.851</i>
16 Foreign affairs and national security		0.977	0.959	0.982	0.819	0.850	0.842
<i>its subtopics</i>	<i>30</i>	<i>0.997</i>	<i>0.995</i>	<i>0.998</i>	<i>0.738</i>	<i>0.773</i>	<i>0.749</i>
17 Weather, disasters and environment		0.966	0.983	0.981	0.831	0.826	0.848
<i>its subtopics</i>	<i>13</i>	<i>0.995</i>	<i>0.997</i>	<i>0.996</i>	<i>0.805</i>	<i>0.817</i>	<i>0.810</i>
18 Science and space		0.995	0.998	—	0.606	0.750	—
19 Sports		0.982	0.997	—	0.800	0.789	—
20 Entertainment, celebrity and the arts		0.950	0.987	—	0.836	0.740	—
21 Human interest and daily life		0.947	0.983	—	0.701	0.625	—

Notes: Table compares classifications to hand-coded labels at the level of individual topics, for the held-out ads and news validation samples. A text is positive for a topic when it carries that topic or any topic below it in the schema. Accuracy is the share of texts on which the classification and the hand-coded label agree on whether the text is positive for the topic. Because most topics are rare, accuracy is extremely high for many of them (over 99%), reflecting “true negative” texts where the topic did not appear and the classifier correctly did not detect it. F1 is the harmonic mean of precision (the share of texts the classifier assigns to a topic that the coders also assign to it) and recall (the share of texts the coders assign to a topic that the classifier also assigns to it). It excludes true negatives and so is not inflated by a topic’s rarity, falling whenever the classifier misses texts the coders flagged or flags texts they did not. Panel A reports the four content families, with the number of schema topics resolving to each. Panel B reports each top-level topic on the first line and, on the second, all topics below it scored jointly: the italic rows pool the text-topic decisions of that branch’s subtopics, so each subtopic enters in proportion to the texts it is assigned. Rates computed from fewer than five hand-coded positives are not reported.

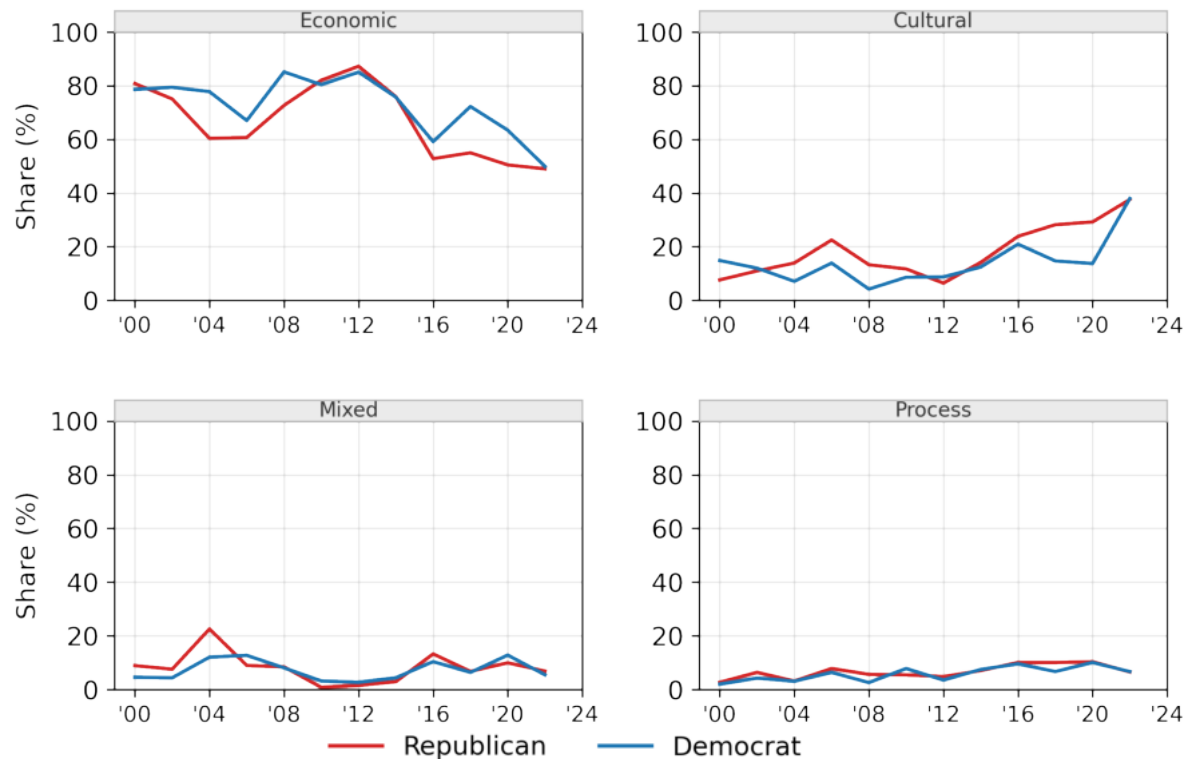
B Additional Results on Cable and Broadcast News

Appendix Figure B1: Content of Republican and Democratic campaign television advertisements, 1960–2022

(a) Cultural share of economic and cultural content



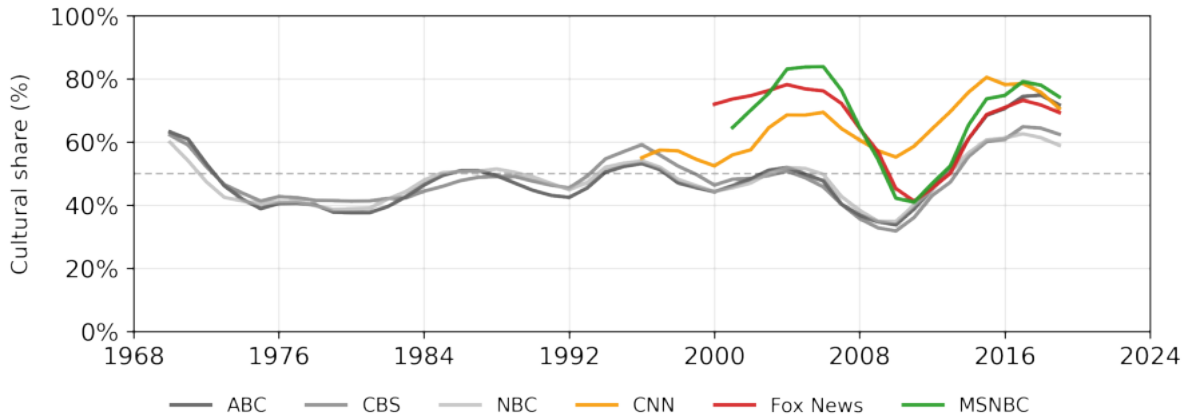
(b) Top-level political families



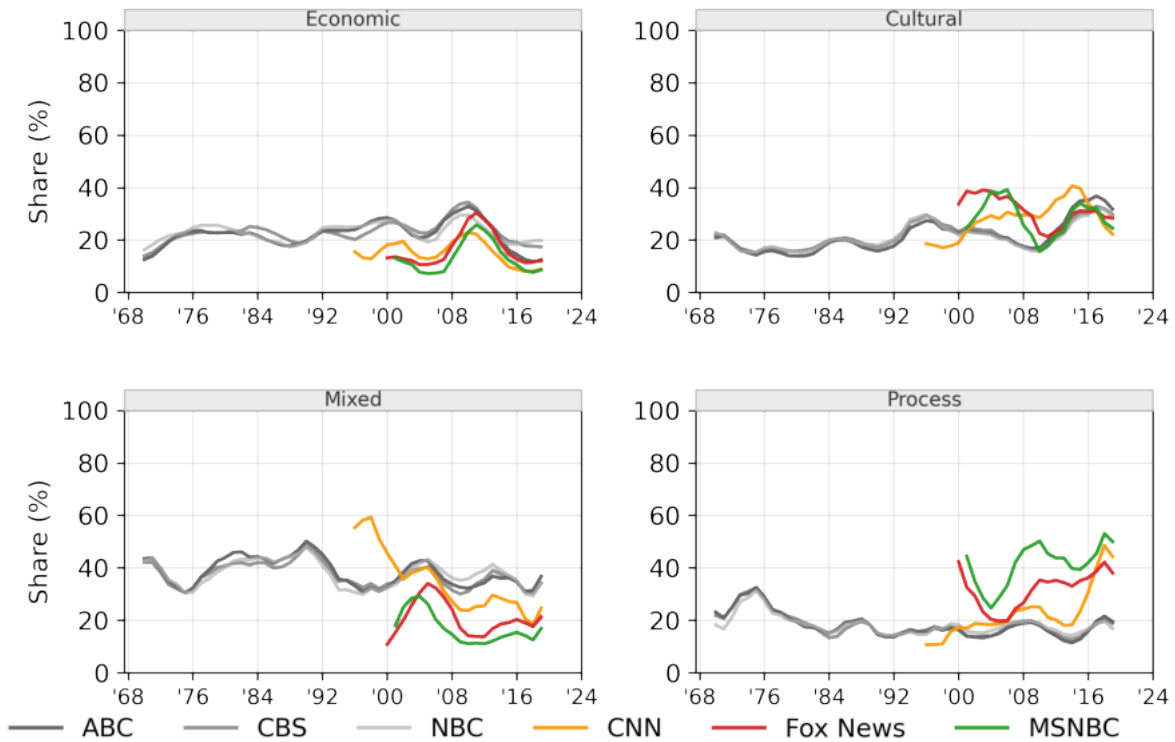
Notes: The sample is Republican and Democratic candidate advertisements in the Wisconsin and Wesleyan Media Projects, covering presidential, gubernatorial, House, and Senate races in even years from 2000 to 2022, weighted by total airings. Panel A additionally splits each party into presidential and non-presidential races, extending the presidential series to 1960 using the Kanter archive. Panel A plots, as in Figure 1, cultural content as a share of all content classified as either cultural or economic. Panel B plots each political family as a share of all economic, cultural, mixed, and process content, excluding nonpolitical content. Each issue code assigned to an ad receives mass equal to one over the number of codes assigned to that ad. Topic assignments are described in Appendix A.

Appendix Figure B2: Prevalence of top-level categories in broadcast and cable over time

(a) Cultural share of economic and cultural content

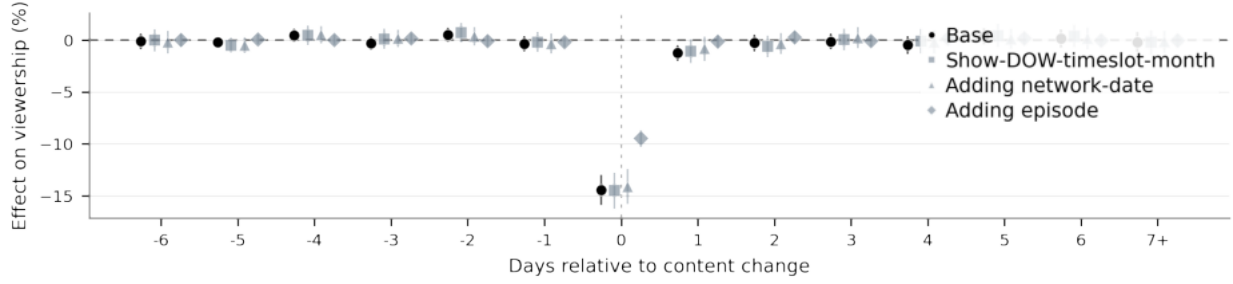


(b) Top-level political families



Notes: As in Figure 1, in each year, we plot cultural content as a share of all content classified as either cultural or economic. The broadcast series uses the Vanderbilt Television News Archive until 2014 and TVArchive thereafter. The cable series uses Vanderbilt and LexisNexis until 2014 and TVArchive thereafter. Topic assignments are described in Appendix A. Cable and broadcast series are smoothed with four-year rolling means.

Appendix Figure B3: Effect of advertising on TV viewership



Notes: Figure plots estimates of $\{\beta_m\}_{m=-6}^7$ from various specifications of Equation 1, with β_{-7} normalized to 0. The dependent variable is (logged) total seconds watched of the fifteen-minute segment, computed from FourthWall. The explanatory variable of interest is the share of the segment devoted to commercial advertising. All specifications take the network-by-timeslot as the panel unit and the calendar date as the running variable. The base specification controls for calendar date fixed effects, show-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects, and show-by-timeslot-by-day-of-week fixed effects; additional specifications fully control for show-by-day-of-week-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects, add network-by-date fixed effects, and add fixed effects for the particular 60-minute episode. We display 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Figure B4: Effect of topics on cable viewership



Notes: Figure plots estimates of β_0 from Equation 1, separately for each of the 80 topics displayed in Figure 2. The specification is the same as the preferred “base” specification of Figure 4: calendar date fixed effects, show-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects, and show-by-timeslot-by-day-of-week fixed effects. Point size is proportional to summed prevalence across campaign ads, cable news, and broadcast news. The dependent variable is (logged) total seconds watched of the fifteen-minute segment, computed from FourthWall. The explanatory variable in each row is the corresponding topic’s share of the segment. We display 95% confidence intervals.

B.1 Robustness of cable cultural premium

Capturing channel-surfing viewers The robustness specification in which we condition on tuning in is still downstream of a household’s endogenous decision of *when* to leave their previous channel. Here, we next isolate viewers displaced from their previous channel by the beginning of a commercial break. Because these displacements are triggered by the origin channel’s advertising schedule, both the timing of the resulting exposure to cable news and the composition of the exposed audience are determined independently of cable news content, with the fixed effects accounting for any predictable patterns. Each displacement contributes CNN, Fox News, and MSNBC as candidate destinations, and the outcome is an indicator for whether the viewer watched more than 5, 15, or 30 seconds (depending on column) of the candidate segment, coded as zero for candidate networks the viewer does not tune into. As shown in Panel A of Appendix Table B1, the resulting estimates are consistent with those of Appendix Figure B5. Panels B and C restrict attention to displacements from entertainment programming (Panel B) or broadcast news (Panel C). As discussed in Section 4.4, these results establish that cultural topics’ advantage for mobilization and economic topics’ advantage for poaching extends to the *attraction* margin, rather than solely the *retention* margin documented in Figure 5.

Alternative segment lengths We examine the extent to which the effects change as we change the length of our unit of analysis. Panel B of Appendix Figure B5 presents estimates at the length of a five-minute segment, a fifteen-minute segment (our preferred specification), and an entire sixty-minute episode. The estimated effect remains strong and significant across all specifications, but grows as we increase the duration of the segment. This pattern is consistent with increasing disutility to economic content: viewers may be willing to tolerate five minutes of economic content in anticipation of the episode returning to its typical mix, but are more likely to turn off if the entire episode is economically focused.

Replication using representative sample The FourthWall sample is not representative of the TV-viewing population and is drawn from only the 28 Nielsen media markets from which FourthWall began collecting data in 2015. We therefore replicate the results using the aggregate audience sizes published by Nielsen (The Nielsen Company, 2021). The Nielsen panel upon which audience estimates are based is recruited to be representative of the American TV-viewing population and has been extensively used in prior work (see, e.g., Shapiro et al. 2021; Gentzkow et al. 2024). These data are available only at the hourly level, so we compare them to the hourly variant of the FourthWall analysis above. As shown in Panel C of Appendix Figure B5, the estimates based on the FourthWall and Nielsen data are virtually identical.

Alternative panel setups To evaluate potential pretrends operating at a timescale different from the calendar day and to assess the robustness of the estimates to alternative sources of variation, we present two alternative specifications. The first takes as the panel unit the *show-by-timeslot* (e.g., *Tucker Carlson Tonight* at 8:15pm) and the running variable as the episode number (e.g., the third episode of *Tucker Carlson Tonight* aired since the data begin). The second instead takes as the panel unit the *network-by-day-of-week-by-timeslot* (e.g., Fox News at 8:15pm on Tuesdays) and the running variable as the calendar week. As shown in Panel D of Appendix Figure B5, the estimated effects under these alternative specifications are, if anything, slightly larger than those under our preferred network-by-date specification.

Static specification The event studies above retain only segments for which we have continuous content and viewership data for the full week before and after, discarding approximately half of segment days. As a simpler specification that imposes no window requirement, we estimate Equation 1 setting $P = 0$: a static panel regression of viewership on contemporaneous content under the same fixed effects. Panels A and B of Appendix Table B2 compare the contemporaneous event-study coefficients to their static counterparts across our baseline specification and the three additional show-level-control specifications introduced above. The static estimates closely track the event-study estimates in every specification.

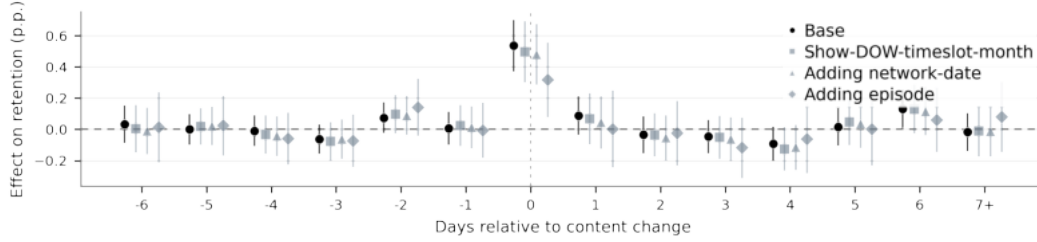
Appendix Table B1: *Cultural content and sustained post-ad-break viewing*

	(1) > 5 seconds	(2) > 15 seconds	(3) > 30 seconds
<i>Panel A: All displacements</i>			
Relative cultural content (p.p.)	0.06*** (0.018)	0.07*** (0.016)	0.07*** (0.015)
Destination-cell observations	446,363	446,363	446,363
<i>Panel B: Entertainment-origin displacements</i>			
Relative cultural content (p.p.)	0.04*** (0.016)	0.06*** (0.015)	0.06*** (0.014)
Destination-cell observations	446,362	446,362	446,362
<i>Panel C: Broadcast-news-origin displacements</i>			
Relative cultural content (p.p.)	-0.15* (0.080)	-0.16** (0.078)	-0.18** (0.078)
Destination-cell observations	216,162	216,162	216,162
Destination-network $\times$ 15-minute timeslot FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Calendar-date FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Show $\times$ timeslot $\times$ month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Show $\times$ timeslot $\times$ day-of-week FE	Yes	Yes	Yes

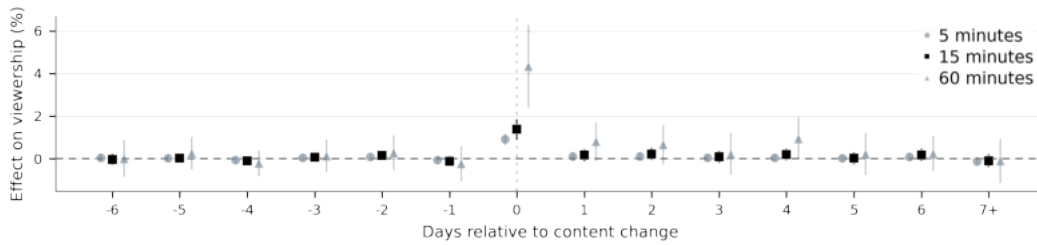
Notes: The unit of observation is a cable news segment. The table examines all viewing spells that began at least 60 seconds before a commercial break and ended within 60 seconds after the break began. Each displacement contributes potential CNN, Fox News, and MSNBC destination options: the dependent variables in Columns 1–3 are the share of these potential options for which the viewer watches the candidate network for more than 5, 15, or 30 seconds, respectively. Candidate networks not watched are coded as zero. Panel A uses displacements originating from any origin. Panel B uses only displacements originating from entertainment programming. Panel C uses only displacements originating from national broadcast news. The explanatory variable is the candidate network’s relative cultural content: cultural minus economic content divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content. All specifications include calendar-date, destination-show-by-timeslot-by-month, and destination-show-by-timeslot-by-day-of-week fixed effects. Standard errors are two-way clustered by destination-network-by-fifteen-minute-timeslot and calendar date. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

Appendix Figure B5: Effect of cultural relative to economic content on TV viewership: robustness

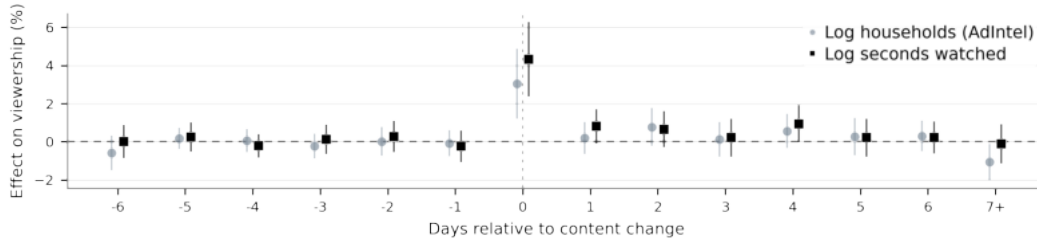
(a) Proportion of segment watched, conditional on tuning in



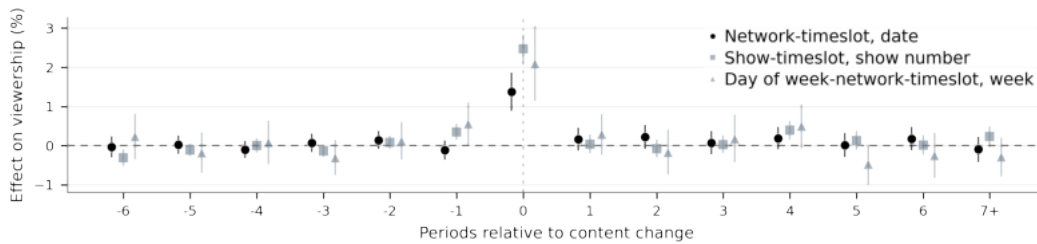
(b) Alternative segment lengths



(c) Comparison with estimates from Nielsen data



(d) Alternative panel specifications



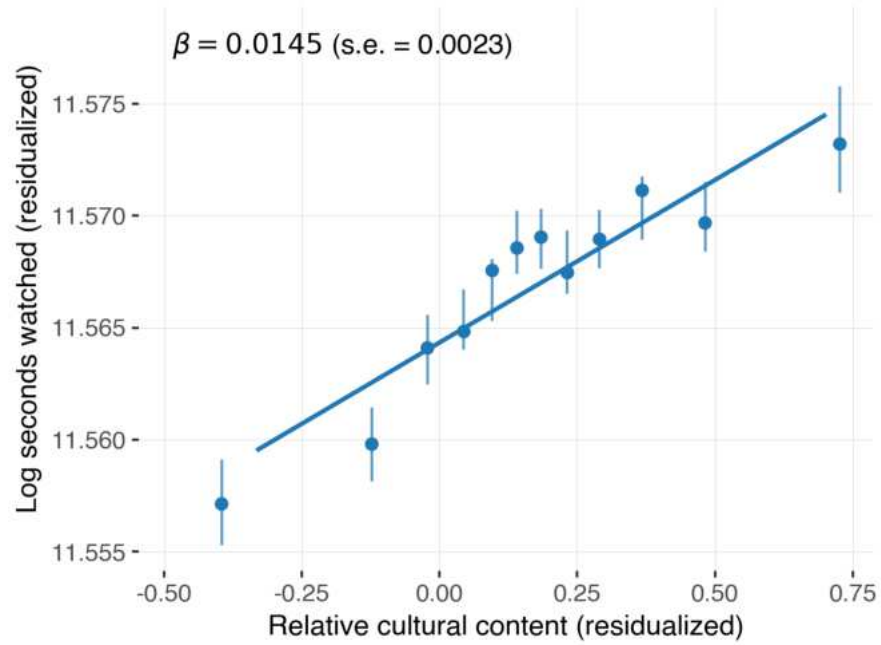
Notes: Figures plot estimates from various versions of Equation 1. The explanatory variable is cultural minus economic content divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content, ranging from -1 to 1 . Panel A replaces the dependent variable with the proportion of the segment the household watched, starting from the second it first tuned into the segment. Panel B presents event-study results from alternative aggregations of the explanatory and dependent variables: 5 minute, 15 minute (our preferred specification), and 60 minute. Panel C replicates the FourthWall estimates using a 60-minute segment length and presents them alongside estimates using the Nielsen data. Panel D shows our default specification, in which the panel variable is a network-timeslot (e.g., Fox News at 8:00–8:15pm) and the time variable is the date, as well as two additional specifications. First, a specification in which the panel variable is the show-timeslot (e.g., *Tucker Carlson Tonight* at 8:00–8:15pm) and the time variable is the episode number since the first episode aired on that show. Second, a specification in which the panel variable is the network-day-of-week-timeslot (e.g., Fox News on Tuesdays at 8:00–8:15pm) and the time variable is the week. We display 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Table B2: Cultural content and viewership across fixed-effect specifications

	<i>Dependent variable: log(seconds viewed)</i>			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
<i>Panel A: Cable, event study, contemporaneous coefficient (β_0)</i>				
Relative cultural content	0.014*** (0.0025)	0.014*** (0.0029)	0.014*** (0.0026)	0.004*** (0.0008)
<i>Panel B: Cable, static specification ($P = 0$)</i>				
Relative cultural content	0.012*** (0.0019)	0.012*** (0.0019)	0.011*** (0.0016)	0.003*** (0.0004)
Observations	447,362	438,446	438,446	438,232
<i>Panel C: Broadcast, static specification ($P = 0$)</i>				
Relative cultural content	0.012 (0.0153)	0.006 (0.0150)	0.007 (0.0138)	0.005 (0.0079)
Observations	34,679	34,473	34,470	34,341
Calendar date FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Show $\times$ timeslot $\times$ month FE	Yes	—	—	—
Show $\times$ timeslot $\times$ day-of-week FE	Yes	—	—	—
Show $\times$ day-of-week $\times$ timeslot $\times$ month FE	—	Yes	Yes	Yes
Network $\times$ date FE	—	—	Yes	—
Episode FE	—	—	—	Yes

Notes: The dependent variable is logged total seconds viewed of the fifteen-minute segment; the explanatory variable is relative cultural content. Relative cultural content is the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content, and ranges from -1 to 1 . Nonpolitical and commercial content is excluded from the denominator. Every sample covers dates before March 10, 2020 and requires each network-show-timeslot cell to appear on at least 90 distinct dates. Panel A reports the contemporaneous ($m = 0$) coefficients from the event-study specifications of Equation 1 plotted in Panel A of Figure 4; the event-study transformation retains the 193,215 of 449,450 segment-days observed over the full window from $t - 7$ through $t + 6$. Panel B reports the corresponding static specifications, which set $P = 0$ in Equation 1 and impose no window requirement. Panel C repeats the static estimator on broadcast news, using the non-local broadcast sample under the same 90-distinct-date recurrence screen. The broadcast event study is not reported: the broadcast schedule is thinner and less continuous, so the event-study transformation retains only 10,901 of 34,387 broadcast segment-days, which is why the static estimator is the one used for broadcast in the main text. Every specification includes network-by-timeslot fixed effects, directly or by absorption into the show-level interactions. Standard errors, in parentheses, are two-way clustered by network-timeslot and calendar date. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

Appendix Figure B6: *Effect of cultural relative to economic content on TV viewership: binned scatterplot*



Notes: Figure presents a binned scatterplot, constructed following Cattaneo et al. (2024), of the static specification of Section B.1: Equation 1 with $P = 0$, a static panel regression of viewership on contemporaneous content under the same fixed effects. The dependent variable is (logged) total seconds watched of the fifteen-minute segment, computed from FourthWall. The explanatory variable is cultural minus economic content divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content, ranging from -1 to 1 . Both variables are residualized on the fixed effects of the preferred “base” specification of Figure 4 — calendar date fixed effects, show-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects, and show-by-timeslot-by-day-of-week fixed effects — and recentered at their sample means, with the number of bins selected by the IMSE direct-plug-in procedure. We display 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Table B3: *Robustness of cable cultural premium gradient to alternative broadcast-news availability measures*

	(1) Recurring schedule	(2) Actual: any Big-3	(3) Actual: Big-3 fraction
Relative cultural content $\times$ availability	-0.0190*** (0.0062)	-0.0305*** (0.0083)	-0.0422*** (0.0107)
Availability p10	0.001	0.004	0.002
Availability p90	0.790	0.712	0.482
Cultural premium at p10	0.021	0.025	0.024
Cultural premium at p90	0.006	0.004	0.004
Implied p10–p90 audience change (%)	-2.96	-4.23	-3.97
Observations	181,359	161,898	161,898
Network $\times$ timeslot clusters	253	253	253
Date clusters	1,878	1,614	1,614
Calendar-date FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Show $\times$ timeslot $\times$ month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Show $\times$ timeslot $\times$ day-of-week FE	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: The table reports the contemporaneous coefficient on relative cultural content interacted with alternative measures of broadcast news availability. Relative cultural content is the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content, and ranges from -1 to 1 . Column 1 uses the recurring year-by-day-of-week-by-half-hour availability measure underlying Figure 6. Column 2 uses the Nielsen-TV-household-weighted share of eligible media markets in which at least one local ABC, CBS, or NBC affiliate carries national news. Column 3 instead uses the corresponding household-weighted mean fraction of ABC, CBS, and NBC available: for example, a slot in which only one network is available contributes $1/3$. All specifications are otherwise as in Figure 6. Standard errors are two-way clustered by network-timeslot and calendar date. The implied audience change applies the estimated interaction over each treatment's 10th-to-90th-percentile range to a full economic-to-cultural content shift. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the 10%, 5%, and 1% levels.

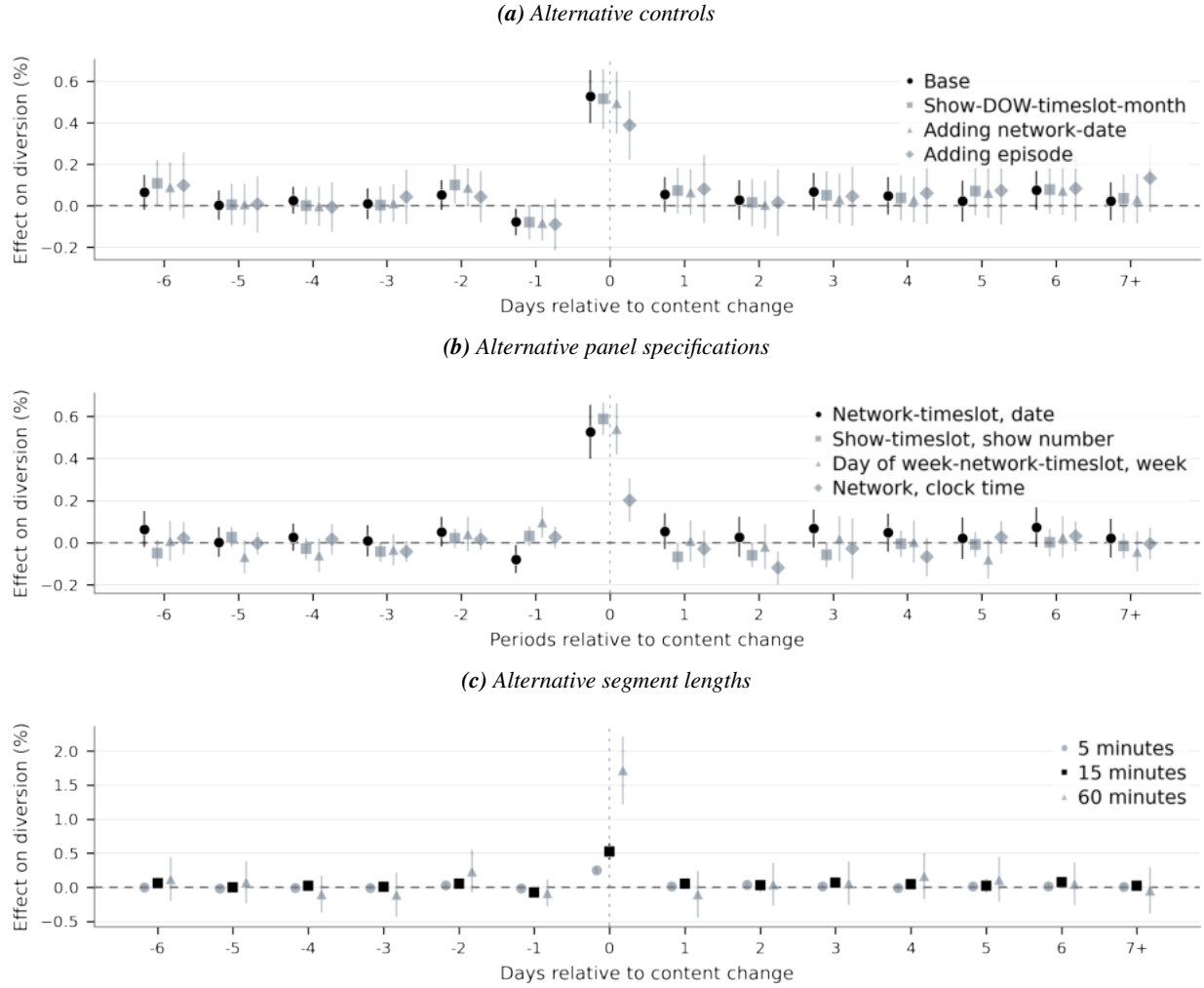
B.2 Further results on poaching vs. mobilization flows on cable

Appendix Figure B7: Effect of topics on cable diversion



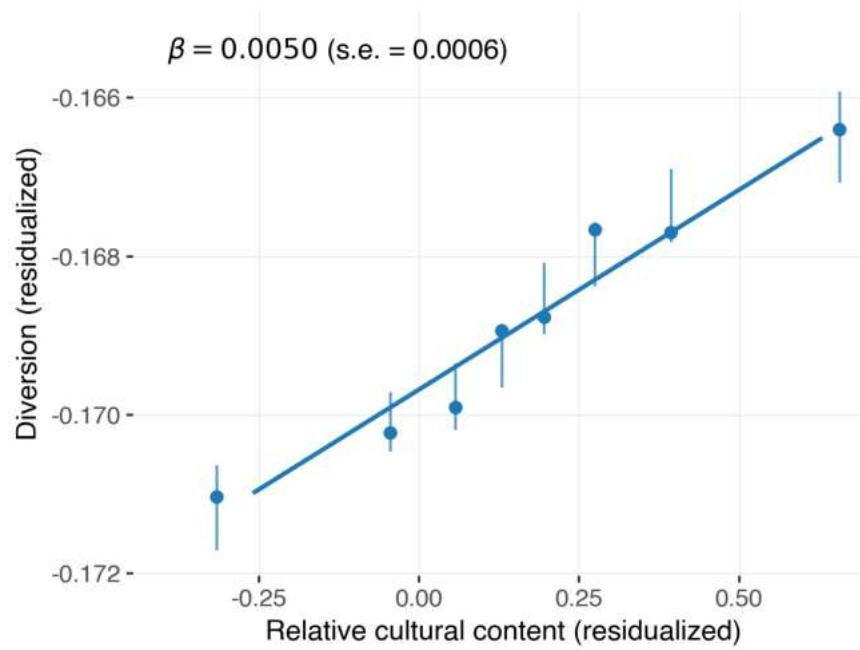
Notes: Figure plots estimates of β_0 from Equation 1, separately for each of the 80 topics displayed in Figure 2. The specification is the same as the preferred “base” specification of Figure 4: calendar date fixed effects, show-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects, and show-by-timeslot-by-day-of-week fixed effects. Point size is proportional to summed prevalence across campaign ads, cable news, and broadcast news. The dependent variable is cable diversion, measured as the share switching to competing news minus the share switching to non-news options (turning off the TV or switching to entertainment), computed from FourthWall. The explanatory variable in each row is the corresponding topic’s share of the segment. We display 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Figure B8: Effect of cultural relative to economic content on cable diversion: robustness



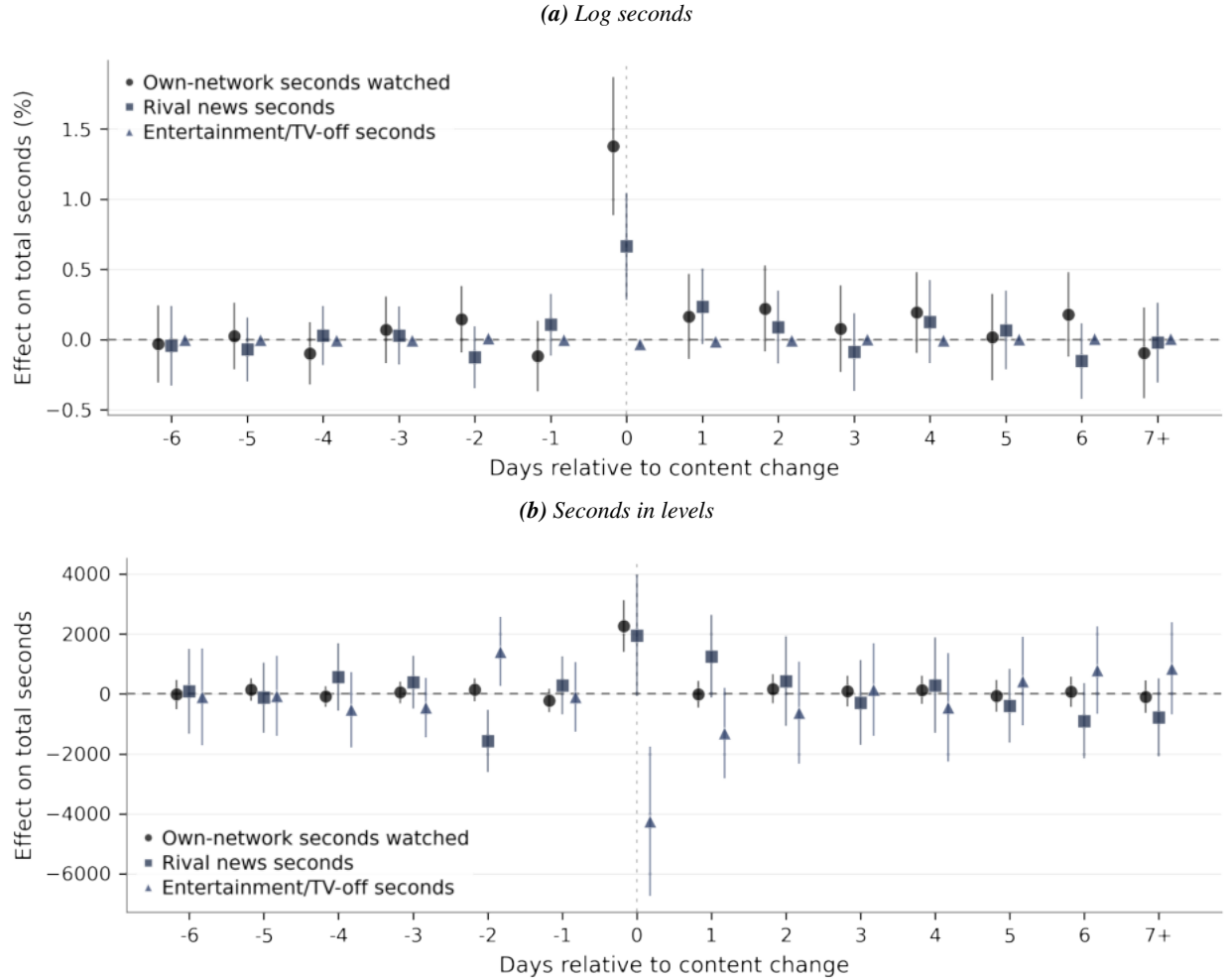
Notes: Figure replicates the robustness checks in Figure 4 and Appendix Figure B5, using as the dependent variable the share switching to competing news channels minus the share switching to an entertainment channel or turning off the TV. The explanatory variable is cultural minus economic content divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content, ranging from -1 to 1 . In Panel A, the base specification controls for calendar date fixed effects, show-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects, and show-by-timeslot-by-day-of-week fixed effects; additional specifications fully control for show-by-day-of-week-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects, add network-by-date fixed effects, and add fixed effects for the particular 60-minute episode. Panel B shows our default specification, in which the panel variable is a network-timeslot (e.g., Fox News at 8:00–8:15pm) and the time variable is the date, as well as three additional specifications. First, a specification in which the panel variable is the show-timeslot (e.g., *Tucker Carlson Tonight* at 8:00–8:15pm) and the time variable is the episode number since the first episode aired on that show. Second, a specification in which the panel variable is the network-day-of-week-timeslot (e.g., Fox News on Tuesdays at 8:00–8:15pm) and the time variable is the week. Third, a specification in which the panel variable is the network and the time variable is the clock time. Panel C presents event-study results from alternative aggregations of the explanatory and dependent variables: 5 minute, 15 minute (our preferred specification), and 60 minute. We display 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Figure B9: *Effect of cultural relative to economic content on cable diversion: binned scatterplot*



Notes: Figure presents a binned scatterplot, constructed following Cattaneo et al. (2024), of the static specification of Section B.1: Equation 1 with $P = 0$, a static panel regression of diversion on contemporaneous content under the same fixed effects. The dependent variable is the share switching to competing news channels minus the share switching to an entertainment channel or turning off the TV, computed from FourthWall. The explanatory variable is cultural minus economic content divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content, ranging from -1 to 1 . Both variables are residualized on the fixed effects of the preferred “base” specification of Figure 4 — calendar date fixed effects, show-by-timeslot-by-month fixed effects, and show-by-timeslot-by-day-of-week fixed effects — and recentered at their sample means, with the number of bins selected by the IMSE direct-plug-in procedure. We display 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Figure B10: Effect of cultural relative to economic content on viewing destinations



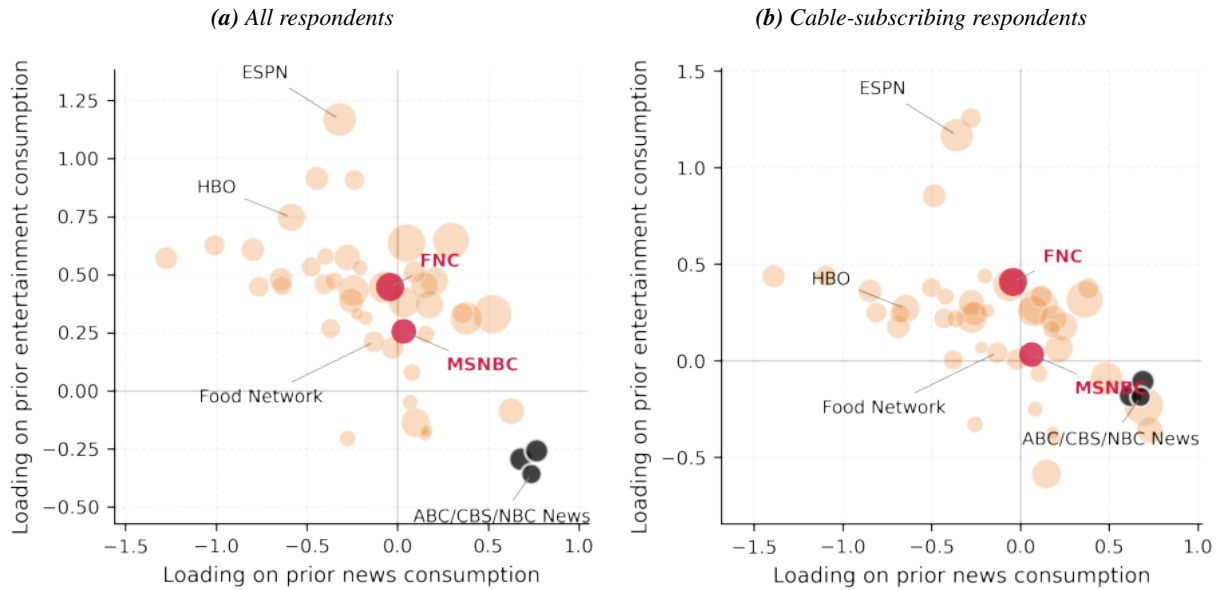
Notes: Panels plot estimates of $\{\beta_m\}_{m=-6}^7$ from the preferred “base” specification of Equation 1 used in Figure 4. The explanatory variable is relative cultural content, defined as the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content, ranging from -1 to 1 . The three dependent variables are total seconds spent watching the focal network; total seconds spent watching the other five news networks; and total entertainment/TV-off seconds. Rival-news and entertainment/TV-off seconds are computed over every household in the FourthWall panel, whether or not the household watched the focal segment. Panel A applies $\log(y + 1)$ to each outcome and reports coefficients in percent; Panel B reports the outcomes in seconds. Both panels control for calendar-date, show-by-timeslot-by-month, and show-by-timeslot-by-day-of-week fixed effects. We display 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Table B4: The MRI television viewership module

Panel A: Survey waves and measured programs					
	Wave	Respondents	Cable subscribers	Programs measured	
				News	Entertainment
	1992	20,103	12,021	41	288
	1993	20,124	12,126	59	414
	1994	20,074	12,896	56	384
	1995	20,083	12,944	58	400
	1998	22,637	15,169	61	460
	1999	25,060	17,081	64	441
Panel B: Programs watched in the past seven days					
	Mean	SD	Median	Watched none	
<i>Pre-entry training waves (1992–1995)</i>					
News programs	5.13	4.53	4	0.097	
Entertainment programs	25.94	20.88	21	0.011	
<i>Entry window (1998–1999)</i>					
News programs	5.13	4.94	4	0.136	
Entertainment programs	31.10	24.35	26	0.008	

Notes: Table presents summary statistics for the MRI Survey of the American Consumer media module. Every show is classified as news or entertainment programming; a small number of shows we were unable to identify are dropped. Panel A reports, for each wave, the number of respondents, the number of respondents subscribing to cable, and the number of news and entertainment items MRI fielded in that wave. Panel B pools the waves in each estimation sample (the pre-entry waves used to train the prediction and the post-entry waves used to estimate the second stage; 1998 is the first wave measuring Fox News and MSNBC viewing).

Appendix Figure B11: Predictiveness of demographic groups' prior news and entertainment consumption for network viewership



Notes: The figure extends Figure 7 to every network in the MRI television viewership module. Each point is a network in the module. Its coordinates are the two coefficients from a regression of a (within-wave z -scored) indicator for whether the respondent reported watching the network in the past seven days jointly on the respondent's predicted news viewership (horizontal axis) and predicted entertainment viewership (vertical axis), with survey-wave fixed effects. Panel A uses all respondents in the 1998 and 1999 waves; Panel B limits the sample to cable-subscribing respondents. Predictions come from LASSO models trained on the corresponding sample in the 1992–1995 waves to predict the (within-wave z -scored) number of news programs and entertainment programs each respondent watches, using as covariates the demographic variables available in MRI (age, education, income, household composition, race, gender, marital status, presence of children, Hispanic ethnicity, employment status, satellite access, county size, and Census region) and the nine demographic and socioeconomic characteristics of the respondent's media market that we use as market-level controls throughout the paper. Broadcast news points are the flagship evening newscasts on ABC, CBS, and NBC. Points are sized based on the number of households reporting watching the show.

C Additional Results on the Returns to Culture for Politicians

This appendix collects additional results examining the relationship between campaign advertising content and electoral outcomes. Section C.1 examines the robustness of the estimates in Table 1 to the choice of controls. Section C.2 disaggregates the win and diversion associations by office, party, incumbency, race competitiveness, time period, and ad sponsorship. Section C.3 contrasts cultural emphasis with ideological extremity across primary and general elections, and Section C.4 reports topic-by-topic estimates. As discussed in Section 5.3, the variation in campaign content is not experimental, and we view these results as descriptive.

C.1 Robustness to controls

Appendix Table C1 re-estimates the win and diversion columns of Table 1 under progressively more demanding specifications. Column 1 includes incumbency-by-office, party-by-office-by-year, and party-by-constituency-by-office fixed effects; Column 2 adds the economic controls interacted with party and with incumbency; Column 3 adds the party-interacted lagged candidate vote and prior poaching and mobilization, matching the preferred specification in Table 1; and Column 4 controls for the candidate’s and opponent’s ideological extremity, the opponent’s advertising content, and both campaigns’ advertising volume. The Column 4 additions are “bad controls” plausibly themselves shaped by the candidate’s content choices, but we report them to assess how much of the association they absorb. Across specifications, more cultural campaigns are consistently less successful than less cultural campaigns, and consistently generate greater diversion.

C.2 Heterogeneity

Appendix Figure C1 estimates the win and diversion associations by subgroup. In each block, we interact relative cultural emphasis and the full control set with the indicated dimension, keeping the fixed effects of Table 1 common across groups. In the final block, we re-estimate the pooled model with content measured from candidate-sponsored or outside-group advertising alone. The point estimate for the win association is negative, and the point estimate for the diversion coefficient positive, in most, but not all, subgroups. We find that measuring content from candidate-sponsored advertising alone yields estimates close to the pooled estimates.

C.3 Election stage and ideological extremity

In Appendix Table C3, we contrast the correlation of cultural messaging with victory with the correlation of ideological extremity with victory, comparing primary to general elections. Cultural emphasis is associated with lower win probability in both stages: -3.6 (s.e. 2.7) percentage points per standard deviation in primaries and -5.0 (s.e. 1.9) in general elections. Extremity’s gradient instead flips sign: more ideologically extreme candidates are *more* likely to win primaries, by 6.9 (s.e. 3.0) percentage points per standard deviation, and less likely to win general elections, by 6.3 (s.e. 3.9) percentage points.

Appendix Table C1: Robustness of politician electoral outcomes

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
<i>Panel A: Won election</i>				
Relative cultural emphasis	-5.19*** (1.94)	-5.60*** (1.95)	-5.13*** (1.92)	-5.45** (2.61)
Dependent-variable mean	50.0	50.0	50.0	50.0
<i>Panel B: Diversion</i>				
Relative cultural emphasis	0.90** (0.35)	0.95*** (0.35)	0.93*** (0.34)	0.76** (0.33)
Dependent-variable mean	-28.1	-28.1	-28.1	-28.1
Economic controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Candidate-vote and prior-flow controls	No	No	Yes	Yes
Candidate/opponent campaign controls	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	1,258	1,258	1,258	1,258

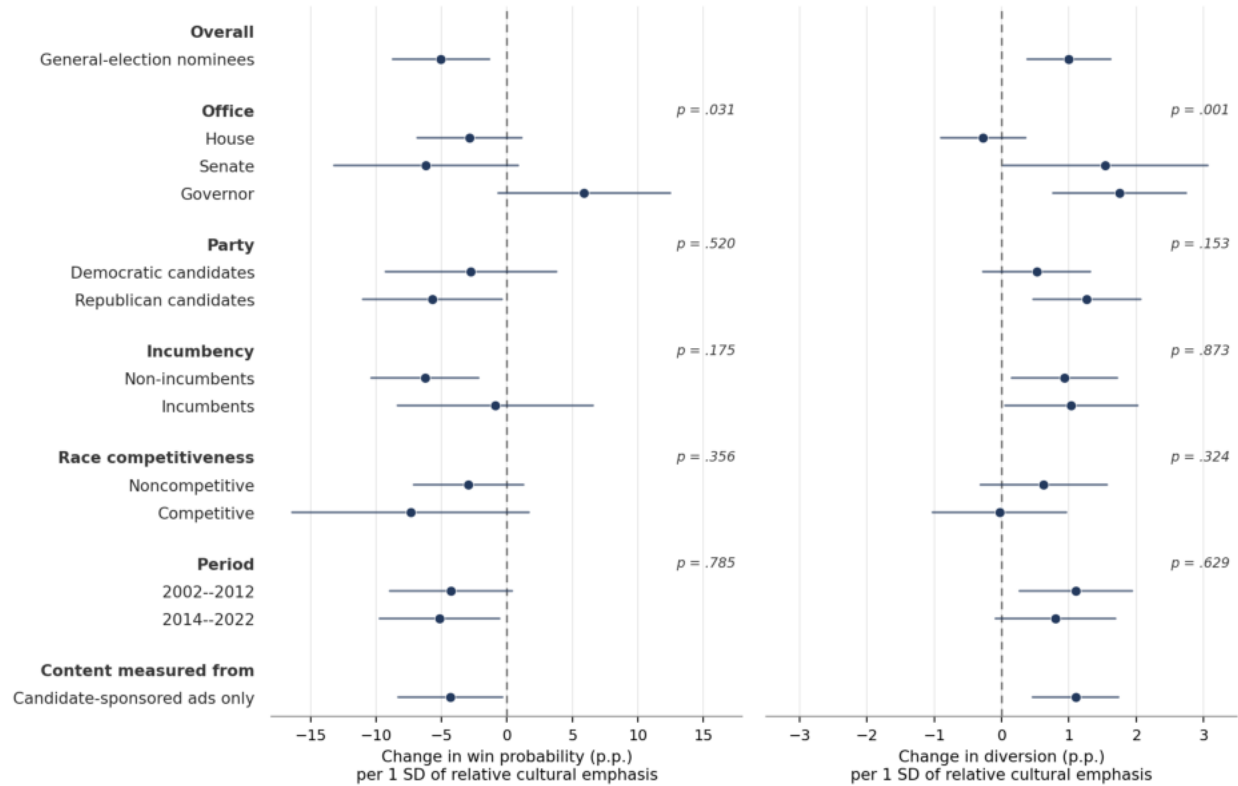
Notes: The unit of observation is a candidate-year. The sample comprises major-party House, Senate, and gubernatorial general-election candidates from 2000–2022 in contested races in which the top two candidates both aired at least one campaign advertisement after the primary. Every column uses one common sample: the estimation sample of Table 1, restricted to candidates for which the Column 4 campaign controls are observed. Relative cultural emphasis is the cultural share minus the economic share of the candidate’s advertising, divided by the sum of the cultural, economic, process, and mixed content shares and standardized within office. In Panel A, the dependent variable is an indicator for whether the candidate wins. In Panel B, the dependent variable, “diversion,” is the highest-vote opponent’s share of the eligible population minus the outside-option share, where the outside option combines abstention and votes for all remaining candidates. Coefficients, standard errors, and dependent-variable means are multiplied by 100 and expressed in percentage points. Every column includes incumbency-by-office controls, demographic controls interacted with party, and party-by-office-by-year and party-by-constituency-by-office fixed effects. Column 2 adds the economic controls interacted with party and with incumbency. Column 3 adds party interactions with lagged candidate two-party vote, prior poaching, and prior mobilization, matching the specification of Table 1. Column 4 adds office-specific slopes for the candidate’s and opponent’s ideological extremity, the opponent’s advertising content, and both campaigns’ advertising volume. The demographic controls are log population, log population density, and the population shares without a high school degree, with a bachelor’s degree, with a postgraduate degree, ages 18–34, 35–54, 55–64, and 65 and older, Black, male, rural, Evangelical, and Hispanic. The economic controls are labor-force participation, the unemployment rate, and log per-capita income. All columns weight candidates by the population of their constituency. We cluster standard errors at the race level. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

Appendix Table C2: *Political advertising content and electoral performance by period*

	Won election (1)	Poaching (2)	Mobilization (3)	Diversion (4)
Relative cultural emphasis $\times$ 2000–2006	-4.22* (2.51)	-0.64** (0.26)	0.39 (0.36)	1.03* (0.58)
Relative cultural emphasis $\times$ 2008–2014	-4.54 (3.91)	-0.67* (0.37)	0.29 (0.33)	0.96* (0.58)
Relative cultural emphasis $\times$ 2016+	-6.39** (3.12)	-0.47** (0.21)	0.52 (0.33)	0.99** (0.47)
Equal coefficients (p-value)	0.846	0.835	0.870	0.996
Dependent-variable mean	49.7	-24.0	-52.2	-28.2
Observations	1,263	1,263	1,263	1,263

Notes: The unit of observation is a candidate-year. The sample comprises major-party House, Senate, and gubernatorial general-election candidates from 2000–2022 in contested races in which the top two candidates both aired at least one campaign advertisement after the primary. Relative cultural emphasis is the cultural share minus the economic share of the candidate’s advertising, divided by the sum of the cultural, economic, process, and mixed content shares and standardized within office. The three rows interact relative cultural emphasis with indicators for 2000–2006, 2008–2014, and 2016 onward. In Column 1, the dependent variable is an indicator for whether the candidate wins. In Column 2, the dependent variable, “poaching,” is the negative of the highest-vote opponent’s share of the eligible population. In Column 3, the dependent variable, “mobilization,” is the negative of the outside-option share, where the outside option combines abstention and votes for all remaining candidates. In Column 4, the dependent variable, “diversion,” is mobilization minus poaching. Coefficients, standard errors, and dependent-variable means are multiplied by 100 and expressed in percentage points. Every column includes the controls and fixed effects of Table 1. The demographic controls are log population, log population density, and the population shares without a high school degree, with a bachelor’s degree, with a postgraduate degree, ages 18–34, 35–54, 55–64, and 65 and older, Black, male, rural, Evangelical, and Hispanic. The economic controls are labor-force participation, the unemployment rate, and log per-capita income. All columns weight candidates by the population of their constituency. We cluster standard errors at the race level. The equality row reports the p-value from the joint test that the three period coefficients are equal. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

Appendix Figure C1: Political advertising content, electoral performance, and diversion, by subgroup



Notes: Figure plots estimates from interacted versions of Equation 5 under the sample, controls, fixed effects, weights, and clustering of Table 1. The left panel reports the change in win probability, and the right panel the change in diversion, per standard deviation of relative cultural emphasis. Diversion is the highest-vote opponent's share of the eligible population minus the outside-option share, where the outside option combines abstention and votes for all remaining candidates. Within each block, relative cultural emphasis and every control — including incumbency, the party-interacted lagged vote, and the prior poaching and mobilization terms — are interacted with the indicated dimension; the fixed effects are common across groups. Each block's annotation reports the p -value of the test that the block's slopes are equal. The *Overall* row is the estimate from Table 1. The competitiveness block uses the general elections covered by the public Inside Elections archive, and rates a race competitive if the last publicly archived rating dated on or before August 31 was Toss-up, Tilt, Lean, or an equivalent older category. The final block instead re-estimates the pooled model with relative cultural emphasis measured from the candidate's own sponsored advertising alone (1,233 campaigns), standardized within office on its estimation sample. We display 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Table C3: Advertising content and candidate extremity by election stage

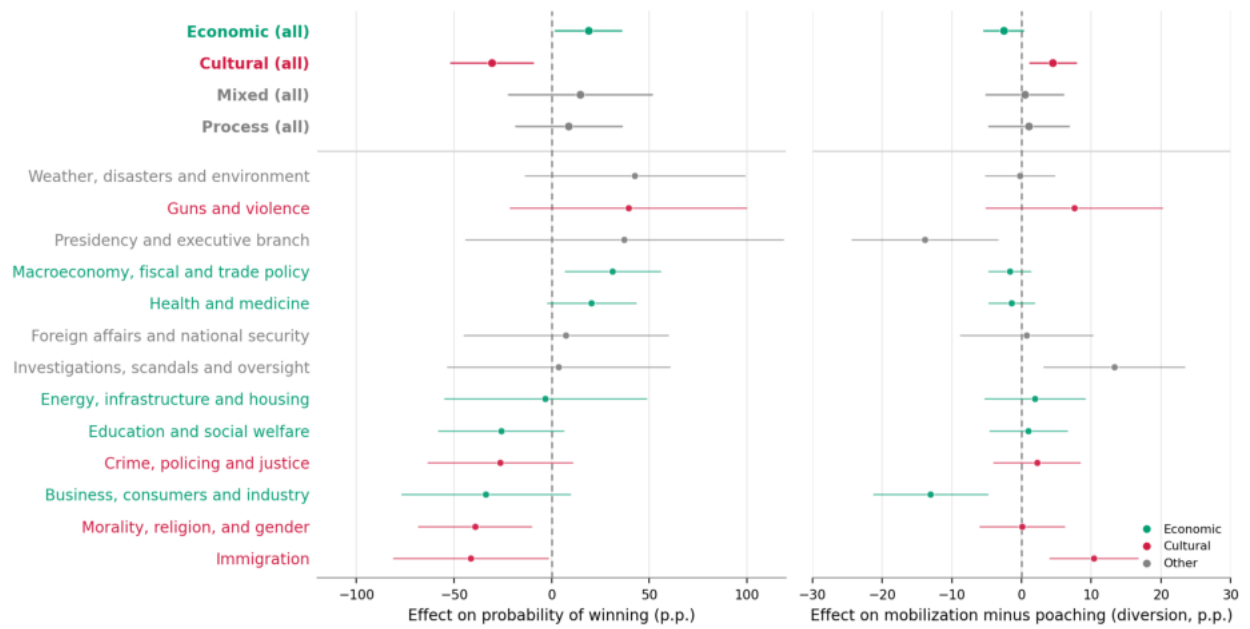
	<i>Dependent variable: Won election or nomination</i>			
	Cultural messaging		Ideological extremity	
	Primaries	Generals	Primaries	Generals
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Relative cultural emphasis	-0.036 (0.0266)	-0.050*** (0.0187)		
Extremity (abs. CFscore, std.)			0.069** (0.0296)	-0.063 (0.0387)
Party $\times$ lagged vote and prior flows	No	Yes	No	Yes
Observations	2,375	1,263	2,375	1,263

Notes: The unit of observation is a candidate-year. Columns 2 and 4 use the sample, general-stage content measure, controls, fixed effects, weights, and clustering of Table 1; the relative cultural emphasis estimate in Column 2 therefore reproduces that table's first column. Columns 1 and 3 use primary campaigns — primary-only losing campaigns plus linked primary winners — measured on their pre-primary advertising, with relative cultural advertising defined as the cultural share minus the economic share of the candidate's advertising, divided by the sum of the cultural, economic, process, and mixed content shares and standardized within office on the primary estimation sample. Columns 3 and 4 report the candidate's ideological extremity, the absolute value of the static DIME CFscore standardized on the candidates' within-office distribution, and retain candidates linked to a scored DIME recipient. The primary columns use the same control architecture; the lagged-vote and prior-flow controls are defined for general campaigns only, and within a stage the stage dimension of every fixed effect and control interaction is degenerate, so the stage-invariant forms enter directly. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

C.4 Topic-level estimates

Appendix Figure C2 reports the win and diversion associations for each of the four content families and for the high-level topics comprising at least 1% of general-stage advertising in the estimation sample, and Appendix Figures C3 and C4 extend the estimates to all 80 topics displayed in Figure 2, in each case under the specification of Table 1.

Appendix Figure C2: Political advertising content, electoral performance, and diversion



Notes: Figure plots estimates of Equation 5 for each of the four content families and for the high-level topics used in Figure 4 that comprise at least 1% of general-stage advertising in the estimation sample, using the sample, controls, fixed effects, weights, and clustering of Table 1. Each explanatory variable is the share of the candidate's general-stage advertising devoted to the topic and enters one at a time. In the left panel, the dependent variable is an indicator for whether the candidate won; in the right panel, it is diversion, defined as the highest-vote opponent's share of the eligible population minus the outside-option share, where the outside option combines abstention and votes for all remaining candidates. A positive diversion coefficient indicates that the content is more positively associated with mobilization than with poaching. We display 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Figure C3: Correlation between political advertising content and electoral success



Notes: Figure presents estimates of Equation 5 for the 80 topics displayed in Figure 2, using the same specification as in Table 1 but with different explanatory variables: the share of the candidate's general-stage advertising classified in the corresponding topic. The dependent variable is an indicator for whether the candidate won the election. We present 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Figure C4: Political advertising content and diversion toward mobilization



Notes: Figure presents separate diversion estimates for the 80 topics displayed in Figure 2, using the same specification as in Table 1 but with different explanatory variables: the share of the candidate's general-stage advertising classified in the corresponding topic. The dependent variable is diversion, defined as the highest-vote opponent's share of the eligible population minus the outside-option share, where the outside option combines abstention and votes for all remaining candidates. A positive coefficient indicates that the topic is more positively associated with mobilization than with poaching. We present 95% confidence intervals.

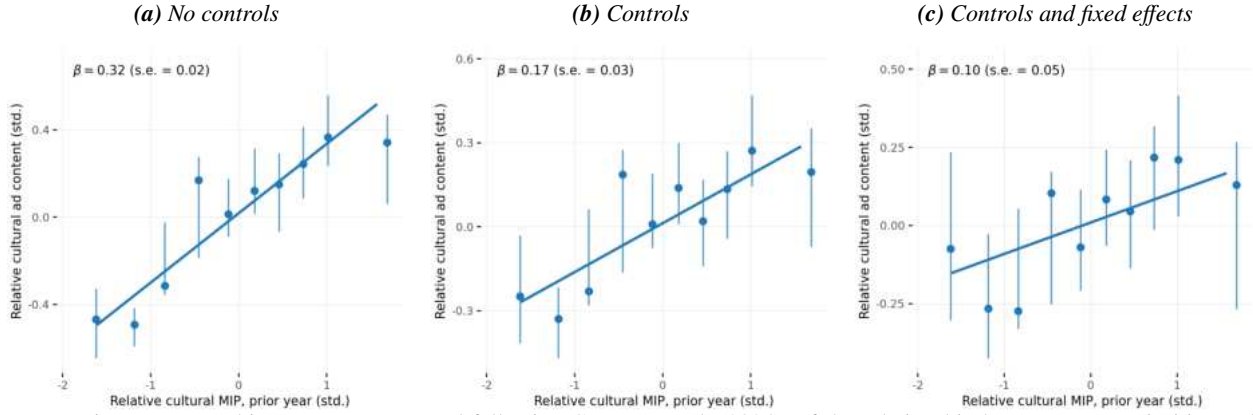
D Additional Results on Changes in Issue Importance

Appendix Table D1: Cable-broadcast coverage gaps and changes in issue importance

	(1) Figure 4	(2) Drop highest leverage	(3) Outcome in levels
<i>Panel A: Gallup Most Important Problem</i>			
Cable – broadcast content-share gap	0.070*** (0.016)	0.048*** (0.013)	0.109* (0.057)
R^2	0.371	0.201	0.215
Top-level topic branches	8	8	8
Observations	17	16	17
<i>Panel B: ANES vote-choice predictiveness</i>			
Cable – broadcast content-share gap	0.050** (0.016)	0.033 (0.017)	0.096 (0.190)
R^2	0.564	0.353	0.037
Top-level topic branches	6	6	6
Observations	11	10	11
<i>Panel C: Political advertising</i>			
Cable – broadcast content-share gap	0.036** (0.016)	0.047*** (0.014)	0.048** (0.019)
R^2	0.148	0.228	0.140
Top-level topic branches	13	12	13
Observations	37	36	37
Outcome in logs	Yes	Yes	No
Coverage gap in logs	Yes	Yes	Yes
Highest-leverage observation excluded	No	Yes	No

Notes: The unit of observation is a topic. The topic sample and construction in each panel are identical to the corresponding panel of Figure 3. The explanatory variable is the difference between the log cable and log broadcast political-content shares for that topic. In Panel A, the dependent variable is the topic-specific annual linear trend in log Gallup Most Important Problem share from 2000–2023; in Panel B, it is the annual linear trend in log ANES vote-choice predictiveness, using the presidential-election waves between 1996 and 2020 in which the topic is available; and in Panel C, it is the annual linear trend in log airings-weighted political-ad share over election years 2000–2022. Column 1 reproduces the regression plotted in Figure 3. Column 2 re-estimates that regression after dropping the observation with the greatest leverage in Column 1: Social Security in Panels A and B, and Coverage decisions and media criticism in Panel C. Column 3 uses the full Column 1 sample but calculates the trend in the level, rather than the log, of each measure. We cluster standard errors by top-level topic. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

Appendix Figure D1: Voter priorities and candidate advertising across markets



Notes: Figure presents binscatters, constructed following Cattaneo et al. (2024), of the relationship between voter priorities and candidate advertising. The unit of observation is a DMA-cycle-office. The sample comprises general-election House, Senate, and Governor advertising from 2000–2022. The dependent variable is relative cultural advertising, defined as the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed advertising in the DMA. The explanatory variable is the share of the DMA Gallup respondents naming a cultural most important problem minus the share naming an economic one, in the year before the election. Both are standardized, and observations are weighted by the total Gallup survey weight comprising each observation. Panel A includes no controls. Panels B and C add the DMA-level demographic controls used in Table 1. Panel C adds DMA and election-year fixed effects. We display 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Table D2: Summed vs. separate channel-position instruments

	Most Important Problem	Candidate advertising
Summed channel position (preferred)	0.059*** (0.027)	0.440*** (0.154)
First-stage <i>F</i> -statistic	15.94	8.74
Separate channel positions	0.059*** (0.025)	0.454*** (0.154)
First-stage <i>F</i> -statistic	10.08	4.91
Summed: Anderson–Rubin p-value	0.004	0.000
Summed: randomization-inference p-value	0.018	0.010
Separate: Anderson–Rubin p-value	0.007	0.000
Separate: randomization-inference p-value	0.038	0.042
Observations	176,227	2,956

Notes: The table compares the primary just-identified construction, which instruments summed Fox News and MSNBC viewership with summed channel positions, with an alternative specification using the two channel positions separately. Both use the samples, controls, fixed effects, weights, clustering, and viewership and outcome standardization of Column 3 of the corresponding main table. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively, and are based on the Anderson–Rubin statistic.

Appendix Table D3: MIP outcome-construction robustness

	<i>Dependent variable: Relative cultural MIP</i>			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Fox + MSNBC viewership	0.059*** (0.0274)	0.049** (0.0264)	0.052** (0.0267)	0.056*** (0.0257)
95% Bayes bootstrap credible interval	[0.009, 0.141]	[0.003, 0.129]	[0.001, 0.132]	[0.010, 0.126]
Randomization-inference <i>p</i> -value	0.018	0.062	0.036	0.008
Outcome construction	Preferred: first reported	Any mention	3–2–1 ranks	First reported, off-schema = 0
Mean dependent variable	-0.391	-0.421	-0.410	-0.375
First-stage <i>F</i> -statistic	15.94	15.95	15.95	15.96
Anderson–Rubin <i>p</i> -value	0.004	0.016	0.010	0.003
Observations	176,227	177,524	177,524	187,810

Notes: The unit of observation is a Gallup respondent. The sample comprises respondents from 2000–2022. Column 1 defines the dependent variable using the respondent’s first reported most important problem: an indicator for a cultural problem minus an indicator for an economic problem. It requires the first response to map to a cultural, economic, process, or mixed political category. Column 2 defines the outcome as an indicator for whether any of the respondent’s three reported problems is cultural minus an indicator for whether any is economic. It requires at least one of the three responses to map to a political category; respondents mentioning both a cultural and an economic problem receive zero. Column 3 assigns weights of three, two, and one to the first, second, and third reported problems, respectively, and divides the weighted cultural-minus-economic difference by the total rank weight of the respondent’s mapped political responses. Column 4 uses the first-reported outcome from Column 1 but retains respondents whose recorded first response does not map to the political schema, coding their outcome as zero. Respondents without a recorded first response remain excluded from Columns 1 and 4. Unmapped and nonpolitical responses are ignored in Columns 2 and 3 when another response is mapped. Every column otherwise uses the specification in Column 3 of Table 3. The primary explanatory variable is the standardized sum of Fox News and MSNBC viewership, instrumented with the sum of the networks’ channel positions. Every column includes year-by-state fixed effects; respondent age, race, education, and sex; fixed-1996 county log population, log population density, age-65-plus share, and log per-capita income; and contemporaneous county population, population density, educational attainment, age, race, sex, rural, Evangelical, Hispanic, labor-force participation, unemployment, and per-capita-income controls. The dependent variable and explanatory variable are divided by their unweighted standard deviations within each column’s estimation sample. Bracketed intervals are equal-tailed 95 percent credible intervals from 500 DMA-clustered Bayesian-bootstrap draws. Randomization-inference *p*-values permute the paired channel positions across DMAs, sum them within each draw, and recompute the Anderson–Rubin statistic over 500 draws. We weight observations by Gallup’s provided survey weights and cluster standard errors at the DMA level. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively, based on the Anderson–Rubin statistic.

Appendix Table D4: Cable-news exposure and relative cultural MIP, by network

	<i>Dependent variable: Relative cultural MIP</i>			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: Fox News only				
Standardized Fox News viewership	0.053** (0.0233) [0.021, 0.153]	0.050** (0.0223) [0.013, 0.119]	0.065** (0.0287) [0.013, 0.146]	0.052* (0.0291) [-0.002, 0.126]
Anderson–Rubin p-value	0.001	0.003	0.002	0.020
First-stage <i>F</i> -statistic	9.59	10.23	13.21	12.47
Effect of a 10% increase in ratings	0.012	0.011	0.014	0.011
Panel B: MSNBC only				
Standardized MSNBC viewership	0.059* (0.0348) [0.009, 0.218]	0.052* (0.0310) [0.006, 0.169]	0.055 (0.0566) [-0.567, 0.531]	0.028 (0.0342) [-0.179, 0.568]
Anderson–Rubin p-value	0.005	0.009	0.097	0.314
First-stage <i>F</i> -statistic	6.41	7.47	2.47	3.54
Effect of a 10% increase in ratings	0.011	0.009	0.010	0.005
Demographic controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Economic controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Voting controls	No	No	No	Yes
Year × state FE	No	No	Yes	Yes
Year × respondent-party FE	No	No	No	Yes
Mean dependent variable	-0.391	-0.391	-0.391	-0.391
Observations	176,236	176,227	176,227	175,943

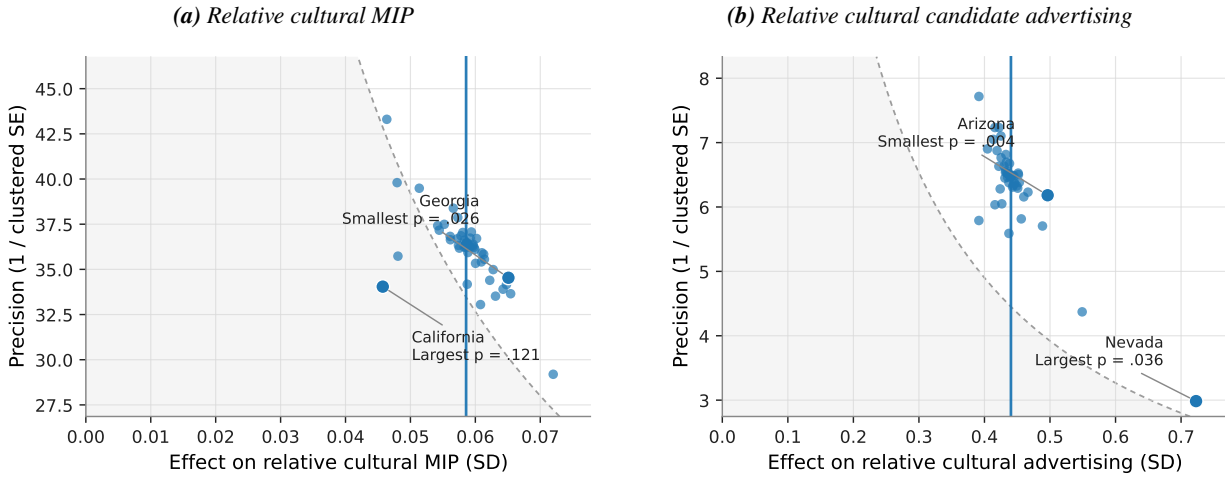
Notes: The unit of observation is a Gallup respondent. The sample comprises respondents from 2000–2022. The dependent variable codes the respondent’s first reported most important problem as one for cultural, minus one for economic, and zero otherwise, divided by its unweighted standard deviation within each column’s estimation sample. Panels A and B respectively instrument standardized Fox News and MSNBC viewership with that network’s channel position. In each panel, viewership is divided by its unweighted standard deviation within each column’s estimation sample. Columns 1 and 2 include year fixed effects. Every column includes respondent age, race, education, and sex; and the county’s demographic controls: fixed-1996 log population, log population density, and age-65-plus share, and contemporaneous log population, log population density, and the population shares without a high school degree, with a bachelor’s degree, with a postgraduate degree, ages 18–34, 35–54, 55–64, and 65 and older, Black, male, rural, Evangelical, and Hispanic. Column 2 adds the economic controls: fixed-1996 log per-capita income, labor-force participation, the unemployment rate, and log per-capita income. Column 3 replaces the year fixed effects with year-by-state fixed effects. Column 4 adds controls for lagged county Republican presidential vote and respondent party identification and ideology, together with year-by-responder-party fixed effects. Bracketed intervals are equal-tailed 95 percent credible intervals from 500 Bayesian-bootstrap draws clustered at the same level as the standard errors. Each panel’s Anderson–Rubin p-values test the null of a zero effect and are robust to weak instruments. We weight by Gallup’s provided survey weights and cluster standard errors at the DMA level. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

Appendix Table D5: Cable-news exposure and candidate advertising content, by network

	<i>Dependent variable: Relative cultural ad content</i>					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Panel A: Fox News only						
Standardized Fox News viewership	0.394*	0.411*	0.422*	0.443*	0.332	0.357
	(0.2081)	(0.2120)	(0.2234)	(0.2240)	(0.2135)	(0.2147)
	[0.085, 1.821]	[0.115, 1.794]	[0.086, 2.570]	[0.100, 2.695]	[-0.147, 1.388]	[-0.025, 1.952]
Anderson–Rubin p-value	0.007	0.005	0.004	0.002	0.117	0.088
First-stage <i>F</i> -statistic	4.97	4.90	4.25	4.14	4.49	4.54
Effect of a 10% increase in ratings	0.099	0.103	0.106	0.112	0.088	0.094
Panel B: MSNBC only						
Standardized MSNBC viewership	0.572**	0.558**	0.502**	0.526**	0.659*	0.700*
	(0.2370)	(0.2441)	(0.1941)	(0.2038)	(0.3729)	(0.4081)
	[0.269, 1.248]	[0.217, 1.305]	[0.220, 1.054]	[0.247, 1.046]	[0.159, 1.535]	[0.136, 1.803]
Anderson–Rubin p-value	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.006	0.006
First-stage <i>F</i> -statistic	7.24	7.20	10.54	10.65	9.42	9.32
Effect of a 10% increase in ratings	0.126	0.123	0.111	0.116	0.148	0.157
Office × year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party × office × year FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Demographic controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Economic controls	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Voting controls	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Campaign controls	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Paired-advertiser sample	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Mean dependent variable	0.121	0.121	0.121	0.121	0.101	0.101
Observations	2,956	2,956	2,956	2,940	1,606	1,606

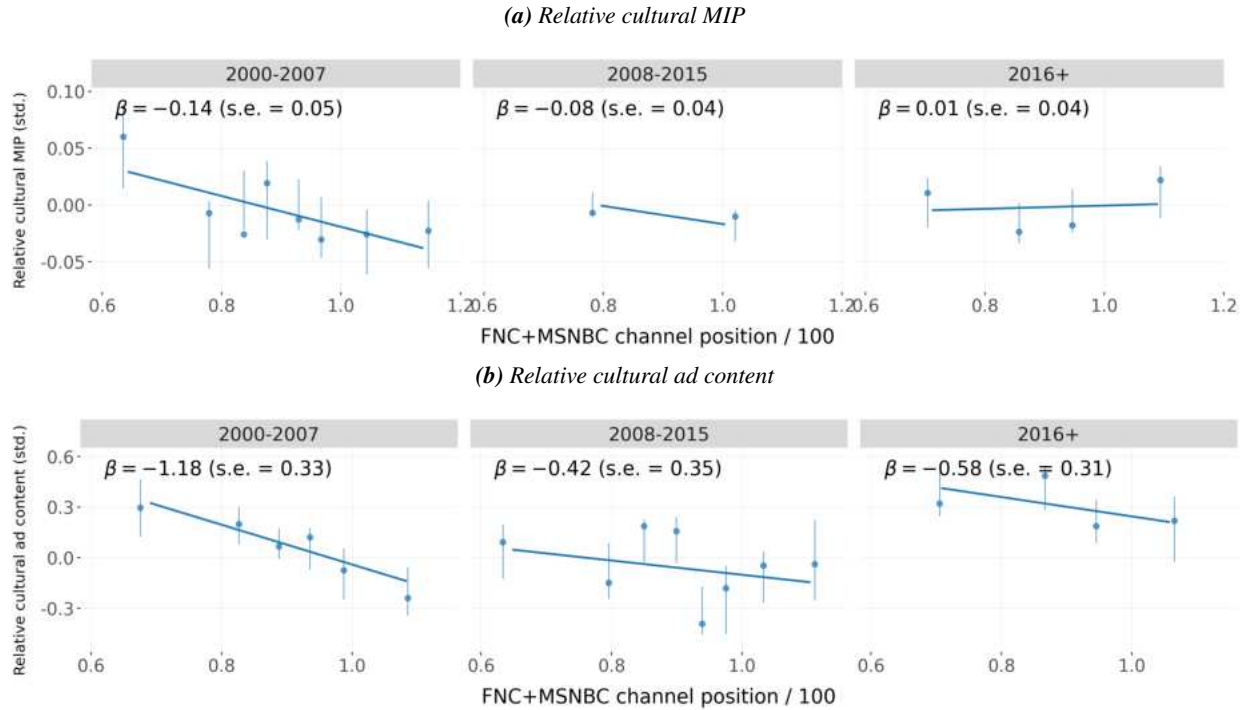
Notes: The unit of observation is a candidate-year. The sample comprises major-party House, Senate, and gubernatorial general-election candidates from 2000–2022. The dependent variable is the candidate’s relative cultural advertising: the cultural share minus the economic share of the candidate’s advertising, divided by the sum of the cultural, economic, process, and mixed content shares and standardized within office. Panels A and B respectively instrument standardized Fox News and MSNBC viewership with that network’s channel position. In each panel, viewership is divided by its unweighted standard deviation within each column’s estimation sample. Every column includes incumbency-by-office fixed effects and the constituency’s demographic controls, interacted with party: fixed-1996 log population, log population density, and age-65-plus share, and contemporaneous log population, log population density, and the population shares without a high school degree, with a bachelor’s degree, with a postgraduate degree, ages 18–34, 35–54, 55–64, and 65 and older, Black, male, rural, Evangelical, and Hispanic. Column 1 includes office-by-year fixed effects. Column 2 replaces them with party-by-office-by-year fixed effects. Column 3 adds the economic controls interacted with party and with incumbency: fixed-1996 log per-capita income, labor-force participation, the unemployment rate, and log per-capita income. Column 4 adds the interaction of party with lagged Democratic two-party candidate-election vote. Column 5 restricts the sample to candidates whose highest-vote opponent also aired classified TV advertising in our sample. Column 6 further controls for the candidate’s and opponent’s standardized extremity (the absolute value of the static DIME CFscore) and own and opponent log ad airings. Bracketed intervals are equal-tailed 95 percent credible intervals from 500 Bayesian-bootstrap draws clustered at the same level as the standard errors. Each panel’s Anderson–Rubin p-values test the null of a zero effect and are robust to weak instruments. We weight by constituency population and cluster standard errors at the state level. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

Appendix Figure D2: Stability of cable-news exposure estimates to omitting individual states



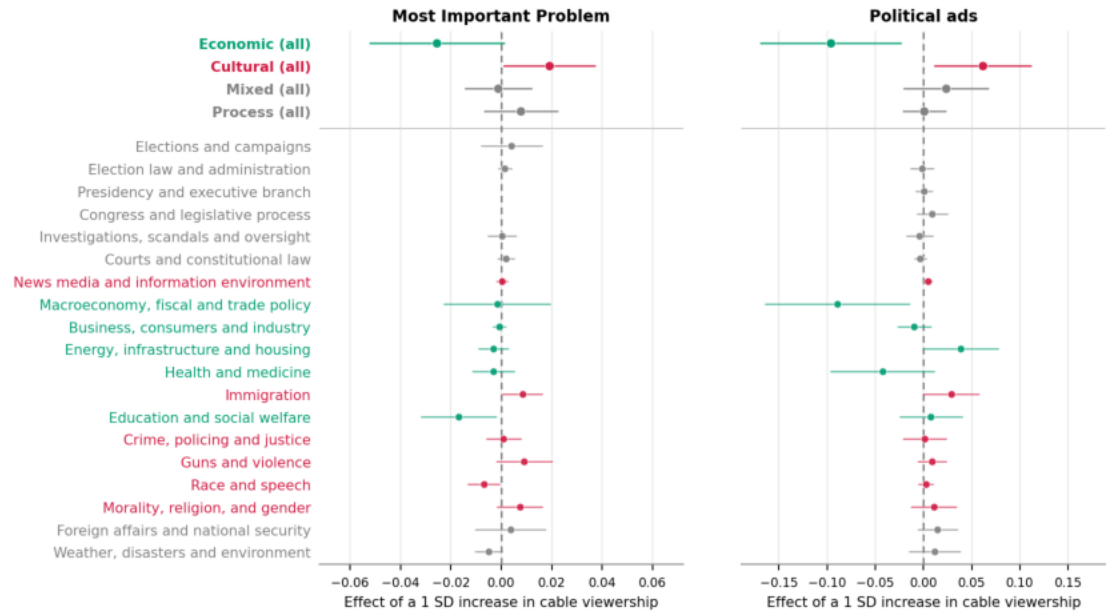
Notes: Figure presents leave-one-state-out estimates of the preferred specifications in Column 3 of Table 3 and Column 3 of Table 4. Each point reestimates the corresponding specification after omitting the indicated state. Panel A reports the MIP estimates. The dependent variable codes the respondent's first reported most important problem as one for cultural, minus one for economic, and zero otherwise, divided by its unweighted standard deviation within each column's estimation sample. Panel B reports the advertising estimates. The dependent variable is the candidate's relative cultural advertising: the cultural share minus the economic share of the candidate's advertising, divided by the sum of the cultural, economic, process, and mixed content shares and standardized within office. The primary explanatory variable is the standardized sum of Fox News and MSNBC viewership, instrumented with the sum of the networks' channel positions. Panel A uses the sample, controls, fixed effects, weights, and clustering of Column 3 of Table 3; Panel B those of Column 3 of Table 4. We weight by Gallup's provided survey weights in Panel A and by constituency population in Panel B. Standard errors are clustered at the DMA level in Panel A and the state level in Panel B. The vertical axis is precision, defined as the inverse of the clustered standard error. The solid vertical line marks the full-sample estimate. The dashed curve marks the region corresponding to statistical significance at the $p < 0.05$ level.

Appendix Figure D3: Reduced-form relationship between voter priority and ad content and channel numbers



Notes: Figure presents reduced-form estimates from regressions of the difference between an indicator for whether the individual mentioned a cultural MIP and an indicator for whether the individual mentioned an economic MIP (Panel A) or relative cultural candidate advertising, defined as the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed advertising (Panel B) on the sum of Fox and MSNBC's channel number in the county. Binscatters are constructed following Cattaneo et al. (2024), with the number of bins selected by the IMSE direct-plug-in procedure. Panel A uses the sample, controls, fixed effects, and weights of Column 3 of Table 3, and Panel B those of Column 3 of Table 4.

Appendix Figure D4: Effects of cable on voter priorities and political advertising



Notes: Figure presents separate 2SLS estimates for each of the four content families, followed by the high-level topics used in Figure 4. The dependent variable is an indicator for whether the respondent's first reported most important problem maps to the topic (left) or the share of the candidate's advertising devoted to the topic (right). The endogenous regressor is the sum of Fox News and MSNBC viewership, instrumented by the sum of their channel numbers and divided by its standard deviation within the estimation sample. The left panel uses the sample, controls, fixed effects, weights, and clustering of Column 3 of Table 3; the right panel those of Column 3 of Table 4. Congress and legislative process has no mapped Most Important Problem response and Elections and campaigns has no candidate advertising, so each appears as a labeled blank row in the corresponding panel. We present 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Table D6: Back-of-the-envelope quantification of effects of cable

	Observed		Counterfactual		
	Baseline	Endpoint	Endpoint, removing...		
			Fox	MSNBC	Both
Panel A: MIP	<i>Relative cultural MIP</i>				
Level	-0.27	0.06	-0.04	0.04	-0.06
1996 → 2019–20 growth explained			30%	8%	38%
Panel B: Ads	<i>Normalized relative cultural ad content</i>				
Level	-0.65	-0.18	-0.52	-0.39	-0.72
2000 → 2022 growth explained			73%	45%	115%

Notes: We compute the counterfactual for each network (or Fox and MSNBC jointly) by multiplying the estimated effect of one rating point (see Appendix Table D4 for effects on MIP and Appendix Table D5 for effects on ads) by the mean cross-sectional rating, and subtracting this value from the observed endpoint. We compute percent of growth explained as $100 \times \frac{y_1^{\text{obs}} - y_1^{\text{cf}}}{y_1^{\text{obs}} - y_0^{\text{obs}}}$, where 0 and 1 index each panel's baseline and endpoint. The MIP baseline is the 1996 annual value from the individual response file of the Most Important Problem Dataset (Yildirim and Williams, 2024); the endpoint is the average value in January 2019–February 2020, the last Gallup fieldwork before the pandemic. In the advertising panel, relative cultural content is the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed advertising; commercial and nonpolitical material are excluded from the denominator. The advertising panel runs 2000 to 2022, so its baseline postdates cable entry by four years.

E Validation and Decomposition of Economic vs. Cultural Topics

This section presents four exercises to validate our family hand-labels (economic, cultural, mixed, process, nonpolitical) of topics, and to examine the sensitivity of our conclusions to these hand-labels.

Section E.1 examines whether the topics we label economic and cultural separate in how they behave across the empirical exercises in the paper; Section E.2 examines how the results change under reasonable alternative assignments of topics to the economic, cultural, and mixed families; and Sections E.3 and E.4 discard the schema altogether in favor of an alternative content basis discovered from the raw segment and ad transcripts. Section E.5 then decomposes the distinction, measuring the emotional register and linguistic complexity of economic and cultural content.

E.1 Separation of economic and cultural topics

First, we examine how much of the systematic variation between topics is captured by the economic vs. cultural hand-labels we assign. We focus on the three sets of topic-level statistics analyzed in this paper: *emphasis* (how much does a given agent talk about a topic?), *performance* (how is issue emphasis associated with viewership or electoral success?), and *diversion* (how much more effective is the topic for mobilization than poaching?). We compute the difference between each topic’s statistic on cable and its statistic on broadcast, and the difference between each topic’s statistic on cable and its statistic for politicians. This yields an $N \times 6$ matrix, where N is the number of political topics with strictly positive prevalence in all three domains and estimable coefficients on all six margins. We extract the first two principal components of this matrix and plot each topic’s loadings in Appendix Figure E1.

The exercise is blind to our labels: the components are extracted from estimated behavior alone. Nonetheless, the topics we label as economic generally clearly separate from those we label as cultural. The first principal component, which accounts for 48.4% of the variance, sorts the two families apart: the average cultural topic sits 1.39 standard deviations of the component away from the average economic topic (permutation test $p < 0.001$).

E.2 Alternative family assignments

Second, we construct narrower definitions of the cultural and economic families, focusing on core policy-relevant topics, and present all results in Appendix Figure E2 under the narrower cultural definition, the narrower economic definition, and both simultaneously. The narrower cultural definition retains in the cultural family only the immigration topics currently assigned to cultural, policing policy and politics, guns, race, women’s rights and gender in public life, abortion, LGBTQ rights and gender identity, religion, and protest and speech. The narrower economic definition retains in the economic family only macroeconomic, employment, wage, tax, fiscal, and trade topics; consumer and energy prices; infrastructure and housing; the health-care system; immigration and the economy; school funding and college costs; social welfare; child care; and pay equity and workforce participation. All other currently cultural or economic topics are assigned to mixed. We also study targeted changes to especially contestable assignments: moving narrative crime and trials (as opposed to crime policy), non-policy policing, race-related events and rhetoric, protest and unrest, or religious institutions to mixed; and moving all immigration topics to economic.

The figure reports six outcomes under all ten assignments: the cable event-study estimates for logged seconds watched and for news diversion, the candidate estimates for electoral victory and candidate diversion,

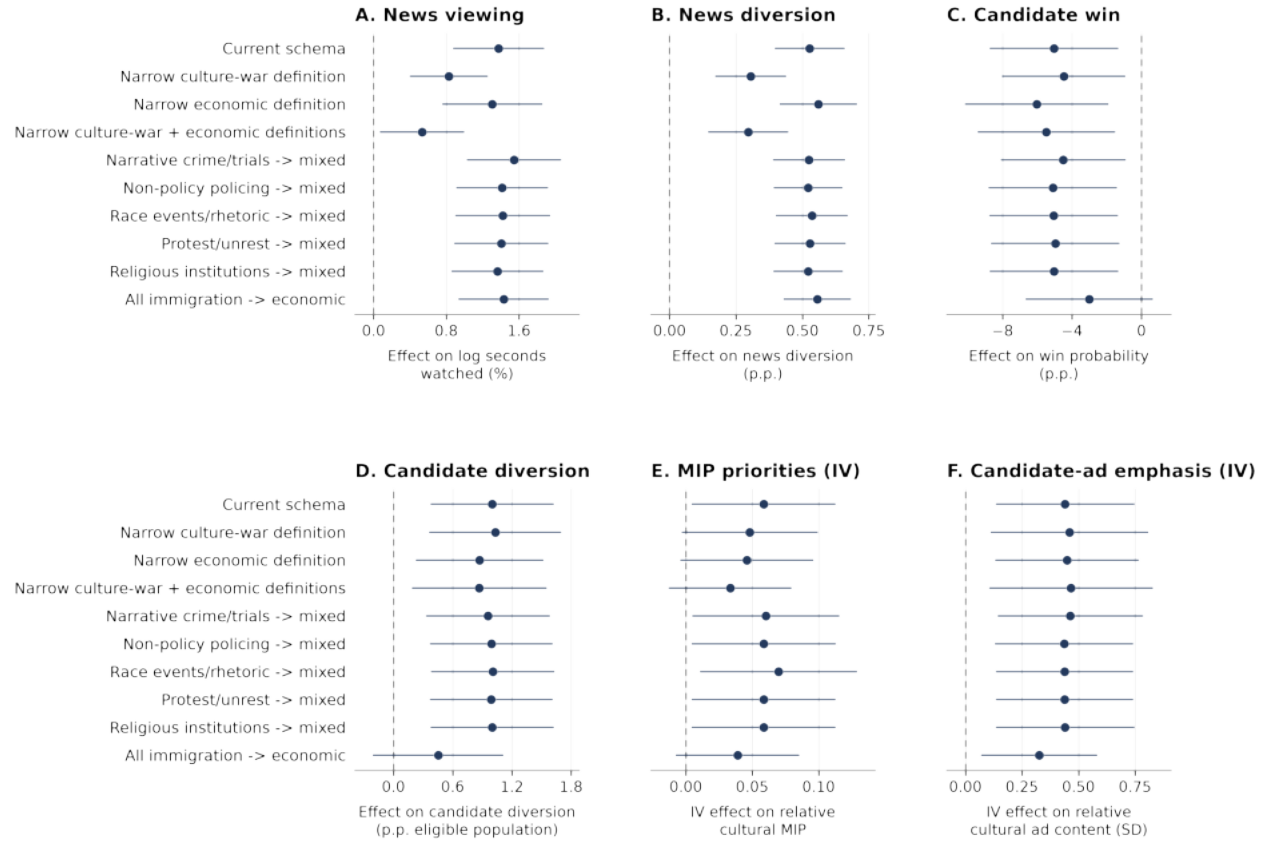
Appendix Figure E1: Validation of “economic” and “cultural” labels



Notes: Figure presents the loadings of each of the topics on the first two principal components of an $N \times 6$ matrix (where $N = 228$ is the number of topics with complete inputs) formed by the following procedure. We take the estimates for the three margins — emphasis, performance, and diversion — for cable news, broadcast news, and candidates, and form two contrasts per margin: cable minus broadcast and cable minus candidates. Emphasis is the log of the shares in Figure 2. The news margins use the static $P = 0$ counterpart of the “base” specification of Figure 4, estimated separately for cable and broadcast. Performance is the topic’s effect on logged seconds watched and diversion its effect on switching to competing news minus switching to non-news options. The candidate margins use the preferred specification of Column 4 of Table 1, with performance the topic’s effect on winning the election and diversion its effect on the highest-vote opponent’s share of the eligible population minus the outside-option share. We winsorize each of the nine supplier-by-margin series at 2.33 standard deviations and standardize it, weighting throughout by the topic’s summed prevalence across campaign ads, cable news, and broadcast news; we apply the same weighted standardization to the six contrasts before extracting components. Point size is proportional to summed prevalence across campaign ads, cable news, and broadcast news. Points are colored by the topic’s assigned family, as reported in Appendix Table A1. We label the high-level topics shown in Panel B of Figure 4.

and the instrumental-variables estimates of the effect of Fox and MSNBC ratings on voters' stated priorities and on candidate advertising. Cable viewing, news diversion, and the candidate-advertising estimate retain their signs and statistical significance throughout; the candidate-win, candidate-diversion, and MIP results remain stable in magnitude but are statistically insignificant in some specifications.

Appendix Figure E2: Robustness to alternative topic-family assignments



Notes: Each row changes the indicated assignment of topics to the economic, cultural, or mixed family, reconstructs the family-level measures, and re-estimates the indicated outcome. The narrow culture-war definition retains as cultural only the existing cultural immigration topics, policing policy and politics, guns, race, women's rights and gender in public life, abortion, LGBTQ rights and gender identity, religion, and protest and speech; all other topics assigned cultural under the current schema are treated as mixed. The narrow economic definition retains as economic only macroeconomic, employment, wage, tax, fiscal, and trade topics; consumer and energy prices; infrastructure and housing; the health-care system; immigration and the economy; school funding and college costs; social welfare; child care; and pay equity and workforce participation. All other topics assigned economic under the current schema are treated as mixed. The joint row applies both narrow definitions. The remaining row labels state the targeted reassignment. Panels A and B report the preferred cable event-study estimates for logged seconds watched and news diversion, using the preferred "base" specification of Figure 4. Panels C and D report the preferred candidate estimates for electoral victory and candidate diversion, using the preferred specification of Column 4 of Table 1. Panels E and F report 2SLS estimates of the effect of Fox and MSNBC ratings, instrumented by their channel numbers, on the relative cultural MIP measure and the normalized candidate-advertising measure, using the preferred specifications of Column 3 of Table 3 and Column 3 of Table 4, respectively. We display 95% confidence intervals.

E.3 Unstructured discovery with sparse autoencoders

Third, we show our key predictions hold using a topic schema discovered entirely from the raw text rather than the schema we designed, in line with recent work using machine learning for hypothesis generation and discovery (Ludwig and Mullainathan, 2024; Movva et al., 2025) and following most closely the approach of

Carlson (2026). We use the Gemma Scope 2 suite of sparse autoencoders (Lieberum et al., 2024; McDougall et al., 2025), which embed inputs using low-dimensional features that fire on specific, frequently human-interpretable patterns in the input text (Bricken et al., 2023; Cunningham et al., 2024; Gao et al., 2024; Templeton et al., 2024).

We generate feature embeddings for each 30-second news segment for cable and broadcast and each 30-second political advertisement. We screen to features occurring in more than 0.1 percent and below 25 percent in all three domains, retaining 6,950 of the 16,384 features. Using these SAE features rather than the schema topics, we re-estimate the three sets of core results in each of the three domains: prevalence, performance, and diversion.

Following Carlson (2026), we use a large language model (OpenAI’s GPT-5.6 Luna) to assign each feature a human-interpretable description. We provide five news and five ad examples per feature, with no information about the source, the outcome, or our hypotheses, and instruct the LLM to generate a description. We use the same LLM to assign each feature a primary label — economic topic, cultural topic, other topic, or not a topic — based on the definition of Shafer and Spady (2014). Of the 6,950 features, 6,516 are labeled *not a topic* — consistent with the interpretability literature’s finding that most SAE features encode lexical, syntactic, entity, formatting, or register patterns — while 149 are other topics, 213 are economic, and 72 are cultural. The economic features cover employment, wages, Social Security, prices, trade, health care, and education; the cultural features cover crime and criminal justice, immigration, abortion, guns, religion, LGBTQ identity, family, drugs, patriotism, and social identity.

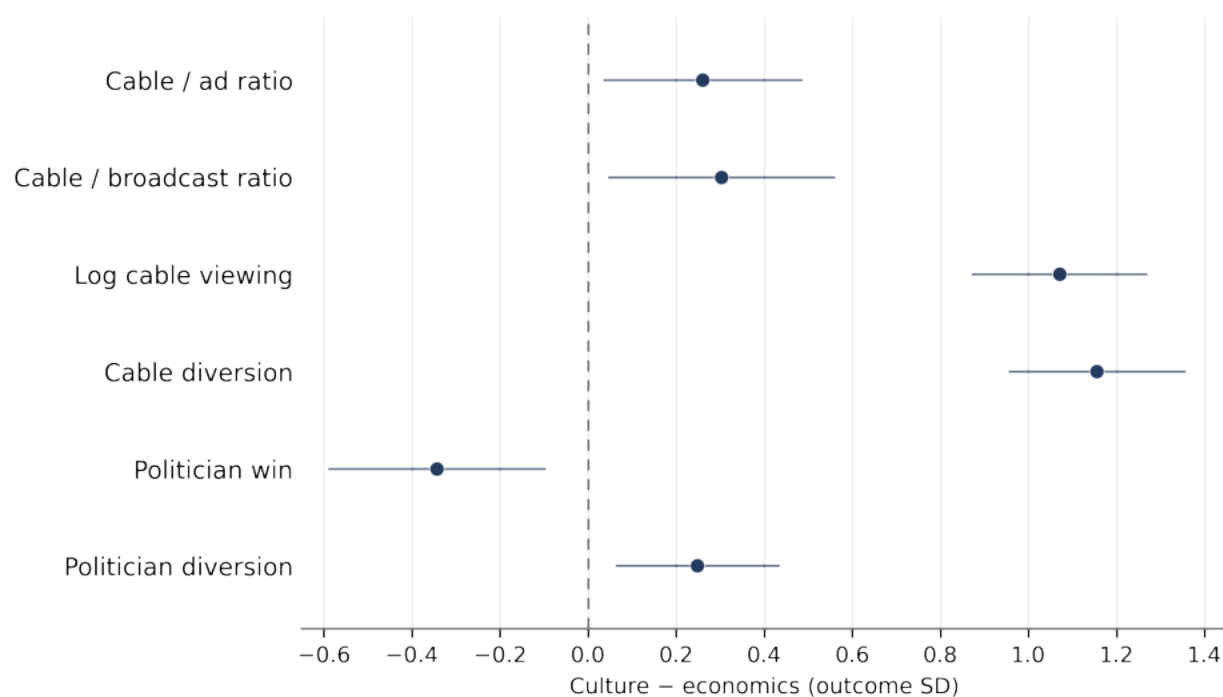
These feature-level estimates and schema classifications enable us to contrast features labeled economic with those labeled cultural. Appendix Figure E3 confirms each of the six predictions: cultural features are more represented on cable than in political ads or in broadcast news relative to economic features, and cultural features have a larger cable viewing return, are negatively correlated with political success, and have higher estimated cable and politician diversion values. All six comparisons are significant at the $p < 0.05$ level.

E.4 Schema-free feature associations

Our final exercise investigates whether the central predictions about different agents’ incentives to poach vs. mobilize extend beyond economics vs. culture. In particular, we examine whether features with higher estimated diversion (that is, relatively more effective at mobilization than poaching) are, as predicted, more prevalent in cable news than in broadcast news or in political advertising, and whether they are correspondingly more effective. For each of the 6,950 features, we relate its standardized cable diversion estimate to five standardized feature-level outcomes: its prevalence on cable relative to broadcast news, its prevalence on cable relative to political advertising, its cable viewing return, its association with electoral victory, and its candidate-side diversion.

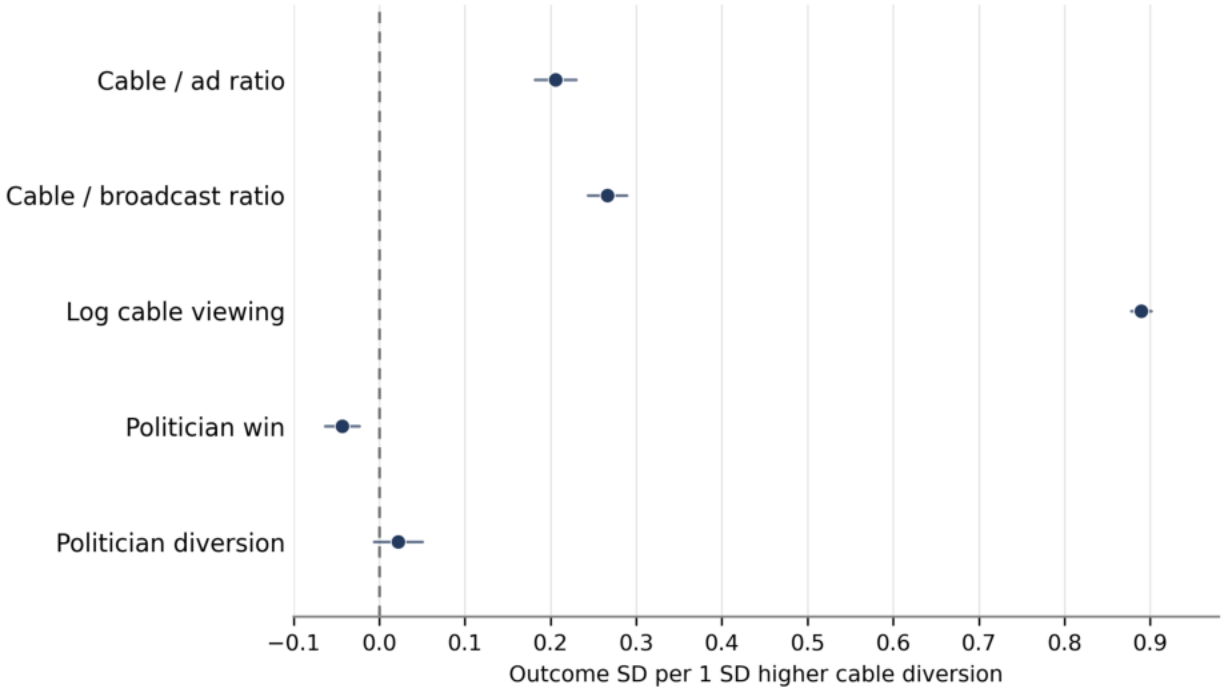
Appendix Figure E4 shows that features with higher diversion are more represented in cable news than in broadcast news or in political ads, show higher viewership returns, and show lower electoral returns. All comparisons are significant at the $p < 0.05$ level. However, we do not replicate the relationship between diversion in news and diversion in political campaigns.

Appendix Figure E3: Replication of prevalence, performance, and diversion differences between economics and culture using SAE features



Notes: Each point is the relative cultural contrast among the 285 SAE features assigned an economic or cultural label. We weight features by the sum of their total prevalences in cable news, broadcast news, and political ads. We display 95 percent confidence intervals.

Appendix Figure E4: Schema-free SAE feature associations



Notes: Each point is the coefficient from a feature-level regression of the indicated (standardized) outcome on (standardized) cable diversion. We display 95 percent confidence intervals.

E.5 Register and linguistic complexity of economic vs. cultural content

This subsection measures the emotional register and linguistic complexity of news segments and political ads, investigates whether these features correlate with economic or cultural classification, and examines to what extent they account for the measured differences between cultural and economic topics. We score the transcript of every news segment and every political ad using the NRC-VAD lexicon (Mohammad, 2018, 2025), which assigns each English word a valence (negative to positive) and arousal (calm to activated) rating in $[-1, 1]$. A segment or ad's score is the mean over its matched tokens; we exclude texts with fewer than five matched tokens. We also compute the Flesch–Kincaid grade level, with higher values indicating more linguistically complex text (Flesch, 1948; Kincaid et al., 1975). We standardize all measures to mean zero and unit variance. Appendix Table E1 reports how each measure covaries with relative cultural content in cable news, broadcast news, and political advertising, and Appendix Table E2 re-estimates the cable viewership and diversion specifications of Figures 4 and 5 and the electoral specification of Table 1 adding the three measures and their interactions with relative cultural content.

Appendix Table E1: Register and linguistic complexity of cultural and economic content

	<i>DV: relative cultural content</i>			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
<i>Panel A: Cable news segments</i>				
Arousal (z)	0.06*** (0.003)	—	—	0.04*** (0.003)
Valence (z)	—	-0.10*** (0.006)	—	-0.10*** (0.007)
Flesch–Kincaid grade (z)	—	—	-0.03*** (0.010)	-0.06*** (0.010)
Observations	1,721,294	1,721,294	1,721,294	1,721,294
<i>Panel B: Broadcast news segments</i>				
Arousal (z)	0.12*** (0.011)	—	—	0.09*** (0.008)
Valence (z)	—	-0.14*** (0.012)	—	-0.12*** (0.018)
Flesch–Kincaid grade (z)	—	—	-0.02 (0.040)	-0.07* (0.038)
Observations	134,609	134,609	134,609	134,609
<i>Panel C: Political advertisements</i>				
Arousal (z)	0.13*** (0.007)	—	—	0.10*** (0.007)
Valence (z)	—	-0.12*** (0.006)	—	-0.10*** (0.005)
Flesch–Kincaid grade (z)	—	—	-0.01** (0.006)	-0.01 (0.006)
Observations	26,815	26,815	26,815	26,815

Notes: The dependent variable is relative cultural content: the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content (in $[-1, 1]$); observations with a zero denominator are excluded. Register measures are NRC-VAD arousal and valence; textual complexity is Flesch–Kincaid grade, computed from words per sentence and syllables per word. All measures are z-scored within panel. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

Appendix Table E2: Register, linguistic complexity, content, and audience and electoral responses

	(1) Arousal	(2) Valence	(3) F–K grade	(4) All three
<i>Panel A: Cable news — log(seconds viewed)</i>				
Relative cultural content	0.011*** (0.0020)	0.010*** (0.0019)	0.012*** (0.0020)	0.010*** (0.0020)
Arousal (z)	0.001*** (0.0005)	—	—	0.001 (0.0005)
Valence (z)	—	-0.003*** (0.0005)	—	-0.002*** (0.0005)
Flesch–Kincaid grade (z)	—	—	0.006*** (0.0009)	0.006*** (0.0008)
Content × arousal	-0.001 (0.0011)	—	—	-0.003*** (0.0011)
Content × valence	—	-0.004*** (0.0013)	—	-0.005*** (0.0014)
Content × F–K grade	—	—	0.003* (0.0016)	0.002 (0.0016)
Observations	443,694	443,694	443,694	443,694
<i>Panel B: Cable news — diversion toward rival news (p.p.)</i>				
Relative cultural content	0.43*** (0.044)	0.38*** (0.042)	0.48*** (0.043)	0.40*** (0.043)
Arousal (z)	0.03** (0.013)	—	—	0.01 (0.014)
Valence (z)	—	-0.11*** (0.014)	—	-0.10*** (0.014)
Flesch–Kincaid grade (z)	—	—	0.07*** (0.018)	0.05*** (0.018)
Content × arousal	-0.03 (0.027)	—	—	-0.12*** (0.028)
Content × valence	—	-0.13*** (0.030)	—	-0.14*** (0.032)
Content × F–K grade	—	—	0.18*** (0.041)	0.15*** (0.038)
Observations	443,694	443,694	443,694	443,694

Appendix Table E2: Register, linguistic complexity, content, and audience and electoral responses (continued)

	(1) Arousal	(2) Valence	(3) F–K grade	(4) All three
<i>Panel C: Candidates — won election</i>				
Relative cultural content	-0.03*** (0.010)	-0.02** (0.010)	-0.03*** (0.010)	-0.03*** (0.010)
Arousal (z)	0.02 (0.011)	—	—	0.02** (0.011)
Valence (z)	—	0.02** (0.011)	—	0.03** (0.011)
Flesch–Kincaid grade (z)	—	—	0.01 (0.011)	0.01 (0.011)
Content × arousal	-0.01 (0.008)	—	—	-0.00 (0.008)
Content × valence	—	0.00 (0.007)	—	0.00 (0.008)
Content × F–K grade	—	—	-0.00 (0.008)	-0.00 (0.008)
Observations	4,029	4,029	4,029	4,029

Notes: Content is relative cultural content: the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed content; observations with a zero denominator are excluded. The measures are NRC-VAD arousal and valence and Flesch–Kincaid grade, z-scored within the estimation sample (within office for politicians). Candidate content and the register measures are standardized within office; the measures are also interacted with incumbency and logged airings. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

F Social Media and Digital Advertising

F.1 Data and classification

Despite some transparency efforts by major platforms, data on social media and digital advertising are not widely available and remain difficult to access. After its purchase by Elon Musk, Twitter also restricted access to historical Tweets. For our supplementary analysis of digital and social media, we use two data sources:

1. Comprehensive advertising on Google (including YouTube video ads, banner ads, and sponsored search ads) and Meta (including Facebook and Instagram ads) for all candidates in 2022, made available by Zhang et al. (2025)
2. The Twitter posts of all House and Senate incumbents between 2008 and 2017, which we scraped directly.

We classify the content of all advertisements (using speech-to-text transcriptions for video advertisements) using the same schema and classification approach described in Section 2.1.

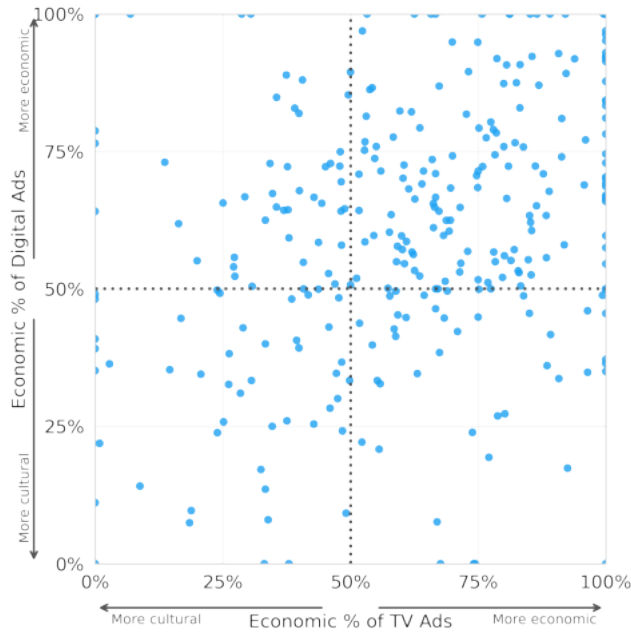
F.2 Results

We present results for 2022 advertising in Appendix Figure F1. Panel A plots the economic share of each candidate’s television advertising against the economic share of that candidate’s digital advertising, where the denominator for both shares is the total share of economic or cultural advertising. Panel B plots the parent-level category shares (restricting to candidates who ran at least one TV ad and at least one digital ad to facilitate comparability). Candidates’ issue focus in TV ads is correlated with their issue focus in digital ads and social media posts, and the overall issue emphases of digital and television advertising are extremely similar. In particular, while the share of cultural advertising in both TV and digital ads in 2022 is substantially higher than the share of cultural advertising on TV before 2022 (as also documented in Figure 1), the cultural share remains lower than the economic share.

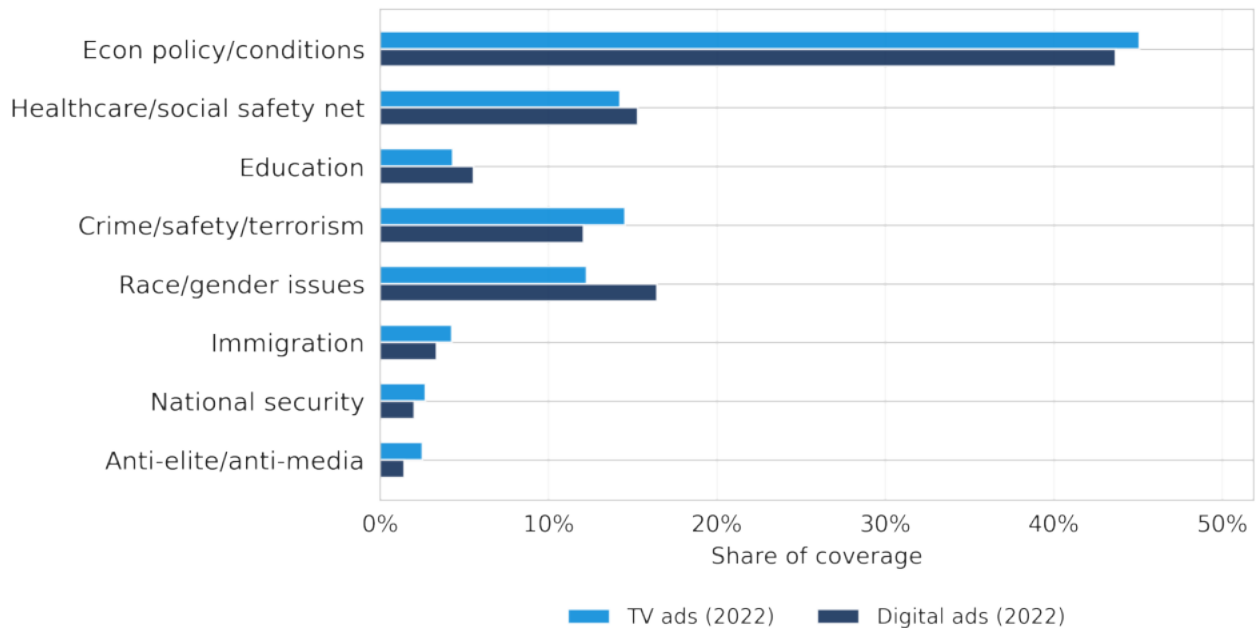
Appendix Figure F2 shows that the same broad patterns are true of candidates’ Twitter posts. Although Twitter posts emphasize cultural topics significantly more than do television ads, economic topics still comprise the majority of candidate Twitter content.

Appendix Figure F1: Content of television vs. digital ads, 2022

(a) Economic content as share of economic + cultural content

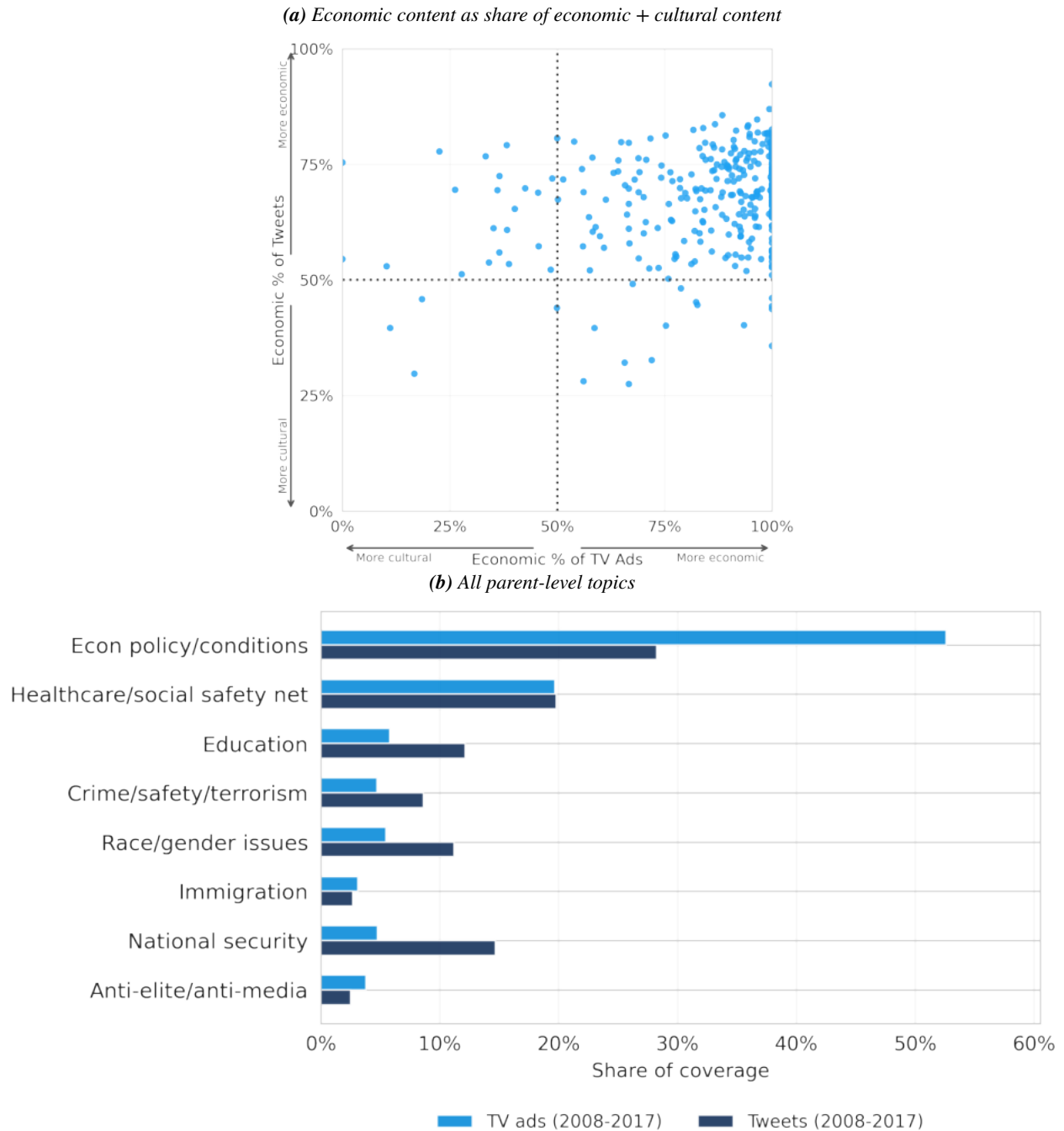


(b) All parent-level topics



Notes: Panel A plots the economic share of each candidate's television advertising against the economic share of that candidate's digital advertising (on Instagram, Facebook, YouTube, and Google), where the denominator is total economic or cultural content. Panel B plots parent-level category shares (restricting to candidates who ran at least one TV ad and at least one digital ad to facilitate comparability).

Appendix Figure F2: Content of television ads vs. Twitter posts, 2008–2017



Notes: Panel A plots the economic share of each candidate’s television advertising against the economic share of that candidate’s Tweets, where the denominator is total economic or cultural content. Panel B plots parent-level category shares (restricting to candidates who ran at least one TV ad and who posted at least one Tweet to facilitate comparability).

G Conceptual Framework

In this appendix, we generalize the conceptual framework of Section 5.1 to allow for an arbitrary number of topics, corner solutions, and a third flow, *countermobilization*, by which one supplier's content mobilizes consumers who would otherwise abstain into choosing its rival. Cable outlets, broadcast outlets, and political campaigns solve the same problem, but place different weights ω on the rival's audience (different *objectives*) and the masses $\mathcal{M}$, $\mathcal{P}$, and $\mathcal{N}$ of mobilizable, poachable, and countermobilizable consumers (different *audiences*).

G.1 Setup

A supplier i chooses a content allocation $x = (x_1, \dots, x_J)$ with $x_j \geq 0$ and $\sum_j x_j = 1$. We model the marginal consumers as three disjoint pools, each defined by a pairwise choice margin: a mass $\mathcal{M}$ of *mobilizable* consumers, choosing between i and the outside option; a mass $\mathcal{P}$ of *poachable* consumers, choosing between i and the rival $-i$; and a mass $\mathcal{N}$ of *countermobilizable* consumers, choosing between the rival and the outside option. The content chosen by the supplier determines the fraction of each pool choosing each option:

$$m(x) = \sum_j m_j(x_j), \quad p(x) = \sum_j p_j(x_j), \quad r(x) = \sum_j r_j(x_j),$$

where m is the fraction of $\mathcal{M}$ that i wins, p the fraction of $\mathcal{P}$ that i wins, and r the fraction of $\mathcal{N}$ that $-i$ wins.

Writing $\bar{V}_i$, $\bar{V}_{-i}$, and $\bar{V}_0$ for the inelastic parts of each audience that do not respond to i 's content, we can express the total number choosing each option as:

$$\begin{aligned} V_i &= \bar{V}_i + \mathcal{M} m(x) + \mathcal{P} p(x), & V_{-i} &= \bar{V}_{-i} + \mathcal{P} [1 - p(x)] + \mathcal{N} r(x), \\ V_0 &= \bar{V}_0 + \mathcal{M} [1 - m(x)] + \mathcal{N} [1 - r(x)]. \end{aligned}$$

The supplier maximizes

$$\Pi(x) = V_i(x) - \omega V_{-i}(x) - c(x), \quad c(x) = \sum_j c_j(x_j), \quad (14)$$

where $\omega \geq 0$ is the weight on the rival's audience and each c_j is a topic-specific cost capturing production, editorial, or reputational considerations. Substituting the audience definitions into Equation (14),

$$\Pi(x) = \text{constant} + \sum_j f_j(x_j), \quad f_j(z) \equiv \mathcal{M} m_j(z) + (1 + \omega) \mathcal{P} p_j(z) - \omega \mathcal{N} r_j(z) - c_j(z), \quad (15)$$

so the marginal payoff of topic j is

$$B_j(x_j) \equiv f'_j(x_j) = \mathcal{M} m'_j + (1 + \omega) \mathcal{P} p'_j - \omega \mathcal{N} r'_j - c'_j(x_j). \quad (16)$$

The first two flow terms correspond to the switching outcomes measured in Section 4.4: $\mathcal{M} m'_j$ to the flow between i and the outside option, and $\mathcal{P} p'_j$ to the flow between i and the rival.

Letting λ denote the multiplier on the budget constraint, the Kuhn–Tucker conditions are

$$B_j(x_j^*) = \lambda \quad \text{if } x_j^* > 0, \quad B_j(0) \leq \lambda \quad \text{if } x_j^* = 0. \quad (17)$$

G.2 Assumptions

- A1. $\mathcal{M}, \mathcal{P}, \mathcal{N} \geq 0$, and $m(x), p(x), r(x) \in [0, 1]$ at every x in the simplex.
- A2. Each m_j , p_j , and r_j is affine and each c_j is twice continuously differentiable.
- A3. Each c_j is strictly convex, so that

$$\Gamma_j \equiv B'_j(x_j) = -c''_j(x_j) < 0 \quad \text{for every } j \text{ and every } x_j \in [0, 1].$$

We add an additional assumption here for exposition, but relax it in Section G.5:

- A4. All topics are used at the optimum: $x_j^* > 0$ for all j .

These assumptions imply that Π is strictly concave on the simplex, the optimum x^* is unique, and the Kuhn–Tucker conditions (17) are both necessary and sufficient.

G.3 Two-topic special case

The framework of Section 5.1 is the case $J = 2$ with no countermobilization ($\mathcal{N} = 0$). Label the two topics cultural ($j = 1$) and economic ($j = 2$), write $x \equiv x_1$, and substitute the budget constraint $x_2 = 1 - x$. Then the expressions

$$m(x) \equiv m_1(x) + m_2(1 - x), \quad p(x) \equiv p_1(x) + p_2(1 - x), \quad c(x) \equiv c_1(x) + c_2(1 - x)$$

are the objects of the main text and their derivatives are their comparative advantages: $m' = m'_1 - m'_2$ is the mobilization advantage of cultural over economic content and $p' = p'_1 - p'_2$ the corresponding poaching advantage.

Subtracting the first-order condition (17) for $j = 2$ from that for $j = 1$ eliminates λ and yields the main-text condition, Equation (3): $\mathcal{M}m' + (1 + \omega)\mathcal{P}p' = c'(x^*)$. With countermobilization, the same substitution defines $r' \equiv r'_1 - r'_2$, and the condition becomes

$$\mathcal{M}m' + (1 + \omega)\mathcal{P}p' - \omega\mathcal{N}r' = c'(x^*). \quad (18)$$

G.4 Comparative statics

Let t denote a parameter (for the purpose of comparative statics) and define topic j 's t -sensitivity as the response of its objective to that parameter:

$$\sigma_j^t \equiv \frac{\partial B_j}{\partial t}; \quad \sigma_j^\omega = \mathcal{P}p'_j - \mathcal{N}r'_j, \quad \sigma_j^{\mathcal{M}} = m'_j, \quad \sigma_j^{\mathcal{P}} = (1 + \omega)p'_j, \quad \sigma_j^{\mathcal{N}} = -\omega r'_j. \quad (19)$$

σ_j^ω is topic j 's *share-sensitivity*: raising the weight on the rival rewards topics that poach and penalizes topics that countermobilize. The remaining three are topic j 's *mobilization*-, *poaching*-, and *countermobilization*-

effectiveness, valued at 1, $1 + \omega$, and $-\omega$ respectively. Define the inverse-curvature weights and the inverse-curvature-weighted average sensitivity

$$q_j \equiv \frac{1}{-\Gamma_j} = \frac{1}{c_j''(x_j^*)} > 0, \quad w_j \equiv \frac{q_j}{\sum_{\ell} q_{\ell}}, \quad \bar{\sigma}^t \equiv \sum_{\ell} w_{\ell} \sigma_{\ell}^t,$$

all evaluated at the optimum $x^*(t)$. Flatter topics (whose costs are least convex and which therefore are most reallocated) carry the largest weight.

Proposition 1. *Under A1–A4, for each topic j and each parameter t :*

$$\frac{dx_j^*}{dt} = \frac{\bar{\sigma}^t - \sigma_j^t}{\Gamma_j}, \quad \text{so} \quad \text{sign}\left(\frac{dx_j^*}{dt}\right) = \text{sign}(\sigma_j^t - \bar{\sigma}^t). \quad (20)$$

That is, an increase in t reallocates content toward topics whose t -sensitivity exceeds the inverse-curvature-weighted average and away from topics below it.

Proof. Totally differentiate the first-order conditions with respect to the parameter t : $\Gamma_j dx_j - d\lambda + \sigma_j^t dt = 0$, so $dx_j = (d\lambda - \sigma_j^t dt)/\Gamma_j$. Summing over topics j and substituting $\sum_j dx_j = 0$ gives

$$d\lambda \sum_j \frac{1}{\Gamma_j} = dt \sum_j \frac{\sigma_j^t}{\Gamma_j} \implies d\lambda = \bar{\sigma}^t dt,$$

since $\bar{\sigma}^t = (\sum_j \sigma_j^t / \Gamma_j) / (\sum_j 1 / \Gamma_j)$. Substituting back yields Equation (20). The sign statement follows from $\Gamma_j < 0$. $\square$

Corollary 1 (Objectives). *An increase in the weight on the rival, ω , reallocates content toward topics with above-average share-sensitivity $\sigma_j^{\omega} = \mathcal{P}p'_j - Nr'_j$. In the two-topic case, $dx^*/d\omega = -[\mathcal{P}p' - Nr']/\Gamma < 0$ whenever*

$$\mathcal{P}p' < Nr'.$$

Under $p' < 0$ this holds for any $r' \geq 0$: culture's poaching and countermobilization disadvantages push in the same direction. It fails only if $r' < 0$ and culture's suppression of the rival's base outweighs its poaching disadvantage, $N|r'| > \mathcal{P}|p'|$. Culture keeps a positive share whenever $\mathcal{M}m' + (1 + \omega)\mathcal{P}p' - \omega Nr' > c'(0)$. Because A2 makes σ^{ω} independent of x and ω , x^ is monotone in ω , so ranking suppliers requires only $\omega^{\text{outlet}} < \omega^{\text{candidate}}$, not pure size or pure margin maximization.*

Corollary 2 (Audience composition). *Fix the total mass on the supplier's own two margins at $T = \mathcal{M} + \mathcal{P}$ and let $s \in [0, 1]$ be the mobilizable share, $\mathcal{M} = Ts$ and $\mathcal{P} = T(1 - s)$. Then $\sigma_j^s = T[m'_j - (1 + \omega)p'_j]$, and an increase in s reallocates content toward topics with above-average $m'_j - (1 + \omega)p'_j$. In the two-topic case,*

$$\frac{dx^*}{ds} = -\frac{T[m' - (1 + \omega)p']}{\Gamma} > 0$$

given $m' > 0 > p'$.

G.5 Corner solutions

We now relax assumption A4 to allow for corner solutions. Let $\mathcal{A} \equiv \{j : x_j^* > 0\}$ denote the active set, and extend the notation of Section G.4 to an arbitrary set of topics $\mathcal{S}$:

$$Q_{\mathcal{S}} \equiv \sum_{j \in \mathcal{S}} q_j, \quad \bar{\sigma}_{\mathcal{S}}^t \equiv \frac{1}{Q_{\mathcal{S}}} \sum_{\ell \in \mathcal{S}} q_{\ell} \sigma_{\ell}^t.$$

Under assumption A2, each sensitivity σ_j^t in Equation (19) is a constant: m_j , p_j , and r_j are affine, so only the cost term $c'_j(x_j)$ in Equation (16) varies with x_j . Let $x^{\mathcal{S}}(t)$, with multiplier $\lambda^{\mathcal{S}}(t)$, denote the solution to the problem restricted to $\mathcal{S}$: that is, with $x_j = 0$ imposed for $j \notin \mathcal{S}$. By assumption A3 the restricted problem is strictly concave, so $x^{\mathcal{S}}$ is unique, and where it is interior to the $\mathcal{S}$ -simplex it is continuously differentiable in t .

Claim 1. *Under A1–A3, fix a parameter t and a value t_0 , and let $\mathcal{A}$ be the active set at t_0 .*

1. *Near t_0 , $d\lambda^{\mathcal{A}}/dt = \bar{\sigma}_{\mathcal{A}}^t$ and $dx_j^{\mathcal{A}}/dt = (\bar{\sigma}_{\mathcal{A}}^t - \sigma_j^t)/\Gamma_j = q_j(\sigma_j^t - \bar{\sigma}_{\mathcal{A}}^t)$ for every $j \in \mathcal{A}$. This is the global optimum while $B_k(0) \leq \lambda^{\mathcal{A}}$ for every $k \notin \mathcal{A}$. If every excluded topic is strictly slack at t_0 , then the active set is constant in a neighborhood of t_0 , so Proposition 1 applies (with all sums restricted to the active set $\mathcal{A}$).*
2. *Suppose instead that exactly one excluded topic k is on the margin of inclusion, $B_k(0) = \lambda$, and every other excluded topic is strictly slack. Let $d_k \equiv \sigma_k^t - \bar{\sigma}_{\mathcal{A}}^t$, so that the exclusion gap satisfies $d[\lambda^{\mathcal{A}} - B_k(0)]/dt = -d_k$. As t rises:*
 - (a) *if $d_k < 0$, topic k remains excluded and part 1 applies;*
 - (b) *if $d_k > 0$, topic k enters strictly, with right-hand derivative*

$$\left. \frac{dx_k^*}{dt} \right|_+ = \frac{q_k Q_{\mathcal{A}}}{Q_{\mathcal{A}} + q_k} d_k = \underbrace{q_k d_k}_{\text{interior rate}} \times \underbrace{\frac{Q_{\mathcal{A}}}{Q_{\mathcal{A}} + q_k}}_{\in (0,1)} > 0;$$

- (c) *if $d_k = 0$, entry depends on higher-order terms.*

Proof. On the restricted problem the argument of Proposition 1 applies unchanged, with all sums over $\mathcal{A}$ and $\sum_{j \in \mathcal{A}} dx_j = 0$; this gives both derivatives. Since Π is strictly concave, the Kuhn–Tucker conditions (17) are necessary and sufficient for the global optimum, and $x^{\mathcal{A}}$ satisfies them by construction.

Now, consider the possibility of a topic entering the active set. We have $d[\lambda^{\mathcal{A}} - B_k(0)]/dt = \bar{\sigma}_{\mathcal{A}}^t - \sigma_k^t = -d_k$. If $d_k < 0$ the gap strictly widens, so part 1 applies. If $d_k > 0$, the gap turns negative, so for t just above t_0 the $\mathcal{A}$ -solution violates the Kuhn–Tucker inequality for k . Since the optimum is unique by strict concavity, it must have $x_k^* > 0$. All topics in $\mathcal{A}$ remain strictly positive (by continuity) and the remaining excluded topics remain strictly slack, so the active set is now $\mathcal{A}' = \mathcal{A} \cup \{k\}$. Part 1 applied to $\mathcal{A}'$ then gives $dx_k^*/dt = q_k(\sigma_k^t - \bar{\sigma}_{\mathcal{A}'}^t)$, and since $\bar{\sigma}_{\mathcal{A}'}^t = (Q_{\mathcal{A}} \bar{\sigma}_{\mathcal{A}}^t + q_k \sigma_k^t) / (Q_{\mathcal{A}} + q_k)$,

$$\sigma_k^t - \bar{\sigma}_{\mathcal{A}'}^t = \frac{Q_{\mathcal{A}}}{Q_{\mathcal{A}} + q_k} d_k > 0.$$

Letting t approach t_0 from above establishes the right-hand derivative at t_0 . □

H Structural Model

This appendix provides additional details on the structural model presented in Section 5.4. Because we do not use this model for welfare calculations, our approach is to flexibly control for most determinants of household choices via fixed effects. This approach allows us to focus on modeling only the aspects of behavior relevant for the counterfactual simulations.

H.1 Demand estimation

Demand estimation proceeds in two steps. In Step 1, we flexibly estimate baseline viewing probabilities at observed content — which households are watching what in each timeslot, and which are at risk of moving to each destination. In Step 2, we estimate the distribution of content tastes β_i , which governs how strongly each of those households responds when content changes.

Information Households currently watching a network respond to its realized content, and all other households respond to its expected content. Let $\mathcal{I}_{im}$ denote all information relevant to a household’s prediction of the content on network d during time m , including household i ’s viewing state at the start of timeslot m , the alternatives available in the timeslot, and any predictable patterns in content. Given the household’s information $\mathcal{I}_{im}$, we implement its (rational) expectation of the content on network d during time m , q_{dm} , as a cross-fitted prediction of realized content on network-by-date, show-by-timeslot-by-month, and show-by-timeslot-by-day-of-week effects. We take each observation’s prediction from a fit that excludes its own fold, so that an idiosyncratic content realization is never used as both realized and expected content.

The identifying assumption — that these fixed effects are sufficient to control for all of the household’s information about content — is testable. In the annual estimations of Step 1 below, we relax the assumption by allowing perceived content for a household not watching network d to be $q_{dm} + \lambda (r_{dm} - q_{dm})$, so that $\lambda = 0$ is Equation 7 and $\lambda = 1$ gives every household full awareness of realized content. We then estimate λ freely and find that it is close to zero in each year, with a maximum estimated value of 0.11. We therefore impose $\lambda = 0$ — the information structure of the main text — in the estimation and in every counterfactual.

Step 1: baseline viewing probabilities The baseline objects to estimate are the probabilities that household i , entering a minute of timeslot m in viewing state o , chooses option d at observed content (Equation 8), with content perceived as in Equation 7. We specify the non-content utility components as:

$$a_{imod} = \alpha_{id} + \mu_m + \mu_{md} + \eta_i A_m + \kappa \mathbf{1}\{d = o\}, \quad (21)$$

where α_{id} is household i ’s attachment to option d , capturing for example one household’s loyalty to Fox News and another’s taste for entertainment television; μ_m is a timeslot index common to every watching option, capturing the overall appeal of watching television in that timeslot; μ_{md} is a timeslot index for each news option, capturing the appeal of news and of each newscast’s schedule position; A_m is the timeslot’s recurring broadcast availability and η_i is a household viewing-propensity summary, so that heavier viewers can be differentially likely to have the television on in timeslots when broadcast newscasts air; and κ is a premium on remaining in the current state o , capturing inertia in channel switching. We normalize the utility of not watching television to zero, and options unavailable in timeslot m are excluded from the choice set.

We estimate the model separately by year, by maximum likelihood on the household viewing panel. Because utility depends on content, each annual estimation recovers not only the year’s non-content components constituting a_{imod} , but also a content taste for each household, the preliminary estimate of β_i . These per-household preliminary estimates are summary statistics that enter the prediction of their actual content taste.

In this step, content tastes β_i are nuisance parameters. We therefore give β_i a deliberately flexible functional form, constructing it as a linear index over a constant and household viewership summaries: the household’s preliminary content slope from the annual first stage; the share of its television time falling in timeslots when broadcast newscasts are widely available (the summary that, scaled by its estimated coefficient, forms η_i in Equation 21); its attachment to news relative to entertainment, to broadcast newscasts relative to cable news, and to CNN and to MSNBC relative to Fox News; its log viewing time of news relative to non-news television and of broadcast newscasts relative to cable news; indicators for the bottom and top thirds of the preliminary content slope and of news attachment; and indicators for cable cross-shoppers (households strongly attached to their second-choice cable news network), for households whose top two cable networks are nearly interchangeable, for the top third of broadcast attachment, and for the interactions of the two cable-competition indicators with a CNN or MSNBC first choice. All nonconstant summaries are standardized across the household panel.

We pool the five years and estimate the twenty loadings, together with the coefficient scaling the availability interaction $\eta_i A_m$, by minimum distance, evaluating the model at observed content and starting each timeslot from households’ observed viewing states.

The moments we match, summarized in Appendix Table H1, are model analogs of reduced-form estimates constructed from the same household panel using the designs of Sections 4 and 5.2: (i) six content premiums — the viewership response to relative cultural content pooled across cable networks (Figure 4) and separately for CNN, Fox News, and MSNBC, the interaction of the pooled cable premium with recurring broadcast availability (Figure 6), and the analogous premium for broadcast newscasts (Section 5.2); (ii) nine first-exit responses — the effects of content on the probabilities that a viewer of the focal cable network first switches to a rival news network, to entertainment, or to television off (Figure 5), plus, separately for each cable network, the responses of first exits to rival news and to the outside option; (iii) five time-use responses — the effects of content on the time a focal viewer subsequently spends watching rival news and the outside option, and on the total time all panel households spend watching the focal network, rival news, and the outside option (Appendix Figure B10); (iv) the observed average audiences of ABC, CBS, NBC, CNN, Fox News, and MSNBC, which pin down baseline market shares; and (v) six per-network audience responses — the effects of each cable network’s relative cultural content on the total viewership of rival news networks and of the outside option.

Step 2: the distribution of content tastes We next take the baseline viewing probabilities from Step 1 as given and estimate the key structural parameters encoding the joint distribution of content tastes with households’ positions on the poaching and mobilization margins. Because each household has the same content taste at every origin and destination, aggregate poaching and mobilization can respond differently to content only through this joint distribution: whether the households at risk of switching to rival news have systematically different tastes from those at risk of leaving news for entertainment or television off.

Appendix Table H1: Baseline observed-origin demand fit

Moment	Empirical target	Model
<i>Panel A: viewership responses to relative cultural content</i>		
Cable viewership, pooled	0.0138	0.0166
Cable viewership, CNN	0.0227	0.0213
Cable viewership, Fox News	0.0106	0.0135
Cable viewership, MSNBC	0.0207	0.0149
Broadcast-availability slope of the pooled cable response	−0.0210	−0.0215
Broadcast newscast viewership	0.0114	0.0116
<i>Panel B: first-exit responses of focal viewers</i>		
First exit to rival news, pooled	0.00287	0.00288
First exit to entertainment, pooled	−0.00521	−0.00496
First exit to television off, pooled	−0.000752	−0.000627
First exit to rival news, CNN	0.00306	0.00324
First exit to rival news, Fox News	0.000767	0.00111
First exit to rival news, MSNBC	0.00411	0.00412
First exit to the outside option, CNN	−0.00631	−0.00684
First exit to the outside option, Fox News	−0.00407	−0.00472
First exit to the outside option, MSNBC	−0.00475	−0.00514
<i>Panel C: viewing-time responses</i>		
Focal-viewer seconds on rival news	1.78	1.82
Focal-viewer seconds on the outside option	−4.13	−4.12
All-household seconds on the focal network	0.150	0.127
All-household seconds on rival news	0.129	0.197
All-household seconds on the outside option	−0.283	−0.129
<i>Panel D: average audience levels</i>		
ABC	0.00836	0.00895
CBS	0.00471	0.00501
NBC	0.0112	0.0117
CNN	0.00519	0.00544
Fox News	0.0165	0.0170
MSNBC	0.00389	0.00406
<i>Panel E: audience responses to each network's own content</i>		
Rival-news audience, CNN	0.00462	0.00259
Rival-news audience, Fox News	0.0152	0.0156
Rival-news audience, MSNBC	0.00704	0.00315
Outside-option audience, CNN	−0.000262	−0.000122
Outside-option audience, Fox News	−0.000560	−0.000250
Outside-option audience, MSNBC	−0.000492	−0.000331

Notes: The table reports the 32 moments used to estimate the baseline viewing model and their model analogs. Panels A, B, C, and E are responses to relative cultural content; Panel D are average viewing levels.

We express the household content taste as

$$\beta_i = z_i' \theta, \quad (22)$$

where the variables in z_i are predetermined summaries from the annual viewing first stage and observed viewing time, listed in Appendix Table H2.

Appendix Table H2: Household content-taste index

Variable	Coefficient
Constant	−14.356
Log viewing time of broadcast newscasts relative to cable news	−9.346
Log viewing time of news relative to non-news television	−8.599
Television time in timeslots when broadcast newscasts are available	2.306
Attachment to news relative to entertainment	2.060
Attachment to broadcast newscasts relative to cable news	13.339
Indicator for the top third of broadcast attachment	−35.985
Attachment to the second-choice cable network relative to the first	4.034
Predicted switching to rival newscasts relative to the outside option	0.276
Preliminary content taste from the viewing first stage	7.099

Notes: The table reports the ten coefficients θ of the household content-taste index $\beta_i = z_i' \theta$, estimated by minimum distance on the moments in Appendix Table H3. Attachments are household–destination fixed effects from the annual viewing first stage; viewing-time contrasts are computed from observed viewing durations; the preliminary content taste is the household’s content coefficient from the same first stage; and predicted switching to rival newscasts relative to the outside option is constructed from the household’s predicted choice overlaps. All nonconstant variables, including the indicator, are standardized across the household panel. The content coefficient is one scalar per household.

We estimate the ten coefficients θ by minimum distance: we choose θ so that the model, evaluated at the Step-1 baseline probabilities, reproduces fourteen reduced-form moments. We report the moments in Appendix Table H3. As discussed in Section 5.4, the moments correspond to the reduced-form exercises presented in the paper.

This minimum-distance problem is linear. Each moment’s model analog is a weighted sum of household responses, and with the baseline probabilities fixed each household’s response is proportional to its own $\beta_i = z_i' \theta$. Stacking the fourteen model analogs $M_\ell(\theta)$ therefore gives

$$M(\theta) = G\theta, \quad (23)$$

where row ℓ of G collects moment ℓ ’s loadings on the ten variables, computed from the baseline probabilities, and estimating θ amounts to weighted least squares of the fourteen empirical moments on G .

H.2 Supply estimation

Microfounding content costs Suppose each of the many stories network k schedules is assigned to a format — economic, cultural, or other — and that a story’s payoff is the audience value of its format, net of the format cost c_{ka} of Equation 10, plus an idiosyncratic shock. Let q_k denote the marginal audience value of relative cultural content, $\partial(V_k - \omega \sum_{j \neq k} V_j) / \partial r_k$, measured per unit of network k ’s baseline audience.

Appendix Table H3: Targeted reduced-form moments and model fit

Moment	Empirical target	Model
Diversion to rival news at first exit	0.002874	0.003747
Diversion to the outside option at first exit	−0.005947	−0.006411
Availability slope of rival-news diversion	−0.001976	−0.002028
Availability slope of outside-option diversion	0.008939	0.009460
Cultural return among mobilizable viewers	0.030640	0.037888
Cultural return among poachable viewers	−0.028174	−0.028377
Availability slope of cable’s cultural return	−0.019042	−0.018504
Observed-to-broadcast shift in cable’s cultural return	−0.007008	−0.007016
<i>Rival-news audience response, by network</i>		
CNN	0.004621	0.002419
Fox News	0.015231	0.012653
MSNBC	0.007041	0.000074
<i>Outside-option audience response, by network</i>		
CNN	−0.000262	−0.000180
Fox News	−0.000560	−0.000474
MSNBC	−0.000492	−0.000331

Notes: The table reports the fourteen moments used to estimate the household content-taste coefficients θ by minimum distance, pooled over 2015–2019. The first four rows are the first-exit responses of switching to rival news and to the outside option and the changes in those responses with recurring broadcast availability. The next four rows are the mobilizable and poachable audience returns and interactions representing how cable’s cultural audience returns change as the availability environment moves toward broadcast-news times. The final six rows are the static responses of the rival-news audience and of the outside-option audience to each cable network’s own relative cultural content. Empirical targets are the corresponding reduced-form estimates; model values are the model-implied moments at the estimated θ (10 coefficients).

A cultural story generates q_k and an economic story $-q_k$, so the Δ_k of the main text is the counterfactual change in q_k . If the shocks are i.i.d. type-I extreme value with scale τ , the share of stories assigned to each format is

$$p_{kC} \propto e^{(q_k - c_{kC})/\tau}, \quad p_{kE} \propto e^{(-q_k - c_{kE})/\tau}, \quad p_{kO} \propto e^{-c_{kO}/\tau}. \quad (24)$$

These are exactly the shares that maximize Equation 9 under the cost function of Equation 10.

Cost estimation The levels of costs at the observed mix are absorbed: Equation 24 identifies each exponent up to a common constant, so the observed shares already embed the c_{ka} together with the baseline value q_k^0 . When a counterfactual changes q_k by Δ_k , only the cultural and economic exponents move, by $\pm\Delta_k/\tau$; dividing the counterfactual shares by the observed shares cancels everything persistent and leaves Equation 11 of the main text.

The key supply-side parameter is the shock scale τ , which governs how strongly content responds to a change in the relative value of cultural vs. economic content q_k . Differentiating Equation 24 gives the local response stated in the main text, $\partial r_k / \partial q_k = (p_{kC} + p_{kE} - r_k^2) / \tau$. We estimate τ from the observed variation in Panels A and B of Figure 6: recurring broadcast availability, denoted A , shifts cable's audience return, and networks' scheduled content responds. Equating the model's local response to the ratio of the two empirical gradients identifies

$$\tau = (p_{kC}^0 + p_{kE}^0 - (r_k^0)^2) \frac{\partial q^0 / \partial A}{\partial r / \partial A} = 0.347 \times \frac{-0.018504}{-0.101877} = 0.0630. \quad (25)$$

The first factor is the derivative term evaluated at the observed format shares, averaged across the three networks. The numerator is the model-implied slope of the audience return with respect to broadcast availability; its reduced-form counterpart, -0.019042 , is a targeted moment of Step 2 that the model closely matches. The denominator is the estimated response of scheduled content to availability. We construct the observed shares p_{ka}^0 from the networks' 2015–2019 classified political content, with “other” combining process and mixed content.

H.3 Counterfactuals

Each counterfactual changes one input to the marginal audience value q_k , holding fixed household tastes, conditional choice probabilities, format costs, and curvature τ .

Counterfactual 1: cable news facing broadcast news' composition of potential viewers For the broadcast exercise, let s_{imo} be the observed probability that household i begins timeslot m in viewing state o (the origin distributions of Step 1), and let A_m be the timeslot's recurring broadcast availability. Weighting timeslots by availability gives the origin distribution facing broadcast:

$$\bar{s}_{io}^B = \frac{\sum_m A_m s_{imo}}{\sum_m A_m}. \quad (26)$$

If a state is unavailable in a receiving timeslot, its probability is assigned to television off. The exercise therefore changes who is initially at risk of being mobilized or poached. Recomputing the own-audience derivative at observed content under these origins gives the return change Δ_k^B . The counterfactual then

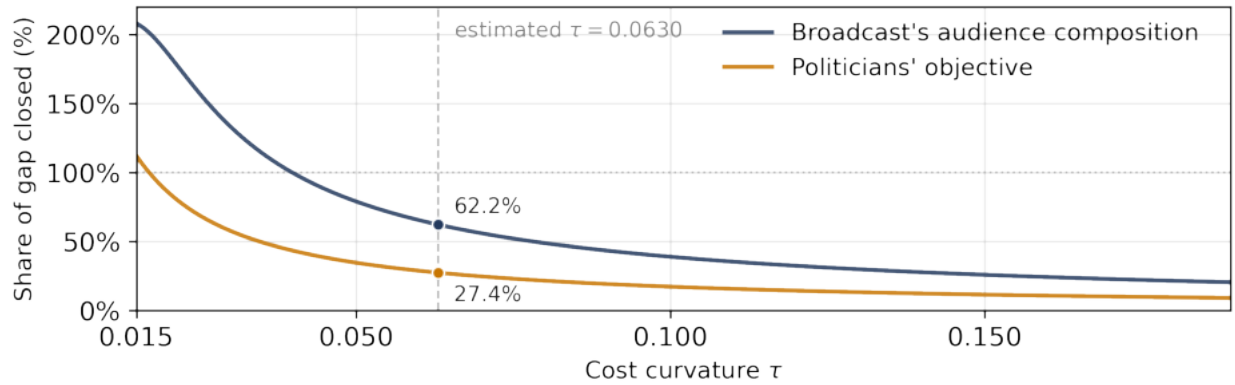
scales this response from the mean broadcast availability of 0.22 to the mean broadcast availability during the weekday 6:30pm newscast half-hours, 0.78.

Counterfactual 2: cable news facing politicians' objective function For the politician exercise, origins remain at their observed values and ω rises from zero to one in Equation 9, which changes the marginal audience value by the derivative of competing news outlets' audience:

$$\Delta_k^P = -\frac{1}{V_k^0} \frac{\partial \sum_{j \in N, j \neq k} V_j(r)}{\partial r_k} \Big|_{r=r^0}. \quad (27)$$

Because economic content is relatively effective at taking viewers from rival news, Δ_k^P is negative for all three networks: valuing poached viewers more moves content toward economics.

Appendix Figure H1: Structural counterfactuals across cost curvature values



Notes: Figure recomputes the two counterfactuals of Table 2 at alternative values of the curvature τ , holding fixed household tastes, conditional choice probabilities, format costs, and each network's return change Δ_k . Each network's counterfactual mix follows Equation 11, and each line plots the resulting share of the corresponding content gap closed. The dashed vertical line marks the estimated $\tau = 0.0630$ of Equation 25, at which the two counterfactuals match Table 2; the dotted horizontal line marks closing the full gap.

I Alternative Explanations: Twitter Adoption and the China Shock

This appendix section examines two alternative hypotheses for the rise of the salience of cultural conflict over the past several decades: social media and globalization.

I.1 Social media

Empirical approach Our analysis of the effects of social media follows Fujiwara et al. (2024), who build on Müller and Schwarz (2023) in exploiting Twitter’s promotion at the March 2007 South by Southwest (SXSW) festival. Their instrument is the log number of followers of the official SXSW account in each county who joined Twitter during March 2007; conditional on followers who joined before March 2007, the instrument predicts the county’s log number of Twitter users in 2014–2015. We exactly reproduce the authors’ first stage using the authors’ published replication package.

We apply the same design at the finest geography of each outcome. For voter priorities, measured by Gallup Most Important Problems, the unit is the county. We retain the balanced sample of counties observed in both 2000–2006 and 2016–2020 and construct the county mean of the relative cultural MIP indicator in each window. We estimate the specification

$$Y_c = \beta T_c + \gamma P_c + g'_c \phi + \eta_{r(c)} + \eta_{d(c)} + \varepsilon_c, \quad (28)$$

where Y_c is either the 2016–2020 outcome level or its change from 2000–2006 to 2016–2020; T_c is county c ’s log Twitter users, instrumented with the log number of March-2007 SXSW followers Z_c ; P_c is the log number of pre-March-2007 SXSW followers; g_c is the full baseline county covariate vector of Fujiwara et al. (2024); and $\eta_{r(c)}$ and $\eta_{d(c)}$ are Census-region and population-decile fixed effects. We report the post-period level first without and then with g_c , followed by the change specification with g_c . Following Fujiwara et al. (2024), we weight by 2000 presidential turnout and cluster standard errors by state.

For political advertising, the unit is the candidate-year, as in Table 4: major-party general-election House, Senate, and Governor candidates. Because the treatment is measured at the county level, we aggregate the treatment, instrument, and pre-SXSW control to each candidate’s constituency as population-weighted averages of the county measures. We estimate

$$Y_{it} = \beta \bar{T}_{s(i)} + \gamma \bar{P}_{s(i)} + g'_{it} \phi + \eta_{p(i) \times o(i) \times t} + \eta_{d(s(i)) \times o(i)} + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (29)$$

where Y_{it} is candidate i ’s relative cultural advertising share in election year t ; $\bar{T}_{s(i)}$ and $\bar{P}_{s(i)}$ are the constituency aggregates of log Twitter users and log pre-March-2007 SXSW followers, with $\bar{T}_{s(i)}$ instrumented by the analogously aggregated log March-2007 SXSW followers; g_{it} contains the demographic and economic control sets of Table 4, entered with the same party and incumbency interactions; $\eta_{p(i) \times o(i) \times t}$ are party-by-office-by-year fixed effects; and $\eta_{d(s(i)) \times o(i)}$ are population-decile-by-office fixed effects, following the decile convention of Fujiwara et al. (2024). We weight by constituency population and cluster standard errors by contest-cycle. We again report the 2016–2020 level, add the full baseline controls of Fujiwara et al. (2024), and then subtract local 2000–2006 candidate-ad content. For the last specification, we map historical House districts to counties using population fragments and reaggregate them to each post-period constituency; statewide baselines are pooled by state and office. We require the pre-period baseline to cover at least half of the constituency population.

Results We report results in Appendix Table I1. We find no evidence that Twitter adoption increased voters’ stated importance of cultural relative to economic issues: all three Most Important Problem estimates are small and statistically insignificant. Candidate advertising shifts significantly toward economics in the specification parallel to our channel-position design. The estimate remains negative and marginally significant after adding the full controls of Fujiwara et al. (2024), while the change from the local 2000–2006 baseline is negative but imprecise.

Appendix Table I1: Twitter adoption and cultural issue emphasis

	MIP responses			Candidate ads		
	2016–2020 level	+ Fujiwara controls	Minus 2000–2006	2016–2020 level	+ Fujiwara controls	Minus 2000–2006
Log Twitter users	0.005 (0.010)	0.004 (0.016)	-0.002 (0.031)	-0.152*** (0.055)	-0.327* (0.193)	-0.338 (0.322)
Effect of 30% more users (p.p.)	0.13	0.10	-0.06	-3.99	-8.57	-8.88
95% CI (p.p.)	[-0.40, 0.65]	[-0.77, 0.96]	[-1.71, 1.59]	[-6.83, -1.15]	[-18.50, 1.36]	[-25.48, 7.72]
Standardized effect	0.039	0.030	-0.014	-0.413	-0.888	-0.826
First-stage <i>F</i>	69.5	116.5	116.5	224.1	100.3	85.9
Geographies	2,513	2,513	2,513	526	526	437
Observations	2,513	2,513	2,513	733	733	610

Notes: Columns 1–3 use the identical set of counties observed in both 2000–2006 and 2016–2020. Column 1 uses the survey-weighted 2016–2020 relative cultural Most Important Problem response, conditioning on pre-SXSW followers and the fixed effects, weights, and state-clustered inference of Fujiwara et al. (2024). Column 2 adds the authors’ full baseline control set; Column 3 additionally subtracts the survey-weighted 2000–2006 outcome. Columns 4–6 use major-party general-election House, Senate, and Governor candidate-years from 2016–2020. House exposure is a district-population-weighted average of county log Twitter users. County mass is assigned using the existing population fragments; official Census county-district incidences restore fragments omitted by the older derived crosswalk and define court-ordered redraws. Senate and Governor exposure is the analogous state average. Column 4 uses the paper’s candidate-IV demographic and economic controls, direct Census constituency-population weights, party-by-office-by-year and population-decile-by-office fixed effects, and race-clustered standard errors. Column 5 adds the full baseline control set and Census-region fixed effects of Fujiwara et al., aggregated with the same constituency weights. Column 6 additionally subtracts local 2000–2006 candidate-ad content. Historical House districts are allocated to counties with population fragments and reaggregated to each post-period constituency; Senate and Governor baselines are pooled by state and office. The change column retains only observations for which the local baseline covers at least half of the constituency population. In all candidate columns, the outcome is relative cultural advertising: the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed advertising. In all columns, log Twitter users is instrumented with the identically aggregated log number of March-2007 SXSW followers, conditional on pre-March-2007 SXSW followers. Geographies are counties in Columns 1–3 and races in Columns 4–6. *, **, and *** indicate significance at the $p < 0.10$, $p < 0.05$, and $p < 0.01$ levels, respectively.

I.2 Globalization

Empirical approach Our analysis of the effects of globalization follows the “China shock” approach of Autor et al. (2013). The treatment is the 2000–2007 growth in Chinese import exposure per worker, built from start-of-period industry employment shares; the instrument replaces US import growth with contemporaneous Chinese import growth in eight other high-income countries, apportioned with decade-lagged employment shares. We measure voter priorities at the commuting-zone level, as the survey-weighted mean of the relative cultural MIP indicator, and advertising at the media-market level, as the airings-weighted relative cultural share of candidate advertising. We aggregate the treatment and instrument from commuting zones to media markets with 2000 county populations.

For each post-period pool beginning in 2008, 2012, and 2016 and ending in 2022, we estimate two

specifications on the same sample of locations:

$$Y_\ell = \beta x_\ell + w'_\ell \phi + \varepsilon_\ell, \quad (30)$$

where ℓ indexes commuting zones (voter priorities) or media markets (advertising); Y_ℓ is either the pooled post-period outcome level or the pooled level minus the location's 2000 outcome; x_ℓ is the growth in import exposure per worker, instrumented with the corresponding other-country exposure growth z_ℓ ; and w_ℓ contains the start-of-period manufacturing employment share, Census-division indicators, the demographic and task controls of Autor et al. (2020) — the shares of the population that are college-educated and foreign-born, the female employment share, the routine-occupation share, and the offshorability index — and the 1996 Republican two-party presidential vote share. We implement estimation and inference following Borusyak et al. (2022): we residualize Y_ℓ , x_ℓ , and z_ℓ on w_ℓ at the location level, aggregate the residuals to industries with lagged industry shares, and estimate Equation 30 equivalently at the industry-shock level, instrumenting with the industry-level shock. We weight by aggregate industry exposure, clustering standard errors by three-digit SIC industry and reporting the corresponding null-imposed 95% confidence intervals.

Appendix Table I2: China import exposure and pooled cultural issue emphasis

Post-period pool	MIP		Political ads	
	Pooled level	Minus 2000	Pooled level	Minus 2000
<i>Panel A. Coefficient estimates</i>				
2008–2022	-0.0108 (0.0032)	-0.0812 (0.0307)	0.0132 (0.0128)	0.0408 (0.0246)
2012–2022	-0.0069 (0.0045)	-0.0779 (0.0305)	0.0150 (0.0148)	0.0426 (0.0260)
2016–2022	-0.0049 (0.0049)	-0.0758 (0.0303)	0.0182 (0.0155)	0.0458 (0.0270)
<i>Panel B. Standardized effects and null-imposed 95% confidence intervals</i>				
2008–2022	-0.300 [−0.503, −0.117]	-0.260 [−0.416, 0.027]	0.141 [−0.102, 0.624]	0.241 [0.016, 0.828]
2012–2022	-0.176 [−0.444, 0.049]	-0.251 [−0.407, 0.035]	0.147 [−0.090, 0.700]	0.247 [0.024, 0.884]
2016–2022	-0.110 [−0.375, 0.102]	-0.244 [−0.399, 0.039]	0.167 [−0.060, 0.723]	0.258 [0.034, 0.904]

Notes: The MIP outcome is the cultural indicator minus the economic indicator. The political-ad outcome is relative cultural advertising: the cultural share minus the economic share, divided by cultural, economic, process, and mixed advertising. Each row pools the indicated years using survey weights for MIPs and airing counts for political ads. “Minus 2000” subtracts the location’s 2000 outcome; both columns use the same 2000-balanced sample. Panel A reports the coefficient per thousand dollars of import exposure per worker, with SIC3-clustered standard errors in parentheses. Panel B reports standardized effects, with BHJ null-imposed confidence intervals in brackets. All models include the lagged manufacturing share, Census-division indicators, ADH demographic and task controls, and the 1996 Republican presidential vote share. Effective first-stage F -statistics are 36.2–36.4 for MIPs and 134.0 for ads; samples contain 256–257 CZs and 73 DMAs. The 2000 outcome coincides with the beginning of the measured shock and is not strictly pre-treatment.

Appendix Table I2 gives different answers for pooled levels and changes from the earliest available outcome. The pooled advertising levels are small, positive, and imprecise in every period, but the changes from 2000 are larger and their null-imposed intervals exclude zero in all three pools. The MIP estimates point in the opposite direction, suggesting a shift toward greater economic relative to cultural concerns: levels are negative throughout (the 2008–2022 interval excludes zero), and the changes from 2000 are negative with intervals that narrowly include zero.